The Islamic Society of Central Jersey: Its Historical Journey

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By The ISCJ History Project Team

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Library of Congress Control Number:		2018907715
ISBN:	Hardcover	978-1-9845-3806-2
	Softcover	978-1-9845-3807-9
	eBook	978-1-9845-3808-6

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Print information available on the last page.

Rev. date: 08/29/2018

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In the name of Allah, Most Gracious, Most Merciful
All praise and thanks are Allah's, the Lord of the
'aalameen (mankind, jinn, and all that exists)
The Most Gracious, the Most Merciful The Only Owner
(and the Only Ruling Judge) of the Day of Recompense
You (Alone) we worship, and You (Alone) we
ask for help (for each and everything)
Guide us to the Straight Way
The Way of those on whom You have bestowed Your
Grace, not (the way) of those who earned Your Anger

ISCJ History Project Core Team



Shoukat Ali



Dawud Assad



Sogra Saleem, MD



Imam Hamad Chebli



Fakhruddin Ahmed, D Phil.



Arif Khan



Dawlat Chebly

Project team in front of the mihrab



From left to right: Br. Arif Khan, Sr. Sogra Saleem, Br. Dawud Assad, Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli, Br. Shoukat Ali, and Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed (Sr. Dawlat Chebly was out of town.)

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The ISCJ Founding Members

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2	A.R. Harb
3	Abdel Moneim El- Meligi
4	Abdel Rehim Riad
5	Abdul Hakim Babar
6	Abdul Rehman Chaudhry
7	Abdul Wahab
8	Abdullah Al-Sulaiman Ahmed
9	Ahmed Asad Radwan
10	Ahmed Mubarak
11	Ali Bradford Judd
12	Amena Assad
13	Anis Ahmad
14	Anis Jaferi
15	Anwar Chaudry
16	Asfia M. Quereshy
17	Asif B. Mirza
18	Athar Shamsi
19	Attiyaat El- Saady
20	Aziz Begum Karim
21	Azra Shahidi
22	Basam Kaslan
23	Bashar A. Mohammed
24	Bilal Mian
25	Dalim Sau
26	Dawud Assad
27	Fakhry M.Saymeh
28	Farida Ali
29	Feroz Safdar
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31	Ghazanfar Ali Shah
32	Ghazanfar Jaferi
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43	Imtiaz Shaikh
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45	Irfan Kayalp
46	Irfanul Huq,
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48	Khalid Malik
49	Khalil A, Shaqfeh
50	Khubaib Mansoor
51	M. Iqbal Khan
52	M. Salim Chowdhery
53	M.A. Ali Khan
54	Madiha Boraei
55	Mahmood Quereshy
56	Mahmoud Taher
57	Mahmooda Raza
58	Manzoor Hussain
59	Maqbool A. Qureshi
60	Masood Qureshi
61	Matloob Khan
62	Meher Nigar Chaudry
63	Mobina Iqbal
64	Mohamed N. El-Saady
65	Mohammad A. Chaudry
66	Mohammad Aslam Raza
67	Mohammad Zarqa
68	Mohammad.S. Huq
69	Mohammed Hanafy
70	Mohammed Nisar
71	Mohammed R. Saleem
72	Montasar Soliman
73	Zahiye Radwan

34	Hakim Irfani
35	Hana Rifai
36	Hanif Chaudry
37	Heera Ismail
38	Humaira Shamsi
39	Hussein Shehata
40	Ibrahim A. Housri

74	Muhammad Ali Chaudhry
75	Muhammad Ashraf
76	Mumtaz Babar
77	Munir Ahmad
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79	Narjis Shaikh
80	Nasreldin El- Saady

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82	Noori Nisar
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84	Omar Boraei
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88	Rabia Khan
89	Rajab A. Silsilah
90	Rana S. Khan
91	Razia Matin
92	Riaz A. Siddiqui
93	Riaz Iqbal
94	Riaz M.Ahmad
95	Riffat Chaudhry
96	Roshan Dasti
97	S. Abad Ahmad
98	S. Chaudry
99	Shaikh Moizul Matin
100	Safir Ahmad
101	Saida El- Miladi
102	Saleh Feteiha, Saleh
103	Sarfaraz Ahmad
104	Shabbir Roowala
105	Shafiq M.Chaudry

No.	ISCJ Founding Member
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107	Shehata Rasool
108	Sheikh Abdul Aziz
109	Sheikh Abdul Rahman Muminah
110	Sheikh Abdullah Huwaish
111	Sheikh Ahmed Ali Hmrani
112	Sheikh Ahmed Baghlaf
113	Sheikh Ahmed Bagido
114	Sheikh Ahmed Hussain Fithaihi
115	Sheikh Ahmed Jamjoom
116	Sheikh Ahmed Yusuf Reza
117	Sheikh Hussain Ali Reza
118	Sheikh Khalid
119	Sheikh Mohammed Askari
120	Sheikh Omar Bahassan
121	Sheikh Salem Basamah
122	Sheikh Wahabi Tihlawi
123	Shoukat Ali
124	Sogra Saleem
125	Suhail Rifai
126	Syed S. Shahidi
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128	Turfa bint Abdul Aziz
129	Waheed Sayed
130	Zuheir M. Abbassi

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	Exec. Secretary	Nazeer Ahmed	Masood Tindyala	
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	President	Abdul Hakim Babar	Riaz Iqbal	
	Vice President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Hanif Chaudhry	
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	Exec. Secretary	Ghouse Ismail	M.Ali Chaudary	
	Treasurer	Montasser Soliman	Ahmed El Saei	
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	Vice President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Hanif Chaudhry	
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	President	Abdul Hakim Babar	Riaz Iqbal	
	Vice President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Raafat Ahmad	
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	Vice President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Ahmed Azmy	
	Secretary	Shoukat Ali	Raafat Ahmad	
	Exec. Secretary	M.Ali Chaudry	Mohamed Zarka	
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	Vice President		Ahmed Azmy	Aziza Badr
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	Vice President		Ahmed Azmy	Riaz Siddiqui
	Secretary	Galal Badr	Sarfaraz Ahmad	
	Exec. Secretary	M.Ali Chaudry	Ibrahim Shaikh	
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	President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Moizul Matin	Hashem El Tayeb
	Secretary	M.Ali Chaudary	Mamdouh Fahmy	
	Exec. Secretary	Shoukat Ali	Sobhi Khalil	
	Treasurer	Ghouse Ismail	Mohamed El Saady	
1987 to 1988	Chairman	Shoukat Ali	Sobhi Khalil	Mohamed Elsaady
	President	Abdel Rehim Riad	Mamdouh Fahmy	Galal Badr
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	Exec. Secretary	Waheed Sayed	Hussain Shehata	
	Treasurer	Salah Awad	Dawud Assad	
			Roshan Dasti	
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	President	Waheed Sayed	Roshan Dasti	
	Secretary	Hussain Shehata	Atyaat Elsaady	
	Exec. Secretary	Riaz Siddiqui	Ghouse Ismail	
	Treasurer	Salah Awad	M Omar Mansour	
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	Exec. Secretary	Hussain Shehata	A Rahman	
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	Exec. Secretary	Khan Z Iqbal	Sogra Saleem	
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	Secretary	Khan Z Iqbal	Abdel H Ramadan	
	Exec. Secretary	Nadia Younes	M. Omar Mansour	
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	Treasurer	Parvaiz Malik		
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	Secretary	Riaz Siddiqui	Parvaiz Malik	Omayma Mansour
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Year	Board of Trustees			Board of Overseers
	Officers	Name	Trustees	
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2001 to 2002	Chairman	Parvaiz Malik	Hussein Shehata	Fatima Aziz (Chief)
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	Exec. Secretary	Sogra Saleem	Magdy Hagag	
	Treasurer	Abdel Moneim Said		
2002 to 2003	Chairman	Muhammad Ashraf	Hussein Shehata	Zaher Nazif (Chief)
	President	Magdy Hagag	Alan Bowman	Syed Zain Ahmed
	Secretary	Atiya Aftab	Omayma Mansour	Ghouse Ismail
	Exec. Secretary	Sogra Saleem	Tariq Masood	
	Treasurer	Abdel Moneim Said		
2003 to 2004	Chairman	Muhammad Ashraf	Hussein Shehata	Syed Zain Ahmed (Chief)
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	Secretary	Atiya Aftab	Mohommed Siddiqui	Zafar Ahmed
	Exec. Secretary	Kassem Riad	Tariq Masood	
	Treasurer	Abdel Moneim Said		
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	Secretary	Sogra Saleem	Mujibur Rehman	Durriya Asghar
	Exec. Secretary	Muhammad Ashraf	Tariq Masood	
	Treasurer	Kassem Riad		
2005 to 2006	Chairman	Alan Bowman	Hussein Shehata	Atiya Aftab (Chief)
	President	Magdy Hagag	Mohmmed Siddiqui	Dalya Yousef
	Secretary	Sogra Saleem	Mujibur Rehman	Khalid Ozair
	Exec. Secretary	Muhammad Ashraf	Basem Hassan	
	Treasurer	Kassem Riad		

Year	Board of Trustees			Board of Overseers
	Officers	Name	Trustees	
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	Exec. Secretary	Mujiur Rehman	Ross Masood	
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	Exec. Secretary	Sogra Saleem	Dalya Yousef	
	Treasurer	Abbas Shaikh		
2011 to 2012	Chairman	Muhammad Ashraf	Magdy Hagag	Rabia Saeed (Chief)
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Year	Board of Trustees			Board of Overseers
	Officers	Name	Trustees	
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	Exec. Secretary	Tufail Tahir	Junaideen Fahumy	
	Treasurer	Tabassum Khan		

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Thanks To Everyone Who Made ISCJ What It Is Today

Our special thanks go to the Pioneers/Founding Members, who made tremendous personal and financial sacrifices to get the ISCJ project off the ground during the mid-1970s. We would like to especially thank Br. Omar Boraie for identifying the 6.41 acres lot where the ISCJ stands today. Without his foresight and guidance ISCJ might not have found and acquired this strategic location. We also want to thank those founding members who stepped in later 1970s and early 1980s and continued the work of nurturing the ISCJ.

The successive ISCJ Board of Trustees and Board of Overseers deserve our gratitude for guiding the ISCJ through good and turbulent times. We thank the members of the various ISCJ Committees and Groups who contributed their expertise, time and energy in helping shape the ISCJ into an institution that fulfills the vision of the founders. The ISCJ stands today as an organization that caters to the spiritual and educational needs of the Muslim community and provides true knowledge of Islam to Muslims and people of other faiths through interfaith gatherings and conveys the message of peace and brotherhood to our neighbors and the people of America.

We would like to thank our resident and visiting Imams, scholars, speakers and judges who enlightened us, and the political leaders who educated us about our rights and civic duties, and supported us during the dark days following the September 11, 2001 event. We would like to thank local political leaders such as the former U.S. Representative Rush Holt and others who always called us to assure us of protection during such crisis times. Special Thanks to the Police department who provided round the clock protection whenever the Islamic Center was facing hostilities and vandalism.

Our special thanks go to the South Brunswick Township Mayor's Office, the Planning and Zoning Boards, and its several departments who guided us from our infancy through the approval process of the various stages of construction. Our special thanks to the late Mayor Frank Gambatese, Township Councilman Joe Camarota and Councilman Charlie Carley, former Senator Peter Inverso, his chief of Staff Steve Cook without their guidance the ISCJ would not have come along in a relatively short time to where it stands today. We would like to acknowledge the guidance provided by Senator Linda Greenstein and US Representative Bonnie Watson and gratefully remember the visits by the Governors and other state officials in critical times and at special occasions such as Ramadan and Eid festivals. We would also like to thank the South Brunswick

Health department for facilitating registrations of the marriages performed by Imam Hamad Chebli of the ISCJ.

Heartfelt thanks are due to the teachers who taught our children at the ISCJ Weekend School and the Noor-ul-Iman school over the years, educating our children, instilling Islamic values in them, and for being their role models. Scores of volunteers, who are our unsung heroes, deserve a special "thank you" for their selfless work behind the scene that usually goes unnoticed and underappreciated.

Had it not been for our perennial donors, there would be no ISCJ. Time and again the donors came through and made it possible to build the ISCJ, maintain and operate it successfully for the past forty plus years. In addition, they enabled building a permanent school building for a full-time school on the ISCJ grounds currently being operated by Noor-ul-Iman Schools Inc. under a long term lease. The ISCJ and the Noor-ul-Iman school came into being and are thriving because of the continuous care, benevolence and generosity of these donors. To these numerous donors, a big "Thank you!" May Allah reward you for your dedication, intellectual and financial contributions you made along the ISCJ's historical journey.

We would also want to acknowledge the assistance and guidance provided by the current ISCJ Administration Office especially Br. Sayed Hassan in accessing and scanning thousands of the historical records that tell the story of the ISCJ since 1975 and recently, Br. Ahmed Ali Khan and Br. Mohammad Iqbal in facilitating our day to day tasks over the past few years whereas we cannot adequately thank Br. Yehia Abu-Bakr, Br. Mamdouh Fahmy and Br. Sobhi Khalil for their administrative services rendered during the crucial formative years.

Finally, we would like to thank the ISCJ community members for providing their personal write-ups, photos and video interviews in documenting the ISCJ's historical journey.

Above all, we thank AllahuTala (God) for His Guidance and Blessings that have been evident in all of our endeavors since the very conception of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey.

Sincerely,

The ISCJ History Project Team

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Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) President's Historical Journey Statement

Br. Arif Patel, President of the ISCJ Board of Trustees

As Salaamu Alaykum, Dear Respected Members of the ISCJ Community

The endeavor to capture the ISCJ's history was a daunting undertaking. Our sincere appreciation and gratitude to the entire task force team who have worked so diligently over the past three years to bring this to fruition. It humbled me to see their relentless effort to gather, catalog, chase and assemble this historical journey of the ISCJ. May ALLAH ALMIGHTY shower His blessings on this committed task force, who worked incredibly hard to ensure your invaluable contributions were well documented. Their efforts portray ISCJ as an organization that provided a full range of quality services for our community locally, regionally, and nationally for the past 40 plus years!

As we look ahead to what is to come in next 40 years, we pray that our kids and grandkids take everything we have done, to the next level, and beyond our dreams and imagination, Insha'Allah. We are constantly looking to improve the ISCJ experience for everyone. Our commitment to excellence and service will continue, and as new families move into the area, we are dedicated to helping the new generations integrate and lead our Society.

This historical record will be something our future ISCJ generations will be able to utilize and learn from. This record will convey how we are dedicated to providing the best possible experience for our community, and how we work together for the House of Allah (SWT), the ISCJ. This project will convey how the ISCJ is a place where everyone feels welcome, why our membership continues to grow, why our youth and seniors are happy to attend the ISCJ, and why we continue to be a role model for other Masjids locally and nationally.

May Allah (SWT) guide us all to serve Him and the community with sincerity and continued devotion! Ameen!

Jazakum'Allahu Khairun. Wa' Salaamu Alaikum

The ISCJ History project was started in 2014 when Br. Arif Patel was the president of the ISCJ Board of Trustees.

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Contributions of the ISCJ History Project Team Members

Br. Shoukat Ali

I am glad to record the following specific contributions of the members of the task force:

Imam Hamad Chebli: He proposed the original idea of compiling a history of the ISCJ; he provided hundreds of local newspaper articles and photos of important events for use in the history book and information about various interfaith meetings that ISCJ was involved with.

Br. Dawud Assad: He provided crucial historic information regarding how the ISCJ came about as he was involved with the people and events leading to the birth of the ISCJ; he reconnected with the people of that era to get their ISCJ related stories although they had moved away years ago. As he was the Chairman of the Board of Trustees and the Building and Religious Committees for many years he provided valuable historical info relating to the purchase of the land and other properties, the financial and technical struggles that were faced during the acquisition of land and construction of phases. He has reviewed personal write-ups and preambles to various chapters to ensure accuracy.

Dr. Sogra Saleem: She was involved in almost every aspect of the project since our first ISCJ History Project meeting on Sept 6, 2014 at Imam Chebli's house; she went through volumes of ISCJ related newspaper articles and ISCJ Archives to extract historical documents that became part of the ISCJ History Book; she recruited volunteers to scan thousands of pages into the ISCJ computer; she "chased" down people to get them to do their write-ups, video interviews and provide their photos; she proposed adding Dr. Fakhruddin and Br. Arif Khan to the task force for editing and IT needs; which proved valuable. She was responsible for "Fact Checking" all historical dates and data. She was always there to help you and exhort you if you are falling behind on your assignments which kept us all on our toes.

Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed: He is our Editor and Adviser; after all of us have written or reviewed the write-ups and preambles he would review and edit them from literary point of view; which added a literary elegance that I am sure the readers will notice.

Br. Arif Khan: He was our IT department; he brought his computer skills to the project; he made sure that all documents are properly sized to fit 8.5X11 pages, scanned and stored on the ISCJ computer and individual members' USB drives. Consequently, almost the entire ISCJ's historical documents are now digitized and stored. These can be accessed by subject and date using links. Without his expertise, the history book articles would not be electronically accessible.

Sr. Dawlat Chebly: She brought her expertise in video recording to the project; this allowed us to capture the faces and voices of many of the founders, pioneers and others who were involved during the first forty years of the ISCJ; because of her involvement with the project these faces and voices will be preserved, seen and heard by many generations.

In addition, Sr. Amira Feknous, Sr. Hajira Farooqi, Sr. Samira Bajighar and Sr. Sarah Ahmed worked as hired volunteers to help with the project; they did a splendid job of scanning thousands of documents and photographs. So, anyone interested in reading any historic document in its original format can do so by accessing these documents via access links.

I consider myself very fortunate to have had the help of the highly motivated and talented task force members and volunteers noted above who brought their unique skills to the project and did all the heavy lifting making my job of organizing and managing the project rather easy. May Allah reward them for their dedication and hundreds of hours of their labor of love for documenting the history of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey for the current and future generations.

Sincerely, Shoukat Ali Chairman,

The ISCJ History Project Team

A Note from the History Project Team Members

Suffice to say, the ISCJ historical journey project would not have seen the light of day without the dedication, tenacity, and leadership of Br. Shoukat Ali, the editor. He was enthusiastic about the project from day 1, recruited a team of task force members with diverse background and expertise, guided them, and made them work cohesively.

He reached out to the ISCJ community, solicited their assistance, issued guidance regarding what to include in personal write-ups about a member's association with the ISCJ, and requested them to furnish old photographs that pertained to the ISCJ's history.

He held biweekly and weekly meetings with the task force members to monitor the progress of the project, took advice from all, and kept meticulous notes of the meetings. He alone did all the correspondence with the board of trustees, project team members, and the ISCJ community at large. He read every e-mail/mail, write-up, and preamble and made comments and corrections before sending those for editing.

Brother Shoukat managed to do all this while retaining a full-time job that required frequent travel. For the hundreds of hours that he spent on the project over the last three years, on behalf of the ISCJ, the project team members would like to profusely thank Br. Shoukat Ali and Sr. Farida Ali, both of whom founding members of the ISCJ, who were very active in its formative years.

It was a privilege to work with him on this historic book. May Allah bless Br. Shoukat Ali, Sr. Farida Ali, and their family.

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Preamble: The ISCJ History Project

Br. Shoukat Ali

The idea of the ISCJ history project was proposed by Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli during a general assembly meeting in June 2014. So that the history of the ISCJ is not lost with the passage of time, he suggested that we should compile a history of the ISCJ for the record and for the benefit of the current and future generations as the generation of Muslims who conceived and established the ISCJ is retiring and passing the baton to the next generation.

The Imam suggested that the project be undertaken by Br. Shoukat Ali and Br. Dawud Assad as they have been involved with the ISCJ since its inception and have firsthand knowledge of how the ISCJ was conceived and started in the mid-1970s.

The proposal was presented to the board of trustees in the fall of 2014, along with a work plan, mission statement, and a not-to-exceed-budget request for $20,000. In November 2014, the ISCJ Board of Trustees approved the project, and the president of the ISCJ, Br. Arif Patel, established the ISCJ History Project Task Force and appointed the following members: Br. Shoukat Ali (chairman), Br. Dawud Assad, Sr. Sogra Saleem, and Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli. Subsequently, Br. Arif Khan, Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed and Sr. Dawlat Chebly were invited to join the task force to bring their special talents and skills to the project.

The project's mission was to compile an authentic, comprehensive, and accurate history of the ISCJ based on available documents and personal narrations that would provide the reader with a glimpse into the past as to

how it all started, the struggles, the setbacks, and the achievements of the ISCJ community over its first forty years, from 1975 through 2015.

To achieve the stated objectives, biweekly progress meetings were scheduled. Initially, these meetings were held at Imam Chebli's house on Richard Road and later moved to the ISCJ library. The project's work plan was broken down into the following tasks, and team members were assigned to each of them:

1. Send out appeals to the ISCJ community, announcing the project and its mission, and ask for their participation.
2. Video interview the founding and other key members of the ISCJ who have been involved with the organization for a long time.
3. Collect ISCJ-related newspaper articles, arrange them in chronological order/subject, and scan them.
4. Collect historical documents from the ISCJ administration office records and from members of the society, arrange them in chronological order/subject, and scan them.
5. Compile yearly lists of the board of trustees, board of overseers, and standing committees and groups from the ISCJ administration office records and scan them.
6. Collect and ask for ISCJ-related personal and special events photographs and scan them.
7. Collect from the ISCJ community ISCJ-related personal write-ups, fact-check, and edit them.
8. Collect all approved general body meeting minutes with entire contents and scan them.
9. Collect the original ISCJ Constitution and later modified constitutions and scan them.
10. Hire necessary paid and unpaid volunteers to help do some of the above tasks as needed.
11. Buy necessary video camera and scanner and necessary software and USB drives for the project.
12. Proofread all the scanned documents for legibility and quality before sending to the publisher.
13. Prepare a draft manuscript for the history book and Excel sheet, listing scanned photographs.
14. Hire a reputable book publisher and sign a contract.
15. Send the manuscript and photographs to the publisher for editing and publishing the book.

Challenges

The main challenge was to contact the founding and other older members of the ISCJ who had moved out of the area and get them to write about their personal memories of the early days of the ISCJ. Some of them would rather give a video interview than write down their story. This required considerable follow-up efforts.

In cases where the members had passed away, their life's work and contributions to the ISCJ were collected from their family members and others and included as a tribute in lieu of their personal write-ups.

The other challenge was to find volunteers who could be relied upon to do some of the listed tasks in a timely manner. Students were only available during their recess; therefore, other members of the society who were available and willing to work as and when needed were hired at very reasonable rates to complete the various tasks in proper sequence and in a timely manner.

The ISCJ historic documents archives contain roughly twenty-thousand-plus pages. As it was not possible to accommodate so many documents in a reasonable size book, it was decided to provide a link for the purchasers of the book so they could download these historic documents, personal write-ups, personal, important events photos and video interviews from the ISCJ archives. Purchasers are requested to contact Shoukat68@outlook.com to obtain the link.

The selection of the publisher was critical. Three reputable publishers were contacted, and based on the services offered and the price, Xlibris was selected to publish the book. A video camera was purchased as recommended by Sr. Dawlat Chebly, who uses this camera model in her professional work and had joined the task force to record video interviews as and when required.

Project Summary

The first ISCJ history project team meeting occurred on September 6, 2014, at Imam Chebli's residence on Richard Road, South Brunswick, New Jersey, and then every weekend for a couple of months, and then it moved to the ISCJ premises. Thereafter, the task force met mostly on alternate Saturdays. It held some seventy plus meetings over a span of about three and a half years and spent over one thousand person-hours in meeting time and follow-up work to complete the project.

The ISCJ history book is titled *The Islamic Society of Central Jersey: Its Historical Journey*. It is composed of sixteen chapters. Each chapter contains a specific subject. A preamble precedes each chapter, which provides an overview of the contents of the chapter, and a sample of the documents it addresses, which gives the reader an idea as to the type of documents covered by that chapter. Similarly, all interview sessions were video recorded. The reader will able to view the recorded video interviews with the ISCJ founders and other members of the society.

Many members of the ISCJ provided personal write-ups. These are included in the book. These provide the reader a window into the past forty years of the ISCJ as narrated by the people who were involved in the organization.

It is anticipated that this first edition of the history book will be followed by future editions at regular intervals such as at the fiftieth anniversary of the ISCJ (2025) that will continually capture the ISCJ's story and update its history with the passage of time.

I would like to acknowledge the efforts and dedication of every member of the task force and all the other volunteers who helped in advancing the project from its conception to the publication of the book. Without their sustained efforts over a three-and-a-half-year stretch, the history book would not have seen the light of the day.

We hope this book will provide the future generations an insight into the challenges overcome by their predecessors in transforming the vision of the founders into its manifestation and encourage them to set higher goals.

We would like to acknowledge the support of the successive board of trustees who approved the concept, provided guidance, and set aside necessary funds to complete the project.

Special thanks to Br. Arif Patel, the ISCJ past president and Br. Muhammed Ashraf, the current president, Br. Sayed Hassan, the current office administrator and past administrators and other office staff for facilitating our task.

Above all, we thank AllahuTala (God) for His guidance and blessings throughout this endeavor.

Preamble: Forty Years of ISCJ's Historical Journey

Br. Shoukat Ali

This is the story of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) and the pioneers who came to New Jersey from different countries of the world for education and jobs starting in the 1950s with aspirations for a good life for themselves and their children. Their initial priorities were to earn American degrees in their professions so that they could get suitable jobs and settle their families in this new land called the United States of America.

Once they fulfilled their day-to-day needs to survive in this new land, they began to realize that there was a spiritual vacuum in their lives. There were no mosques or places dedicated for practicing the obligatory daily prayers in their neighborhood and where they and their children could go to pray, socialize, and learn to live and practice the Islamic way of life.

Here is the chronology of how the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) was founded:

> **1974:** Rutgers University authorities were approached by Br. Nabeel Taha, who was teaching there, to allow the Muslim students the use of two classrooms in Scott Hall on Sundays, starting with the September 1974–1975 school year. The Muslim families started meeting in Scott Hall at Rutgers University on Sundays for Qur'anic seminars and Zuhr prayers. However, it was soon apparent that the growing Muslim community needed its own

place of worship so it could pray and perform its religious obligations as and when mandated by Islam.

1975: The Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) was organized as a nonprofit, religious, and charitable organization and registered with the state of New Jersey as a 501(c) (3) organization on May 27, 1975. The first fund-raising event later that year netted $3,000, including a donation from the Islamic Service Organization (ISO) of which Br. Dawud Assad was the president.

1976: The first board of trustees were elected.

A search began in earnest to establish a mosque/community center that would cater to the spiritual, religious, and social needs of the Muslims to practice their Islamic way of life. About this time, the Rutgers group of Muslims came to know about another Muslim group in Trenton, New Jersey, who were also looking for a suitable place to build an Islamic center.

1977: Both these groups met on September 18, 1977 and agreed to combine resources and look for a single suitable location for a mosque/Islamic center. The next priority was to raise funds to buy a land. The Rutgers group raised about $14,000 and the Trenton group about $20,000 from local families. Additional funds were raised by approaching friends and relatives in the United States and abroad.

1978: The first official board of trustees were elected. Br. Suhail Rifai was elected the president and Br. Dawud Assad the chairman.

1979: The ISCJ bought its first parcel of land, 6.41 acres, on April 24, 1979, for $70,000 adjacent to Route 1 South, Monmouth Junction, and South Brunswick Township.

The first building committee consisted of Br. Dawud Assad (chairman), Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, Br. Saleem Baig, and Br. Hakim Irfani. Concurrently, the search

began for an architect who would design the Islamic center. The local firm of Mahony & Zvosec Architects & Planners, located at 621 Alexander Road, Princeton, was chosen to design the Islamic center. The first ISCJ Building Committee meeting with the architects occurred on Thursday, April 26, 1979. Mahony & Zvosec prepared phase 1 construction documents for a fee of $36,022.

1981: The construction contract documents were prepared for phase 1 of the ISCJ and submitted to the South Brunswick Township for approval. Several public hearings were held, where objections were raised by the neighbors concerning increased traffic associated with the Islamic center operation and their fear of this unknown entity that was requesting to build an Islamic center in their neighborhood. These concerns were addressed by the members of the board of trustees by meeting with the neighbors and assuring them that the Islamic center would be a good neighbor. The ISCJ's architect and lawyer ensured that necessary provisions were made in the plans to the satisfaction of the South Brunswick Township. The South Brunswick Township approved the plans in September 1981, and the construction of the first phase of the ISCJ started.

Several fund-raising events were held. Special payment arrangements were made with Mahony & Zvosec and Lemp M. Construction, architect and contractor team, for the turnkey contract that certain portions of the building would be released for construction in certain sequence, one segment at a time, so the construction invoices can be paid with the funds raised and available at that time. The fund-raising and construction releases were so planned that at no time construction had to be stopped for want of funds.

The ISCJ Constitution was adopted on March 29, 1981. Originally, Dr. Nazeer Ahmed was assigned the task of writing a preliminary constitution and bylaws for the purposes of obtaining incorporation with the state of New Jersey. However, when he moved

to California in 1978, Br. Shaikh Moizul Matin was given the responsibility to develop a comprehensive constitution and bylaws for the ISCJ. While Brother Matin headed the constitution committee, several other founding members and the board of trustees were actively involved in the discussions, leading to the development of the first ISCJ Constitution.

1983: Phase 1 of the ISCJ building was formally dedicated on December 4, 1983, although the weekend school student classes and other activities, such as Sunday seminars, had started on October 9, 1983.

1986: Imam Ahmed M. H. Sharkawy was hired as the first imam of the ISCJ in late 1984. However, he left after serving for a very short time because of ill health in the spring of 1986. Imam Hamad Chebli was hired on June 25, 1986. He joined the ISCJ in August 1986. He has been serving as the religious director and imam of the ISCJ for the past thirty-one years. He continues to offer many religious services to the community and develop relationships with leaders of the Christian and Jewish faiths and political leaders.

1988: Phase 2 of the ISCJ main building was started.

1989: A groundbreaking ceremony for phase 2 for the mosque occurred on August 29, 1989.

1990: Phase 2 of the Islamic center was also funded with a series of fund-raisers, and the contractor was paid in installments based upon the funds raised so the ISCJ never had to stop construction because of lack of funds. The opening of the second phase was celebrated with a religious dedication ceremony on July 28, 1990, and a formal grand opening ceremony on December 22, 1990. There were three hundred Muslim families registered as members at that time. The annual membership fee was $100/person and $200/family (husband and wife).

1993: Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI) was incorporated as an independent tax-exempt organization after considerable discussions between the ISCJ and NUI. In the fall of that year, Noor-Ul-Iman full-time school opened with twenty-seven students from pre-K to third grade.

1995, 1997, and 2000: New modular units (trailers) were added to expand NUI. By 1998, the student enrollment was 180 with a long waiting list.

2001: A formal memorandum of understanding was signed by the ISCJ and the NUI boards on May 13, 2001.

2004: The ISCJ purchased the house at 31 Richard Road, South Brunswick, for $335,000 on July 28, 2004.

2006: The ISCJ master plan was approved by South Brunswick Township Zoning Board.

2010: Noor-Ul-Iman permanent school building phase 1 construction started in June. Hessberger was the architect, and WOW Construction was the contractor.

2012: Noor-Ul-Iman School building phase 1 construction was completed in August.

Sr. Atiya Aftab was elected as the first woman chairperson of the ISCJ Board of Trustees on April 30, 2012.

The grand opening of the phase 1 of the Noor-Ul-Iman School project was celebrated on September 8.

2013: School building phase 2 was started. Hessberger was the architect, and WOW Construction was the contractor.

2014: Noor-Ul-Iman School building phase 2 was completed in August. The total cost of construction of the building was about $10 million plus.

The first ISCJ History Project Meeting was on September 6, 2014 at Imam Chebli's home on Richard Street next to the ISCJ Buildings.

2015: The ISCJ_celebrated its fortieth anniversary on December 12.

2018: The last face to face ISCJ History project meeting was on Sunday July 22, 2018.

Looking back, the Islamic Society of Central Jersey has come a long way since the days of its conception in the minds of the early Muslims who migrated from different parts of the world to settle in New Jersey and conceptualized the ISCJ as it stands today. It continues to manifest their vision of an institution where Muslims and non- Muslims go to seek true knowledge of Islam from its resident imam, teachers and visiting imams, and scholars from well-known institutions in the United States and abroad.

Today the ISCJ stands as a vibrant, diverse, and progressive community of Muslims that is keeping strides with the changing times while preserving its Islamic values and aspirations. Our founders envisioned an ISCJ that would one day become a premier institution that would dispel misconceptions about Islam and Muslims by providing knowledge of true Islam and leadership by example. By the grace of Allah, the inspired vision has continually been transformed over time into reality by the concerted efforts of the successively elected board of trustees, overseers, various committees, fund-raising group, the imam, and the material capital and intellectual generosity of the ISCJ community. All praise is to Allah (God) for His continued guidance and blessings along this historical journey. We hope and pray that the ISCJ would continue to grow in its stature by promoting the message of Islam—peace and harmony and love for one another among all people of this land through eternity. May the light of Islam shine forever!

Preamble: Reminiscences of the ISCJ Members through Their Write-Ups

Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed, D. Phil.

Compilation of the reminiscences of the long-serving members of the ISCJ has been a painstaking process. Through the recollections of the ISCJ's founding members and old-timers, it was important to document the germination of the ISCJ, its growth over the years, and its current flowering.

Some founding members have passed on, some have relocated, and the memories of the remaining are fading. Fortunately, some founding members, such as Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, Br. Dawud Assad, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, Br. Shoukat Ali, Br. Shaikh Moizul Matin, and Sr. Sogra Saleem, are in good health. They have been leaders and an integral part of the ISCJ historical journey project.

The editor of the project, Br. Shoukat Ali, sent out invitations to the members of the ISCJ to share their experiences with the ISCJ community. Initial response was tepid. After repeated extending of the deadline, only a few write-ups were received. Then the task force members personally requested the long-time members for their write-ups. Even then, there were foot-dragging and repeated missing of the deadlines. But the task force members persisted. The original expectation was that about twenty reminiscences would be published. Eventually, we ended up with over fifty.

Br. Dawud Assad was most active in persuading the founding members to share their memories. He was present at the genesis of the ISCJ and remembered events as though they had happened yesterday. He has a

photographic memory of events at ISCJ's inception. He was a most valuable asset in this section of the project.

Dr. Sogra Saleem was the fact-checker. She has an encyclopedic knowledge of the history of the ISCJ. Sister Sogra fact-checked every write-up submitted. Not a single mistake, big or small, eluded her eye. The factual accuracy of every name, event, and date in the project is because of the diligence of Sister Sogra.

Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed was the editor of the write-ups. Out of respect for the writers and at their request, we decided to edit only the text, not the contents.

Br. Shoukat Ali had the unenviable task of putting it all together, which he did superbly. He read every piece, made comments and corrections, and had the final say on everything. The success of this project is a testament to Br. Shoukat Ali's tenacity and leadership.

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Preamble: Personal and Events Photos

Br. Arif Khan

In response to Br. Shoukat Ali's several appeals to the ISCJ community, many individuals sent their original photos over a period of about two years. These were then turned over to Sr. Sogra Saleem, who recruited and supervised several volunteers to scan about 150 originals of various shades and sizes. The originals and the scans were then handed over to Br. Arif Khan for quality check and improvements necessary for publication.

We were still missing a lot of photos of the write-up authors. Br. Arif Khan faced a lot of hurdles in collecting the personal photographs of those who submitted write-ups. Sometimes the photographs submitted were not of publication quality. It required repeated reminders by him to collect the photographs that are included in this chapter. He had to rescan some photos from poor quality originals or scan and extract them from the video interviews or group photos.

The various events photos show persons and their families who visited the ISCJ and attended events associated with the ISCJ. Some photos also show members and friends of the ISCJ attending events at other places or at historical events.

During these visits and events, many photographs were taken going as far back as when black-and-white photos were the standard. The owners of these photographs have shared them with the ISCJ History Project Team so we could include them in the book.

Preamble: Islamic Art

Br. Arif Khan

Islamic art includes the visual arts produced from the earliest times by people who lived within the territory that was inhabited by or ruled by a population that was culturally Islamic.

It is a very difficult art to define because it covers many lands and people over some 1,400 years, and it is not art specifically of a religion, or of a time, or of a place.

The huge field of Islamic architecture is exhibited in calligraphy, painting, glass, pottery, and textile arts, such as carpets and embroidery.

Islamic art is not at all restricted to religious art but includes all the art of the various Islamic societies. The calligraphy of the Qur'an is an important aspect, but other religious art, such as glass mosque lamps, and other mosque fittings, such as tiles, woodwork, and carpets, usually have the same style and motifs as contemporary secular art, although with prominent religious inscriptions.

In this book, we have captured some of the art calligraphy by Faraz Khan (http://www.farazkhanartstudio.com/).

Preamble: Constitution and Amendments

Br. Shoukat Ali

The Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) was incorporated as a nonprofit, religious, charitable, and educational organization in the state of New Jersey on May 27, 1975, to qualify as a tax-exempt organization that could raise tax-deductible funds to meet its operational and capital expenses.

To meet the state regulations and establish a well-defined organizational structure required definitions of the authority and responsibility of the officers of the corporation, the rights and obligations of the members, and election and amendment procedures, Dr. Nazeer Ahmed filed the preliminary constitution and bylaws with the state of New Jersey. After his migration to California, a constitution committee was formed to draft a comprehensive constitution. This committee was headed by Dr. Shaikh Moizul Matin. It also included Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, Dr. Riaz Iqbal, Dr. Mahmoud Taher, Br. Shoukat Ali, and Br. Dawud Assad.

The constitution has the following salient features:

Article II. Character and Objective

The character of the organization is to remain Islamic at all times, and it must observe Islamic values in all its proceedings. The overall character cannot be compromised; that is, the society, while conducting its business according to the laws of the land, must exercise its Islamic values such as honesty, men and women's rights, and justice in all matters of dispute

among its members. It must facilitate and promote better relations and understanding within the Muslim community and with people of other faiths.

Article III. Activities of the Society

All its activities must be focused on serving its objectives while maintaining Islamic character. These include the following:

1. Providing religious, educational, charitable, social, and cultural services
2. Providing true Islamic teachings to Muslims and non-Muslims who may seek knowledge of Islam
3. Establishing, maintaining, and operating an Islamic center with facilities for observing mandates of Islamic faith, such as offering five times daily prayers and observing fasting in Ramadan, the two Eid, and so on.
4. Providing a library access to the imam and other scholars to dispense true knowledge of Islam
5. Providing imam's services in connection with funerals, marriages, and births and embracing Islamic faith
6. Raising necessary funds for operating and capital expenses
7. Instituting interfaith dialogues and joining with other institutions to serve a common cause

Article IV. Structure and Organization

The organizational structure adopted by the ISCJ Constitution consists of three basic branches of government: (1) the supreme authority (general body), (2) the executive branch (the board of trustees), and (3) the judiciary (the overseers). Each branch has a specific role and responsibility. The constitution provides checks and balances so that no branch may exceed or abuse its authority or overreach into others' territory. The board of trustees and board of overseers are equal in stature and independent of each other. Each has different responsibility, while both report to the general body, the supreme authority of the ISCJ. But all three, including the general body, are subservient to the constitution and cannot override it.

Article V. Jurisdiction and Authority

The ISCJ's organizational structure is based on the following subgroups:

General Body: These are the adult (eighteen years of age and above) members of the Muslim community at large who pay a prescribed yearly membership fee to the ISCJ. Those who have paid the prescribed full yearly fee by December 31 of any given year constitute the general body and would be eligible to vote at the general body meeting/s held in the following year. The general body is the supreme authority of the ISCJ. However, the general body must follow the constitution in conducting its business. Any changes to the constitution must be presented as amendments following prescribed and approved procedure and for approval.

Board of Trustees: The board of trustees are the executives of the ISCJ who are responsible for the day-to-day operation of the ISCJ, planning for the future and keeping the ISCJ solvent. There are nine regular members of the board as a norm, but two additional members may be appointed at the discretion of the board if deemed necessary to supplement any special skill or talent lacking within the nine regular membership of the board. Also, in case a vacancy occurs in the board due to any reason, it can be filled by the board by selecting candidates from the list of nominees of the last election as set forth in the constitution for a maximum one- year term. All actions and decisions by the board must conform to the objectives of the society (ISCJ), and it must follow and abide by the constitution and bylaws as adopted by the general body.

Any trustee may be elected for two consecutive terms without break; however, there must be a two-year break before he/she can be reelected to the board. This was done to give an opportunity for new members of the society (ISCJ) who have never been a trustee to have a fair chance of being elected and to break any group monopolizing

the elections by getting elected year after year without successive term limitations.

The board selects an executive committee from within itself consisting of five members who are assigned specific portfolios to help the board carry out its duties and responsibilities.

The board has the authority to create committees to carry out specific duties. It appoints the committee chairs. However, no board member may chair a standing committee. This was done to keep the committees from being unduly influenced or dictated to by the board.

Overseers of the Society: Every year, the general body elects two members who meet the qualification requirements listed under "Overseers of the Society." They are the judicial branch of the ISCJ. They carry out duties, such as nominations and elections and any mediatory, reconciliatory, or any investigative role, if needed. They have neither responsibility nor power nor authority to be involved in the decisions of the trustees. The overseers are required to attend the board of trustees meetings to keep abreast of all the board actions to ensure that no constitution or bylaws are being violated in conduct of its business. They may offer their opinion on matters under discussion at such meetings but do not have a vote on any matter under the board's jurisdiction. They must themselves follow and abide by the constitution and the bylaws adopted by the general body in conducting their business and making their decisions.

The above structure was adopted and responsibilities assigned to make sure that the board of trustees and the overseers are independent of each other and report to the general body.

The overseers have the following responsibilities:

1. Investigation: They must investigate any issue brought up to them by the board or general body or any petition, grievance, or dispute brought up to them by individuals. They cannot initiate an investigation on their own.

2. Communication: The overseers must communicate with the membership and the board of trustees while performing any authorized activities.
3. Nomination: They invite nominations for election to the board of trustees and overseers and validate them in accordance with the qualifications set forth in the constitution. They must provide reasons for disqualification of any candidate from nomination. They cannot be a nominee in an election they are supervising. This was done to avoid any conflict of interest.
4. Elections: They must carry out the entire process of election as per the constitution and bylaws.

   If they fail to carry out their duties, they are subject to dismissal by the board of trustees. This was done to ensure that the overseers abide by the constitution even when they are solely in charge of the entire election or other authorized activities mentioned above.

5. Only general body can fill any vacancies in the overseers following the procedure set forth in the constitution. This was done to keep the overseers independent and only accountable to the general body.

Membership: There are five classes of membership in ISCJ.

1. Life Members: Those who have contributed an exceedingly large amount of money to the ISCJ in the opinion of the board of trustees.
2. Founding Members: Those who had contributed at least $1,000 in one year prior to the annual general body meeting of 1981 and pay annual dues to the society. There are 130 founding members on the record.
3. Voting Members: These are Muslims of eighteen years of age and over who filed their application for membership or renewed it before September 30 of a year, and paid the prescribed membership fees for each calendar on or before December 31, and met other eligibility requirements set forth in the constitution. All voting members have equal rights. These include receiving all timely notification by mail or by e-mail of annual general body meetings, proposed amendments to the constitution, audited annual financial statements, newsletters, and nomination forms for elections and the right to protest or file grievances.

4. General Members: These are the members of the Muslim community whose circumstances do not allow them to become voting members of the ISCJ.
5. Honorary Members: Those who provided valuable services to the ISCJ. They are not required to contribute any money and are not entitled to vote.

Article VII: Financial Management and Responsibility

1. The board of trustees are responsible and liable for all finances, assets, and financial commitments on behalf of the society (ISCJ). They are required to present a comprehensive operating and capital budget for each year for approval by the general body. They cannot take on financial and legal obligations without prior approval of the general body. While this may seem to restrict them, it also protects them and limits their liability and exposure to legal suits.
2. The board is required to have the ISCJ accounts audited by a well-known independent certified public accountant (CPA) every year, who serves as the external auditor and certifies the statements per American standards. To meet the requirement of the independent auditor, the ISCJ has a team of accountants on its staff who prepare the accounts in the format required by the external CPA. These internal accounts are first audited by an internal audit committee before sending it to the external independent CPA for review and certification based on generally accepted auditing standards in the United States.
3. The board of trustees are required to balance the budget every year, meaning that the expenses must match the revenues.
4. The trustees are authorized to appropriate an existing annual operating budget for the New Year starting on January 1 until the general body adopts a new operations budget as the ISCJ fiscal year starts on January 1 and ends on December 31. This allows payment for expenses that may have been initiated in the current year but extending into next year.
5. Similarly, capital budgets are prepared for the fiscal year starting on January 1 and ending on December 31, but the trustees are authorized to fulfill any and all contractual obligations previously authorized and incurred beyond the fiscal year up to the extent funds are available until the general body adopts a new capital budget.

6. Even though a capital program may be conceptually approved by the general body that may span over several years, capital budgets are approved one year at a time. This was done because of the unpredictability of available funds that are based on funds raised and expenses incurred during the previous year.

Article VIII: Elections

Generally, every year, the office terms of three trustees and two overseers expire. The ISCJ Constitution requires that elections be held every year to fill these and any additional vacancies that may have occurred because of any other reason. The elections are carried out entirely by the overseers from start to finish. This involves the following key steps:

1. Overseers review the accounting records to determine the total number of the eligible voting members as of December 31 of the year. They constitute the general body of the society (ISCJ).
2. Overseers invite nominations for election to the board of trustees and board of overseers.
3. Upon receipt of nominations, the overseers determine the eligibility of the proposed candidates based on the criteria set forth in the constitution for election to a board of trustee or overseer position and advise the board of trustees. Overseers prepare the final list of eligible nominees to be included in the package for the annual general body meeting.
4. All elections are carried out by secret ballots. These ballots are cast manually by the voting members at the ISCJ on the day of the annual meeting by the ballot box closing time stated on the meeting agenda. Absentee ballots are provided to voting members of sixty-five years or over at their requests. Absentee ballots must be mailed or dropped off in the sealed envelope provided by the overseers by 1:00 p.m. on the Election Day.
5. The votes are counted by the overseers upon closing of the ballot boxes if a minimum qualifying 20 percent quorum is achieved on or before the published ballot boxes closing time announced on the meeting agenda.
6. The ballot boxes closing time announced on the general body meeting agenda cannot be curtailed or extended by the general body present on the floor or by the overseers or by the board of trustees, or else, all the votes would be invalidated.

7. If the votes are invalidated, the overseers are required to send out fresh voting ballots with necessary explanation and information by mail/e-mail. The results are decided and announced on receipt of the mailed/e-mailed ballots by certain date and time.

Article IX: Amendments to the Constitution

Since the ISCJ Constitution is a living document governing the workings of the ISCJ—it must allow for its growth and address its changing needs while maintaining its basic Islamic character—amendments may need to be made from time to time. To provide an orderly process, detailed procedures have been laid out for any voting member to be able to propose an amendment for consideration by the ISCJ general body. These procedures, under procedures and policy manual, are available at the ISCJ office or on the website. Any voting member has the right to propose an amendment following the prescribed procedure.

Once a proposed amendment is reviewed by the constitution committee, it is presented to the general body at the annual general body meeting or any special meeting called for the purpose. The notice for such meeting has to be mailed/e-mailed to the voting membership at least fifteen days before the meeting. The notice describes the proposed amendment in an exact language.

A minimum 20 percent quorum and three-fourths of votes cast are required for approval of any proposed amendment.

The proposed amendment is subject to discussion and modification following Roberts's Rules of Order, the most commonly followed procedure by large associations/bodies in the United States.

Article XI: Bylaws

The constitution clauses are supplemented by bylaws. These provide detailed procedures to be followed to implement various clauses. While the amendments to the constitution require approval of the general body, the bylaws can be amended by a simple majority vote in a board meeting with a minimum of seven days' notice. The bylaws must be consistent with the constitution clauses they pertain to. They cannot restrict or alter any provision of the constitution. Additional bylaws can be enacted by the board. Robert's Rules of Order has been adopted for the conduct of general body meetings. This provides a standard procedure for conducting

such meetings in accordance with this nationally accepted procedure in the United States. It prevents manipulation of procedures by the board of trustees/board of overseers or any other person/group to suit their own preference at the expense of others. This has served the ISCJ well for the last forty-plus years and kept it out of courts by preventing contentious/ frivolous law suits.

The bylaws provide details of authority and responsibility for the president, the chairperson, and the treasurer of the society (ISCJ). This is supplemented by procedures to be followed by various committee chairs and members.

Annual General Body Meeting: A general body meeting is required to be held every year. These are generally held on a Sunday morning starting around nine thirty. All important matters, such as yearly operating and capital budgets and financial statements, are presented by the board of trustees for approval by the general body. Any amendments to the constitution are presented when necessary. The meeting starts with a minimum quorum of 5 percent, and it remains a limited general body meeting until a quorum of 20 percent is achieved when the meeting becomes a regular meeting.

This was done to enable meetings to start without waiting for a full quorum of 20 percent, which is achieved very late, usually after Zuhr prayers. During the limited meeting, a two-thirds majority vote is required to approve items such as the operating and capital budgets. Meanwhile, voting on elections, amendments, and any other ballots is continued. However, these votes are validated only if 20 percent quorum is achieved before or by the announced time on the meeting's agenda for closing the ballot boxes.

These meetings are run according to Robert's Rules of Order.

1. the board of trustees and the overseers decide the date of the annual meeting wherein the elections will be held. The agenda of the meeting is prepared jointly by the trustees and overseers.
2. a complete package consisting of the agenda listing all the items to be discussed is mailed/e-mailed/posted on the ISCJ website at least fifteen calendar days before the announced day of the annual meeting.
3. the annual meeting package contains the income statement, proposed operating and capital budgets, any issues or amendments to be voted on, and president's, chairman's, secretary's, and all committees' reports as well as the list of candidates eligible for election.

4. quorum calls are made starting with the first call when 5 percent of the quorum is achieved and a limited meeting is started. Subsequent quorum calls are made at about half an hour's interval or so until 20 percent quorum is achieved. The fourth and final call at the announced time is very critical. The limited meeting is highly restrictive, and only certain specific items can be discussed during this meeting, no new business.
5. if the 20 percent quorum is achieved by the announced time, all votes cast are counted by the overseers, and provisional results are announced the same day, subject to final confirmation in two weeks.
6. in case no protest is filed during these two weeks, the outgoing chief overseer administers the oath of office to the newly elected members of the board of trustees and overseers and files his/her final report with the board of trustees.
7. in case of any protest filed regarding any issues with the meeting or elections or any other matter brought up during the subject two weeks, the overseers are required to review the protest and announce their decision within four weeks of the date of election and announcement of the provisional results.
8. the overseers' decision is final unless the overseers committed any constitutional violations during the process. In that case, the board of trustees are not obligated to comply with the overseers' decision. Instead, the board of trustees are required to dismiss the overseers and take prescribed remedial action themselves to address the protest. This is the check against any constitutional violations committed by the overseers in arriving at their final decision.
9. if the 20 percent quorum is not achieved by the fourth and final call at assigned/announced time, the meeting remains a limited meeting and votes are null and void. The overseers are obligated to send out fresh voting ballots, along with minutes of the limited meeting, to the general body by mail/e-mail and review the mail ballots when received to declare the final result of elections and any other issue and administer the oath of offices accordingly.

Article X: Dissolution of the Society

This article is placed here at the end of the preamble rather than in the serial order it appears in the constitution as it is highly unlikely that ISCJ will ever be dissolved. Nevertheless, it is a requirement of the state of

New Jersey for registration as an exempt nonprofit, religious, and charitable organization.

It provides that a three-quarter majority of the board of trustees may decree the dissolution for a reason and a cause for approval by a three-quarter majority of the general body called for this specific purpose. Failure of approval by such majority of the general body removes all trustees, and the overseers carry out the wishes of the general body.

CAUTION:

The Preamble provides general information about the ISCJ constitution; as the constitution is subject to amendment, ISCJ strictly follows the latest amended constitution and administrative procedures in force.

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Preamble: The ISCJ Constitutional and Administrative Procedures

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

The Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) was incorporated on May 27, 1975, as a religious, charitable, nonprofit organization in the state of New Jersey. While the constitution meets the legal requirements of the state, the bylaws prescribe the constitutional procedures to be followed in implementing the constitutional requirements. The constitution was adopted on March 24, 1981. The first official board of trustees and board of overseers was elected following the adoption of the constitution and the policies and procedures started being implemented.

Annual General Body Meeting Procedure

The ISCJ Constitution requires that the general body must meet at least once a year. At this annual meeting, the trustees must present the year's activities and financial status of the society as per the requirements set forth in the constitution and bylaws.

The annual general body meeting (AGBM) is generally held in the month of April. The ISCJ Board of Trustees presents the financial statement of the previous year and the operating and capital budgets for the current year for approval. The overseers present the slate of nominees for election to the board of trustees and the board of overseers. The committees provide their activity reports.

A lot of work goes into preparation for the general body meeting. An agenda is prepared and agreed upon by the board of trustees in conjunction with the board of overseers. The date and time of the meeting is notified well in advance. The overseers send out the notification letter about the terms of expiring trustees and overseers and collect the names of nominated candidates from the society's membership. They then determine the eligibility of each individual nominee, as per the eligibility criteria set forth in the ISCJ Constitution, before placing them on the ballots for voting by the general body. All general body meetings are run according to Robert's Rules of Procedure, which is the nationally adopted standard procedure for conducting large legislative meetings in the United States.

The president runs the meeting, and the overseers are in charge of the quorum calls and conducting the elections. The agenda typically consists of the following:

1. Voting member registration conducted by the membership committee.
2. Qur'anic recitation by the imam, followed by comments.
3. First call for quorum: Upon achieving 5 percent of the quorum, a limited meeting may be started. Wherein all matters are decided by two-thirds majority vote, three interim quorum calls are made at convenient intervals. The purpose of these calls is to announce to the general body as soon as 20 percent quorum is achieved, at which time the meeting achieves the regular status. The decisions from this time on require only a simple majority vote, and all other votes cast up to the closing time are validated.
4. Overseers' explanation of annual body procedures and election ballots and opening time of ballot boxes. If any amendment ballots are involved, these are explained by a constitution committee representative. Any other special issue ballots are explained by the president or the chief overseer.
5. If there are any amendments to the constitution, these are discussed and voted on. The constitution committee representatives explain and answer any questions before voting. If any new amendments are approved, they are incorporated in the revised and amended constitution.
6. Chairperson's comments.
7. Approval of the previous year's annual general body meeting minutes and the status of any action items. This is open to question and answer from the general body.

8. President's comments, including all activities, new initiatives, and achievements, while answering any questions and concerns.
9. Treasurer's presentation of the previous year's financial statement and proposed operating and capital budgets with discussion, modification, and approval.
10. Committee reports – any questions or clarifications.

    At the fourth and final quorum call, all the ballot boxes are closed. If 20 percent quorum is met, the votes are validated. In case the 20 percent quorum is not achieved by the fourth and final call at the time announced on the agenda, the meeting remains a limited meeting and the ballot boxes are closed. The election and all other ballots are mailed/e-mailed to the general body for fresh voting to validate the votes cast.

11. Meeting is adjourned (earlier if quorum falls below 5 percent).
12. Overseers announce the results of the election and any other ballots.

There is a two-week window after the day of the election when any voting member can lodge a complaint or protest stating why in his/her opinion the conduction of the election violated the constitution. Such complaint is investigated thoroughly by the overseers, and when everything is found satisfactory, the final list of elected members is announced.

If there is a valid protest as determined by the overseers on a certain item of the annual meeting, that item may be revisited in a special general body meeting. This is again handled by the board of overseers in conjunction with the board of trustees (who may have revised the report in contention) and follow the prescribed agenda to resolve the matter.

An example of the protest following the 2015 AGBM held on April 24, 2015, and a special general body meeting held on October 25, 2015, are accessible on the accompanying USB drive.

The first annual general body meeting of the ISCJ was held on September 18, 1977, at which time the two communities from Rutgers and Trenton area had successfully merged. Dr. Suhail Rifai was the first president of the ISCJ and Br. Dawud Assad the first chairman. They informed the members of the purchase of 6.4-acre land on Route 1 and reported on the progress in obtaining a zoning variance for the construction of a mosque.

The next AGBM took place on Sunday, January 28, 1979, at the Holiday Inn in Princeton. At this meeting, the elections of the trustees took

place under the guidance of a special committee chaired by Dr. Mahmoud Taher (since there were no overseers). Although the constitution was not formalized, there were some proposed suggestions that were approved and incorporated later into the constitution. At this time, Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar was elected as the president and Br. Dawud Assad as the chairman. There were eleven trustees with staggered terms from one year to three years to help transition into the standard three trustees and two overseers to be elected every year.

The excerpts of the meetings in the 1970s and early 1980s were published in the newsletter and later in the *Noor-Ul Islam* magazine, which were the official publications of the ISCJ. The meeting minutes, which were recorded by the secretary, and later by the executive secretary, were kept in the ISCJ office for anyone wishing to look at it.

In the mid-1980s, a special booklet dedicated to the AGBM was published, and the practice is still in force. Since 2014, the AGBM booklet is also available to the members electronically. Apart from the constitution, there were several bylaws enacted that deal specifically with the AGBM, elections, and roles and responsibilities of trustees, overseers, and the administration. The electronic e-mailing and placing of the AGBM booklet on the website have streamlined the administrative process of preparing and transmitting the AGBM booklet, resulting in significant labor and cost savings.

Administrative Policies and Procedures

Besides, the society has complied a set of comprehensive operating procedures for the day-to-day operation of the ISCJ. These are contained in a separate binder kept in the ISCJ administrative office.

From the very beginning, the minutes of the board meetings were recorded by the secretary of the board. Any resolutions adopted at monthly meetings were recorded in a separate ledger. The meeting minutes of the annual general body meeting were diligently recorded by the executive secretary and published. The treasurer followed generally accepted accounting standards and established fiscal policies. The role and responsibilities of the trustees and the president, secretary, and treasurer are outlined in the constitution. Article VII of the constitution addresses the financial management and responsibility.

In the mid-1980s, the first person to be hired was an imam, and a job description was prepared for this purpose, including his role and responsibility and a financial commitment as well as obligation of ISCJ

toward him. The first administrator was hired in 1991 during Br. Morad Abou-Sabe's term as the ISCJ president, and the job description, roles, and responsibilities were formalized. Similar job procedures were written in the mid-1990s when ISCJ hired an accountant on their payroll.

In 2005, Br. Aly Aziz took the daunting challenge of creating an operating manual for policies and procedures. This manual goes into details of ISCJ structure and organization. The operating procedures were voted and approved by the trustees in 2008 and since then have become part of the administrative policies. The constitution committee was entrusted with the responsibility of preparing scope for each committee. The manual also covers guidelines to adhere to the performance of ISCJ functions and tools for internal and external auditors, reliability of financial records, and safeguarding the assets of ISCJ. Financial transactions are periodically checked and appropriate steps taken to make sure these are accurate.

In 2005, the first code of ethics was put in place for all officials and employees. At present, this is being revised, along with conflict of interest issues by the constitution committee. ISCJ started their website, and this is maintained and updated periodically. This helps in the dissemination of time-sensitive information to ISCJ members. All information has to be approved by the president. Any changes in any functions of ISCJ have to be formally modified, approved, and updated periodically.

CAUTION:

The Preamble provides general information about the ISCJ constitution; as the constitution is subject to amendment, ISCJ strictly follows the latest amended constitution and administrative procedures in force.

Preamble: The Annual Green Pages and Communicator

Br. Dawud Assad

In the first quarter newsletter (vol. 1, no. 1, dated January–April 1979) that was published, Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, the president of the ISCJ, spoke about the building project and said that it would include a mosque, a social hall, a library, and classrooms for weekend Islamic school for children as well as for adults. He said that during the previous two years, the ISCJ had raised approximately $100,000 mainly through contributions from local Muslims as well as friends across the United States and overseas. He said that the estimated cost of this project would be close to $600,000 and that the plan called for a phased construction over the following two to three years. A fund-raising dinner was announced to take place at the common room of the North Brunswick High School in New Jersey. The price of a ticket was $15 per adult. Tickets were to be purchased from Brs. Syed Salaam Shahidi and Abdel-Rehim Riad and Dr. Riaz Iqbal.

At this fund-raiser, the annual general body meeting was announced, which was held on Sunday, January 28, 1979, at the Holiday Inn, Route 1 North, Princeton, New Jersey. The minutes of the meeting of the previous general assembly, which was held on September 18, 1977, were read by Br. M. Tandiyala. Dr. Suhail Rifai, president of the ISCJ, outlined the activities of ISCJ in the previous year, the purchase of the 6.4 acres of land, and the progress in obtaining a zoning variance from the South Brunswick Township Zoning Board for the construction of the society and the good cooperation between large Muslim communities in New Brunswick and Trenton areas. Br. Dawud Assad, chairman of the board, reported on the program of the building project, and the annual financial

report was presented by the treasurer, Br. Soliman Montasser. The election was chaired by Dr. Mahmoud Taher, and the executive committee and the members of the board of trustees were elected. This issue also had a report on the weekend school and included the names of the various ISCJ committees, the chairmen, and members. For details, see the newsletter, vol. 1, no. 1, January–April 1979 on the enclosed CD/USB.

***GREEN PAGES* NEWSLETTERS:** This was an annual Muslim directory (*Green Pages* issue) listing businesses, doctors, services, Islamic centers, youth and women's corner, Islamic publications, Islamic schools, prayer schedule, a membership form, and miscellaneous advertisement to bring revenue to the society.

Six small brochure issues were published in the early years after the establishment of the ISCJ. The first issue consisted of six pages and highlighted the establishment of ISCJ, its activities, the choosing of its site, the plan and the estimated cost, the planned date for construction, a sketch of proposed project, and an appeal for contribution. It also printed the names of officers and trustee members. Another issue carried the announcement of the proposed groundbreaking ceremony on the first day of Ramadan, July 13, 1980, and the fund-raising dinner at the Nassau Inn, Princeton, New Jersey, at 8:30 p.m.

***NOOR-UL-ISLAM* MAGAZINE** was the official publication of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey. A souvenir issue, volume 1, number 1, was issued in summer 1980. It published on its cover a sketch of the future Islamic center of the ISCJ. The issue included news of the groundbreaking ceremony that was held on July 13, 1980, at the site of the future center. More than 150 members of the ISCJ, 2 members of the South Brunswick Township Committee, several neighbors, and many other guests took part in the ceremony.

Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, president of the ISCJ, acknowledged and appreciated the assistance and cooperation of the members and friends of the ISCJ in raising close to $250,000 for the center. He expressed the hope that they would be soon meeting under a roof of their own rather than meeting under the open sky. It was beautiful sunny day, and of course, being the first day of Ramadan, it was a blessing for our future hopes.

Br. Dawud Assad, the chairman of the board of trustees of the ISCJ, welcomed the guests and reiterated that there "is much talk in the world these days of ecumenism." Muslims would like to work with other faiths to foster that understanding and friendship, which alone can be the basis of a lasting peace, of peace with values. Brother Dawud added that the

Qur'an says, "There is no compulsion in religion," and that Islam is the religion of peace. He assured ISCJ's neighbors, be they Christians, Jews, or others, that the future Islamic center will be a good neighbor to them and that the ISCJ was looking forward to being a part of this community. He introduced the prominent guests, including His Excellency Ambassador. Br. Yousef Sylla, permanent representative of the Islamic Conference to the United Nations; Br. Mohsin Alaini, permanent representative of the Yemen Arab Republic to the United Nations; and Mr. Jerry Bettner, South Brunswick Township administrator.

Other issues of *Noor-Ul-Islam* published dealt with the stages of the construction of the ISCJ center, fund-raising dinners, and so on. Some issues had a page or two for children, titled "Children's Corner," addressing subjects such as "Islamic Etiquette," "Why I Am a Muslim," and "Islam Is a Way of Life" and featured advertisements, names of ISCJ officers and BOT, membership application, names of the ISCJ founding and active members, contribution of Muslim scientists to civilization, the Islamic art of calligraphy, and so on. Br. Zamir Hassan was the editor of *Noor-Ul-Islam* for many years in the 1990s and the early 2000s.

Preamble: Fund-Raising/ Expansion Funding Group

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

The first plot of land on Route 1 South and Stouts Lane was purchased for $70,000. This seed money came from some dedicated Muslim brothers and sisters of Friends of Rutgers and Trenton Physicians groups. Each group came up with $35,000 with a contribution of $1,000 or more per person. After acquiring the land, a conceptual plan was developed. The plan was divided into two phases. The first phase consisted of a multipurpose room for prayers and meetings, a few classrooms, and bathrooms. The phase 1 was estimated to cost $350,000. Fund-raising was undertaken under the leadership of Pres. Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, and a fund-raising committee was formed. The fund-raising committee was chaired by Dr. Riaz Iqbal and consisted of Dr. A. H. Babar, Dr. Hanif Chaudhry, Dr. Irfanul Huq, and Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad. A letter from the ISCJ president Dr. Babar and Chairman Dr. R. Iqbal was sent out to the community, inviting them to the first public fund-raising event, which was held at the Nassau Inn in Princeton in June 1980. The tickets for the event were $100 per person. The goal was to have five hundred donors contribute $500 each to collect $250,000.

In addition, an ISCJ publication, *Noor-Ul-Islam*, which was recently launched, was utilized to get advertisements from professionals and businessmen. A full-page advertisement and two fund-raising function tickets were given to any person donating $500 and participating in the fund-raising effort. Many physicians, businessmen, and other people participated in this. Br. Fahd Al Nasser, director of Muslim League, attended the fund-raising function. Overall, the fund-raising efforts were

successful, and by the grace of Allah, in 1983, the phase 1 of the project was completed, and the weekend school classes were held for the first time at this location of the ISCJ instead of the Rutgers University campus.

One of the incentives offered to raise funds was to grant any member paying at least $1000 in one year prior to the annual general body meeting of 1981 and pay annual dues to the society, a founding membership of the ISCJ. In all, 130 individuals came forward with $1,000 or more donations in the years prior to the meeting and thus became the founding members of the ISCJ. The category of founding membership became part of the constitution of the ISCJ. This category of membership was closed after the abovementioned general body meeting.

In 1982, Br. Omar Boraie, Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dr. Mohamed Elsaady, Br. Roshan Dasti, Br. Mohamed Zarka, and Sr. Raafat Ahmad joined the fund-raising committee. In 1984, three of the founding members—Dr. A. H. Babar, Dr. Suhail Rifai, and Br. Mahmoud Taher—went to Saudi Arabia during the month of Ramadan and collected donations from private individuals toward the construction of the mosque.

In 1987, additional highly motivated members joined the ISCJ. They included Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady, Br. Morad Abou-Sabe, and Dr. Sogra Saleem. Under the leadership of Br. M. Abou-Sabe, we had a fund-raising dinner at the Hyatt Regency hotel in Princeton at $100 a plate. Dr. Jamal Badawi was the keynote speaker. This event was very successful. Concurrently, there was the first art exhibition in the ISCJ's multipurpose room, where works of some local and national artists were displayed. This generated great interest and brought in much-needed additional funds.

In 1990, we had an opening ceremony for the second phase of the ISCJ, which is the present ISCJ mosque. At this time, Dr. Sogra Saleem as the chairperson, along with Br. M. Abou-Sabe as the president, headed a fund-raising event at Ramada Inn in East Windsor. Dr. Maher Hatoot was the guest speaker. Needless to say, the community response was great. In the 1990s, Br. Syed Moinuddin took over the chairmanship of the fund- raising committee and continued to hold many more fund-raising events.

In 1993, the Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI) began functioning on the ISCJ premises using the existing ISCJ rooms as classrooms, which they shared with weekend school on the weekends. With the instant overwhelming success of, and demand for, NUI, the school had to add three modular units (trailers) in the 1990s to use those for classes, laboratories, computer rooms, and offices. With an ever-expanding enrollment, even that was not enough. To alleviate the overcrowding, in the mid-2000s, Br.

Abdel-Rehim Riad provided a new facility for NUI on a nearby location on Route 1 North. This led the ISCJ board to start developing a plan to build a proper school building to house the NUI and the weekend school on the ISCJ premises. By this time, an adjacent property, which had been purchased by Br. Mahmoud Taher, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, and Dr. Zuhair Abbasi, was donated to the ISCJ.

In 2006, a business expansion plan was initiated by Br. Aly Aziz, then president of the ISCJ, to study the feasibility of building the multimillion-dollar school project. Other key members included Br. Salim Manzar, Dr. Helmi Saud, Dr. Mohamed Esseghir, Br. Mike Conaboy, Dr. Sogra Saleem, and Br. Khalid Ozair. In addition, in 2007, an outside fund-raising consultant, Ruotolo Associates Inc., was brought in to help in a planning study for raising the necessary funds. The consultants conducted interviews of the ISCJ members and the NUI parents to gauge the interest of the community. This started the official expansion funding group. One of the salient features was to target major donors and have them sponsor classrooms, science labs, art rooms, and administrative offices. By 2008, this plan was in motion and had an enthusiastic response from the ISCJ community. An estimated $10 million was collected just for the school building. A donor tree was erected later in the new school lobby to recognize these donors.

Concurrently, the burial preparation house was completed with the help of a few generous donors. At every step of expansion, parking lots also had to be expanded to satisfy the South Brunswick Township regulations. Several prominent speakers, including Br. Hamza Yusuf, Br. Jamal Badawi, Br. Ahmed Sakr, Br. Siraj Wahaj, Br. Ghassan Hatoot, Br. Maher Hatoot, Br. Talal Eid, Br. Bakash, Br. Sohaib Webb, Br. Yusuf Estes, Br. Zulfiqar, and Br. Yasir Qadi, have graced our fund-raising events.

In 2010, a community loan program was started, where some members loaned up to $30,000 to ISCJ to help pay for the projects. Suffice to say that by 2016, most of these loans have been paid back by the ISCJ.

Soon, a younger group of fund-raisers emerged, which included Br. Sohail Pirzada, Br. Mujibur Rehman, Br. Fayez Azeez, Br. Babar Saeed, Br. Junaideen Fahumy, Br. Sherief Battat, Br. Khattab Abu Attieh, Br. Faisal Masood, Br. Amr Hilal, and Br. Arif Khan. In 2014, under the leadership of Br. S. Battat, a cruise around New York City took place, which received great reviews. Also under the leadership of Sr. Omayma Mansour and Dr. Sogra Saleem, an art gala was held, which turned out to be a memorable event.

The ISCJ's fund-raising events took place in big hotels, school cafeterias, and on our own ISCJ premises. At the ISCJ, all Ramadan

activities were organized to help this growing community with all the projects. Throughout all these years, at all these events, the unity of purpose among the ISCJ members and their generosity were on display. This provides us hope for continuation of such successful efforts, assuring a bright future for the ISCJ.

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Preamble: Acquisition of Land Parcels and Properties

Br. Dawud Assad

In the beginning, the ISCJ tried hard to purchase a building from Rutgers University, or one of their properties, but to no avail. Then Brs. Dawud Assad, Nabil Taha, and Suhail Rifai started to look for other places, such as churches or existing buildings in Downtown New Brunswick or in East Brunswick, again without any success.

Ultimately, a piece of land measuring 6.41 acres, located at the junction of U.S. Route 1 South and Stouts Lane, roughly equidistant from Princeton University and Rutgers University and the cities of Trenton and New Brunswick, was found It was less than fifty miles from Downtown New York and Downtown Philadelphia. Because of its central location, we hoped that many Muslim families would be attracted to come and live in the nearby housing developments. The purchase price was $75,000. The realtor was Br. Omar Boraie, who very generously waived his commission and sold it to us for $70,000. This parcel of land was bought on April 24, 1979.

The site is located in proximity to the Princeton Christian Theological Seminary, one of the largest in the world and a center of many international conferences in the region, including a conference on religion and peace in 1979. This proximity to seminary offers the ISCJ an excellent opportunity to promote a better understanding of Islam among peoples of other faiths.

Zoning variance for the construction of the ISCJ was granted by the local township of South Brunswick in March 1979. Land survey, architectural design, and various other requirements and fees, including permits for the construction for the ISCJ and a mosque, were completed

in June 1979. There were some objections from some neighbors against the building of the ISCJ. These were overcome by inviting them for a private briefing. The majority of them voted in favor of the ISCJ at the following township meeting.

The first building committee meeting was held with Mr. Leo Mahony, AIA for Mahony & Zvosec, Architects & Planners, at 621 Alexander Road, Princeton, NJ 08540 on April 26, 1979.

The building committee was composed of Br. Dawud Assad as chairman and Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, Br. Hakim K. Irfani, Dr. Suhail Rifai, and Br. Salim Baig as members (ref. Mr. Mahony meeting minutes dated April 26, 1979, Thursday, in his office).

The committee discussed the required areas to be constructed, such as the prayer room, multipurpose room, classrooms, library, toilet facilities, and storage and mechanical rooms.

Then the idea of purchasing additional pieces of land and properties around the society came from Br. Abdel-Rehim A. Riad. This was to make sure that the adjacent properties could not be purchased by undesirable businesses, such as taverns or pubs, in close vicinity of the ISCJ. Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad paid $450,000 from his own pocket as a donation to the ISCJ for the purpose of buying neighborhood homes and additional 4.5 acres of land for the future full-time school. Properties were also bought for the imam, burial preparation, and so on. As of now, the ISCJ has acquired about 17.5 acres of land. In 2001, the society started to work on a master plan for developing this land. A lawyer and architecture/engineering firms were hired to prepare necessary plans and documents to obtain approval from the township and permits to build.

Preamble: Imams Since the Beginning of the ISCJ

Br. Dawud Assad

As many questions were being raised by the ISCJ members at the seminars about the several Islamic services needed by the ISCJ members, the need for an imam became acute. The ISCJ approached Rabitat Office (Muslim World League Office to United Nations [MWL] in New York), where Br. Dawud Assad was the assistant director and a founding member of the Supreme World Council of Masjid (WCM), headquartered in Makkah al-Mukarramah, Saudi Arabia, and president of the local Council of Masjid of USA (CMUS), and requested his help in this matter.

1. Ahmed M. H. Sharkawy

Imam Ahmed M.H.Sharkawy, an Egyptian imam, who was on the payroll of Rabitat Office, was brought from Canada to the ISCJ and was given an apartment in Whispering Woods Apartments located nearby the society. He served the community for about six months. Then because of his health issues, he decided to return to his family in Canada and from there back to Egypt.

2. Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli

Imam Chebli, originally from Lebanon, came to the United States in March 1982 with other nine imams who also came from Lebanon, all on the payroll of Muslim World League (Rabitat al-Alam al-Islami). Br. Dawud Assad was assigned to locate all these imams to various masjid (mosques) in the USA and Canada. He assigned Br. Hamad Chebli to the Islamic center in New Orleans, Louisiana.

After serving four years in New Orleans, a request came from the ISCJ for an imam to replace Imam Ahmed M.H.Sharkawy Br. Dawud Assad was approached by Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, and Br. Dawud Assad suggested the name of Br. Hamad Chebli.

After the arrangements were made by Brs. Dawud Assad and Abdel-Rehim Riad, Imam Chebli joined the Islamic Society of Central Jersey, known as the ISCJ, in June 1986 as a religious director and is still there to this day.

As far as the qualification of Br. Imam Chebli is concerned, he spent his elementary and secondary years in the city of Tripoli, Lebanon, and then traveled to Egypt, receiving his undergraduate degree in Islamic studies and his master's degree in Islamic canonical law from Al-Azhar University in Cairo. He holds a high license in the principles of religion, section of doctrine and philosophy.

Since joining the ISCJ, he has published texts on Islam and religion in various journals and newspapers, including the *Star Ledger*, *Home News Tribune*, *Central Post*, *Communicator*, *Courier News*, *Noor-Ul-Islam*, and the *Message*.

For his other activities, Imam Hamad Chebli was appointed to the Governor's Leadership Summit on diversity. Also, he joined other panelists in speaking to a crowd of more than four hundred people about Islam, followed by a meeting with then governor of New Jersey Christie Whitman. Imam Chebli was also appointed by the mayor of North and South Brunswick to the diversity committee, a group asked to go into churches, Synagogues, public schools, and town meetings to promote diversity.

His activities and duties as an imam and religious leader at the ISCJ include, but is not limited to, daily prayers, Friday prayers, Eid prayers, funeral prayers and services, Saturday and Sunday Children's Islamic School, Khatme al-Qur'an, Qur'anic studies on weekends (Saturday and Sunday), matrimonial introductions, wedding services, newborn baby services, and Islamic arbitration and counseling. In addition, he visits hospitals, schools, colleges, and universities and participates in interfaith meetings.

Preamble: ISCJ-NUI Relationship

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI) is a full-time Islamic school with a traditional American curriculum and an emphasis on good morals, scholarship, and good citizenship of the United States. It opened in 1993 with twenty-seven children from pre-K to grade 2 on ISCJ's masjid premises. It was incorporated in the state of New Jersey in 1993. Since then, it has grown by leaps and bounds, currently boasting a five-hundred-plus student population, offering classes from pre-K to twelfth grade. From a few rooms at the masjid in 1993, NUI now features a full-fledged permanent school building on the ISCJ premises.

In 1993, the two entities authorized a task force headed by Br. Shoukat Ali to look into ISCJ-NUI working relationship. The task force recommended that NUI adopt a "subsidiary relationship" with the ISCJ. This proposal was originally agreed to by both the NUI Board of Directors and ISCJ Board of Trustees. However, for reasons that have not been documented, this arrangement did not materialize, and NUI and the ISCJ have remained independent, nonprofit, educational, and religious organizations, although NUI required that the parents of any Muslim student enrolled in NUI School have to be a voting member of and in good standing with the ISCJ.

Consequently, in September 9, 1993, there was a simple agreement between the ISCJ and NUI whereby NUI would utilize a section of the ISCJ building, paying a rental fee and utility fees. In January 1994, based on the ISCJ's 1993 fourth quarter financial reports, and a written request from NUI to waive rental charges, the ISCJ Board of Trustees granted

that request. In 1995, 1997, and 2000, three modular units were added to the ISCJ grounds to help alleviate the congestion in the classrooms for a growing population of students.

In a letter of agreement on February 4, 1996, both the ISCJ and NUI agreed to operate independently of each other while adhering to their constitution and bylaws separately. Both entities also had separate federal and state tax exempt identification numbers. One of the main reasons put forth for this arrangement was to avail of any state school funds for NUI available through the state of New Jersey. NUI also has a board of directors in addition to a school executive committee. After a detailed and extensive review by both entities, the initial agreement was signed on May 13, 2001. After that, there have been a couple more attempts at finalizing the memorandum of understanding (MOU) between the two organizations, the last one being in August 2012. The ISCJ and NUI are working to update the MOU to reflect current conditions for both organizations. An MOU is currently in effect.

The two organizations do have a cost-sharing plan in place. In 2006, the ISCJ put forth a master plan that included the construction of a school building in three phases. In 2012 and then in 2014, phase 1 and phase 2 were completed, respectively. Noor-Ul-Iman School now has a state-of-the-art school building. Phase 3 plans have changed, and it is pending. The ISCJ is going ahead with other expansion projects.

Both the ISCJ and NUI continue to work together despite lack of a formal agreement between the two. They collectively provide necessary educational and religious services to the community. May Allah guide these two Islamic institutions in all their endeavors.

Preamble: ISCJ's Development Plans – Past, Present, and Future

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

The Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) came into being about forty years ago in 1975. The ISCJ has come a long way since the days it was conceived in the minds of the early Muslims who migrated from different parts of the world to settle in New Jersey. They conceptualized the ISCJ as it stands today. The society continues to manifest their vision of an institution where Muslims and non-Muslims would go to seek true knowledge of Islam from its resident and visiting imams, resident teachers, and visiting scholars from well-known institutions in the United States and abroad.

To implement the vision of the founders and pioneers of the ISCJ, a constitution was adopted that outlined the responsibilities of the board of trustees, which included planning for multifaceted development of the ISCJ. This required that the board of trustees plan to purchase and develop additional lands and engage engineering and architectural firms and contractors to design and build the facilities to provide religious and educational services for the growing Muslim community.

Over the last forty years, the ISCJ has always made plans for the future, to expand the facility physically and provide additional programs and services for the growing Muslim community. In the early 1980s, there was a long-range planning committee that took into consideration what projects should be implemented and in what order. That is how the first construction of the multipurpose room, along with the classrooms,

took place in 1983, followed by the masjid in 1990. After that, Noor-Ul-Iman School came into existence in 1993. In 1995, 1997, and 2000, three modular units were added to provide room for increasing number of students and their activities. During this period, adjacent properties on Richard Road were acquired as well.

In 2006, a master plan for the entire 16.54 acres was prepared by the ISCJ and submitted to the South Brunswick Township Zoning Board. This included a 40,000 square feet of office space, 87,000 square feet of a two-story school building, 10,700 square feet addition to the existing masjid structure, 612 parking spaces, and the conversion of Lot 16 dwelling into a burial preparation home, retention basins, and new access driveways. The master plan was approved.

In 2009, a fully functional burial preparation home came into existence. In 2012, the ISCJ completed phase 1 of the Noor-Ul-Iman School building, which was followed in 2014 by the completion of phase 2. In 2016, the work on the renovation and expansion of the masjid began and is still under way. All these projects were accomplished primarily through the generous donations from the local ISCJ community.

In 2014, a steering committee was established to help the ISCJ board identify, evaluate, and prioritize options from a range of prudent alternatives related to the ISCJ's overall master plan for the future. In 2015, approximately eleven alternatives were presented to the ISCJ board. After much deliberation, two main options emerged.

1. A 40,000 square feet sports facility should be built instead of the office building as it was determined by the steering committee that an office building may not be sufficiently leased out to provide reliable revenue as there was already surplus office space available in the area. This indoor facility will be temperature-controlled so it could be utilized throughout the year. The sports facility will house several sports, including basketball and badminton courts and soccer and lacrosse fields. This will offer much-needed space for sports and will bring in revenue to the ISCJ. The possibility of getting interested investors both from within and outside the ISCJ community is being explored. The general members of the ISCJ community will not be required to fund this project with their donations.
2. A senior housing complex is being proposed behind the Noor-Ul-Iman School building with one- and two-bedroom units. This will consist of forty-four units that will be available for purchase at competitive market rates. The viability of private investors or

owners from the ISCJ community buying these units is being evaluated before construction of these units so that the general membership would not be required to fund this project.

The Noor-Ul-Iman School phase 3 is to be revised to add fifteen additional classrooms instead of the auditorium. The NUI parking lot has been transformed into a solar carport.

Besides the physical expansion of the existing facilities, the number of working committees has increased to over twenty. These committees manage various functions of the ISCJ, such as fund-raising, schooling, youth development, and so on.

In 2012, the ISCJ hired Sheikh Ismael Essa as the director of the Qur'an Academy to teach Tahfeeth al-Qur'an to students. For the last six years, Sheikh Ismael has been leading the Taraweeh prayers during Ramadan in his superb Tajweed.

Dr. Ahmed Mohamed, a resident director for Youth and Young Adults, was hired in 2017 as a permanent addition to the ISCJ staff.

The ISCJ website and Facebook have been in operation for a few years. A donation kiosk and TV advertisement are available for professionals and businesses. Security has become a major concern. The security system is being constantly updated and staffed around the clock.

In summary, we have ambitious plans for the ISCJ. The future looks bright, by Allah's grace. Long live the ISCJ! May Allah help and guide us to accomplish these objectives. Ameen!

Preamble: ISCJ Newspaper Key Articles

Br. Arif Khan

This chapter provides the reader with a chance to revisit key articles from local newspapers that covered news about the ISCJ over the years. The ISCJ also advertised in the local newspapers, such as the *Star Ledger*, the *Times of Trenton*, the *Home News Tribune*, and the *South Brunswick Post* and also in the *New York Times* on occasions, such as the September 11, 2001, event.

Most of these articles were collected by Imam Chebli over the years. The imam loaned them to the history project task force for scanning them. The task force hired volunteers to cut out the relevant text and photos and scan them to 8.5" X 11" size and store them on an ISCJ computer. This was a herculean task that was accomplished under the supervision of Sr. Sogra Saleem and Br. Arif Khan, who recruited and closely directed several volunteers over the span of about two years. Since the existing printer/copier was not up to the task, a new copier/scanner was purchased to facilitate this effort.

Some of the articles are related to the following:

1. Government officials (local and national) visiting ISCJ – ISCJ has hosted candidates running for various offices in the South Brunswick Township, New Jersey, state and federal governments to come and talk to the members. These were candidates from all the political parties.
2. The ISCJ took out a full-page advertisement in the *Star Ledger*, condemning the 9/11 terror attacks in its immediate aftermath.

Also, personal interviews with the ISCJ board and its members were published in various papers.

Our then congressman Rush Holt called the ISCJ immediately after 9/11, offered help, and asked the South Brunswick and state police to offer the ISCJ extra protection.

3. Starting in 2005, the ISCJ took out ads in the above four newspapers, greeting Americans on the Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha occasions.
4. During and after the expansion of the NUI School, several articles were written in *Home News Tribune* and the *South Brunswick Post* that supported the school expansion.
5. The articles covered the interfaith programs with neighboring churches and synagogues and visits from neighboring seminaries to the ISCJ.
6. "Muslims Making a Home in NJ" provides interesting reading as to how newly arrived Muslims gradually settled in various towns in New Jersey.
7. ISCJ members and Noor-Ul-Iman students volunteering at the South Brunswick Library, Elijah's Promise Soup Kitchen in New Brunswick, and Trenton Area Soup Kitchen.
8. Interviews with imam on Islam.
9. Articles about Muslims living in the South Brunswick.
10. Articles about Muslims' response to post 9/11 security measures.
11. Supporting refugees from other countries.

Preamble: ISCJ's Miscellaneous Documents

Br. Arif Khan

Over the years, numerous documents associated with the ISCJ have been created that have historical significance. We have tried to gather and place those in specifically named directories. However, as creating a separate directory relating to each specific subject would result in too many folders, each containing only one to two files, we created a "Miscellaneous Documents" directory to store such variety of documents. Some of the documents in this directory include

- ISCJ building dedications,
- endowment,
- construction documents with Worthington Associates, and
- documents with Mahoney Architects

Background Information:

The Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) (www.iscj.org) has its origins in the early 1970s and was started by four Muslim students from Rutgers University and four families from the university environs. By the early 1980s, ISCJ had organized itself as a membership-based, nonprofit, religious, and educational organization receiving its 501 (c)(3) IRS tax-exempt status and procuring a parcel of land on the corner of Stouts Lane and Route 1 in South Brunswick, New Jersey. Over the years, that parcel of land has been expanded to encompass 17 acres, and the ISCJ campus

currently includes a 12,000-square-foot masjid and administration and social activities building; a 49,000-square-foot permanent school building that serves the society's 600 weekend school students and also houses the society's full-time (parochial) school and (pre-K to 12), Noor-Ul-Iman (www.nuischool.org), a national leader in Islamic education going on twenty-three years; an outdoor basketball court; an athletic field and playground; several modular units; a multiple location parking lot consisting of 200 paved and 110 unpaved spaces; several residential homes; and a Muslim funeral services burial preparation facility.

ISCJ, owing to the centrality of its geographic location, as well as the great work of many of its more than 1,200 members and visionary leadership over the years, is widely recognized and acknowledged by both Muslims (here and abroad) and non-Muslims (including state- and national-elected officials and governmental agencies) as one of New Jersey's flagship masjids and its long-serving Imam Hamad Chebli as a leading religious figure in the tristate area and nation.

In terms of its concern for the natural world, greening its ecological practices and environmental stewardship (*khulafa'al-ard*), ISCJ has also been a leader in the larger NY-NJ-PA metropolitan area. The specific environmental programming and activities of the society can be categorized into the following areas:

1. Facilities

The facilities of the society are being developed in stages according to the township-approved master plan for the society. This plan, whose planning and implementation is managed and overseen by the society's building committee, made up of professionals from a wide variety of fields and disciplines and focuses on how to best plan, design, and manage the facilities in an efficient way in terms of maximum utilization of land use while at the same time balancing and paying close attention to lessening environmental impact and promoting sustainability in the context of the greater community and environment of which the society is a part of. To these ends, ISCJ recognizes that the long-term success of the society is not only dependent upon the strength of its spiritual and moral core but is also directly linked to the environment, the surrounding community, and the health and safety of its members. The society has sought to incorporate green building ideas and principles in terms of the design and systems servicing its new constructions, like the recently constructed permanent school building (49,000 square feet), which incorporates

LEED (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design) green building principles requirements, including the following:

- SMART building technology that includes energy-reducing, multi-tier, computerized HVAC controllers that operate the direct digital control (DDC) system and CFL lighting throughout the school building, modular units, and masjid building that is motion detector controlled and reduces traditional lighting energy costs/ usage by up to 60 percent.
- Installation of Elkay drinking fountains with water bottle filling stations and a bottle counter. The average American uses (and throws out) 167 disposable water bottles a year (only recycling 38 of them). Since installation, the two drinking fountains in the school and the one in the masjid building have, according to the bottle counter, resulted in saving of couple of hundreds of water bottles from being thrown out.
- Installation throughout the school building (including in the wudu areas) of high-tech water faucets that use motion detection to start the water flow when hands are detected beneath the spout. This results in the preservation of water because of the automatic shut off valve, which stops the flow when movement is no longer detected. In addition, the spread of bacteria is also greatly reduced because it eliminates the necessity of contact with dirty hands. This technology is coupled with low-flow faucet aerators that make use of as little as 0.5–1.5 gallons a minute. This is in comparison with traditional faucets, which can use 2.75 gallons per minute of use. Installation of high- efficiency toilets.
- ISCJ has also retrofitted all its 25 parking lot pole lights with LED fixtures that replaced the previous 400-watt HPS fixtures.
- The society has just begun construction on a $1.1 million solar panel installation project. This important sustainability project, which includes installation of solar panels over the entire roof of the new school building and much of the parking lot (via solar car ports canopies), is projected to produce enough renewable solar- generated electricity to power the entire school building and then some. In addition to the projected energy savings of this project, this will also significantly reduce what has been called the urban heat island effect in which cities are hotter than the surrounding areas, which results from asphalt and concrete's absorption of the sun's energy.
- Greenscaping/landscaping: ISCJ, in keeping with environmental concerns and requirements, has chosen to construct two

bottom- lined "wet pond" water retention basins as part of its storm water management system. In comparison with dry ponds (which hold runoff for a limited period and then release the stored water at once), these types of retention basins constantly keep standing water, allowing the development of a new habitat and ecosystem. This also allows settled particles to be treated biologically. As a natural system, these types of retention basins do not need energy or high- tech appliances. According to the EPA (Environmental Protection Agency), wet ponds (aka storm water ponds, wet retention ponds, and wet extended detention ponds) are constructed basins that have a permanent pool of water throughout the year (or at least throughout the wet season). Ponds treat incoming storm water runoff by allowing particles to settle and algae to take up nutrients. The primary removal mechanism is settling as storm water runoff resides in this pool, and pollutant uptake, particularly of nutrients, also occurs through biological activity in the pond. Traditionally, wet ponds have been widely used as storm water best management practices.

- In addition, in the larger of the two ponds, ISCJ has installed two aerating fountains that are not only aesthetically pleasing but also provide for water aeration. The water is being splashed and exposed to the air to provide dissolved oxygen and vent gases from the water. Oxygen is the key ingredient in any healthy water environment. Dissolved oxygen in the water is essential for aquatic life, such as fish, insects, bacteria, aquatic plants, and so on. Without proper levels of oxygen, a pond will not be able to support life and serve as a healthy ecosystem. This is even more important when discussing a retention pond. As discussed, retention ponds are collecting runoff pollutants and debris from the surrounding areas, holding that extra water, cleaning the water, and releasing it back into the ground, streams, wetlands, and so on. Proper aeration is vital for the retention pond to settle, filter, and use up the pollutants that enter during runoff.

2. Environmental Programming

Since 2011, ISCJ has set up various informational and educational programming for its members not only for adults but also for youth and children designed to raise awareness of environmental issues/concerns, disseminate Islam's teachings regarding the environment, and encourage

eco-friendly practices in keeping with those teachings. To these ends, ISCJ has done the following:

- Hosted Green Muslims of New Jersey's (GMNJ) first inaugural inter-masjid seminar and workshop on its Green Ramadan Initiative (GRI) in June 2011.
- Was among the first three masjids in New Jersey to sing a MOU and formally participate in the Green Muslims of New Jersey (GMNJ) Green Ramadan Initiative (GRI) program (see attached PowerPoint slides for details on GMNJ GRI, the GRI Pledge, and the MOU) beginning in Ramadan 2011 and continuing every year since until the present. ISCJ also joined this year (2015) in the ISNA Masjid Task Force Ramadan Greening Masjid initiative.
- Was highlighted as a pioneering Green Ramadan masjid in the first ever nationally broadcast Green Ramadan Webinar, jointly organized by Green Muslims of New Jersey (GMNJ) and Green Faith in July 2011.
- Participated every year beginning in 2011 in various Earth Day and Arbor Day activities, including planting of trees.
- Encouraged community members to regularly participate in the *Mashee* regularly organized and guided nature hikes by Green Muslims of New Jersey (GMNJ).
- Conducted Salatul Eid Ul Adha – 2015 (1436 AH) outside in a park for the first time in recent memory in keeping with the Sunna of Eid (Eid Gaah).
- Applied and is in the final stages of completing all the requirements and receiving the Green Faith Water Shield, thereby, inshallah, making ISCJ the first masjid in the NJ-NY-PA metropolitan area to receive this important recognition and coveted award. The goal of this program is to educate and marshal religious communities to reduce water consumption and protect water quality and, in turn, receive recognition for their efforts once those steps have been completed. Turning a faith-based community into a "blue" leader requires a top-to-bottom approach to water conservation. It is as important to teach and preach about the issue as it is to carry out action steps in the home and within the facility (see an article that mentioned ISCJ's efforts in this regard: http://blog.grdodge. org/2014/05/20/green-faith-institutions-take-on-water-conservation-in-their-communities/).

Preamble: ISCJ Personal Video Interviews

Sr. Dawlat Chebly

Originally, the plan for the history book did not include video interviews as we did not know of anyone who would have the necessary equipment, skill, and time to devote to this activity on voluntary basis. Imam Chebli suggested that we contact Sr. Dawlat Chebly, who did video interviews at her college. So we invited Sister Dawlat to become part of the history project task force, and she accepted our invitation, and the process began in earnest.

We did not have a professional-grade movie camera. Sister Dawlat proposed buying a quality camera and gave us the specifications. We purchased the suggested camera. It turned out to be the easy part of the process; the real challenge she faced was in scheduling video sessions with the founders of the ISCJ and other significant contributors to the ISCJ over the fort-plus years of the ISCJ since its conception in the early 1970s. It was difficult to schedule these video interviews as most people were busy, and some had moved out of the state. Several interviews would be scheduled then cancelled and rescheduled. It was a frustrating experience.

Once Sister Dawlat finished interviewing, she needed to stitch all the interviews on a computer, which required 12 GB memory, and 1TB hard drive, and 15.6-inch screen. Since the ISCJ did not have the necessary equipment, we borrowed the required computer, and the final video was completed for review.

After three years of research, contacting original members and conducting interviews, the Islamic Society of Central Jersey is able to present to you a fifty-minute documentary about the history of the ISCJ.

This documentary includes details about how it all started, the struggles that we faced, what it took to find a location, and the beginning of the building process as well as so much more. This documentary allows the original board members themselves to tell the ISCJ community the story of the ISCJ, starting with how it all began. After forty long years of developing a society, it is finally time to share our story. Hope you will like it.

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A Tribute To The Founding Member Br. Mahmoud Taher, PhD

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD, Br. Dawud Assad, and Imam Hamad Chebli

Dr. Sogra Saleem writes: The name Dr. Mahmoud Taher is synonymous with the ISCJ. Dr. Taher came to the United States in the 1950s and was associated with one of the oldest mosque in the USA located in Cedar Rapids, Iowa. He moved to Central New Jersey in the early 1970s and became involved with the ISCJ from its inception. He was one of the very few handful original founding members who were instrumental in the formation and shaping of the ISCJ. He is considered by some to be the "Father of the ISCJ."

One of the earliest tasks of the ISCJ was to form a board of trustees with the trustees elected by the membership. Dr. Taher acted as an overseer to conduct the elections. From this point on, the elections became an annual event and continue to be so to this day. During the Rutgers period of the ISCJ, Dr. Taher acted as the principal for Sunday weekend school. He also helped coordinate the adult seminars after the Qur'an Tafseer. He often ended up as the seminar speaker himself. He also recruited qualified members as teachers.

In 1990, Dr. Taher was elected to the ISCJ Board of Trustees and became president for one year. The next year, he resigned from the board. During this time, I had the pleasure of working with him and came to know him as a man of principle with high moral ethics, generosity, and simple living.

In the 1980s, Dr. Taher financially assisted the ISCJ to purchase the house at 28 Richard Road with other contributors. He gave the ISCJ full

access to it for holding regular BOT meeting and some committee meetings. In addition, he let the senior weekend school class to be conducted there by Sr. Mary Moslimany and Br. Saffet Catovic. My daughter was one of the beneficiaries of this class. Dr. Taher donated many of his personal books to start the ISCJ library. He was a professor of entomology and taught at Middlesex County Community College, New Jersey, till he retired and decided to go back to his native Egypt to spend his golden years there. He recently expired. May Allah reward him for all his good deeds. Ameen.

Br. Dawud Assad adds: My dearest brother Dr. Mahmoud Taher will never vanish from my memory. Whatever I write, I know I will not be able to do justice to him or to his accomplishments. As Sister Sogra said, many in the ISCJ consider him to be the "Father of the ISCJ."

Dr. Taher was a member of one of the oldest Islamic organizations in the USA by the name of Federation of Islamic Associations (FIA) in the USA and Canada, established in 1952 in Cedar Rapids, Iowa, by one of the Ajram (Igram) family there. Most of its members were born in the USA and encompassed American Muslim Associations in Detroit, Dearborn, Toledo, Michigan, New York, New Jersey, Toronto, Calgary, Montreal, and British Columbia in Canada. They had little knowledge of Islam. Dr. Mahmoud Taher educated them by giving lectures and taught them about the fundamentals of Islam.

Dr. Taher left Cedar Rapids and came to New Jersey in the early 1970s. I found him a house in Metuchen, New Jersey, and both of us joined the YMCA in this town. We used to go swimming on weekends and then from there to Main Street in Metuchen for a restaurant that served nice ice cream. Dr. Taher loved ice cream very much.

Then Dr. Taher took up an offer from Middlesex County Community College, New Jersey, to teach entomology and taught at the college for a long time until he retired and returned to his native Egypt.

I want to share a story about Dr. Taher and ice cream. My wife and I happened to be in Cairo, Egypt, when Dr. Taher was sick and was staying in the military hospital, where his brother worked, just ten days before he passed away (Rahim ahu Allah). An Egyptian relative of Br. Syed Hassan, the ISCJ administrator, drove us to the hospital to visit Dr. Taher there. Dr. Taher's brother was there too, and he was holding a small paper cup filled with ice cream to feed Dr. Taher. Dr. Taher refused to take the ice cream from his brother. His brother tried hard to feed him but to no avail. So I told Dr. Taher's brother to give the cup to me and that I would try to feed it to Dr. Taher. He did, and then I took a spoon's scoop from the cup and told Dr Taher, "This is very delicious, better than the ice cream that you and I had from the Metuchen restaurant in Main Street, where we used

to eat." Then all of a sudden, Dr. Taher opened his mouth widely and ate all the ice cream I gave him very quickly. Everybody who was there was surprised to see this, and his brother told me, "I never saw him eat that ice cream so fast before! Are you a saint?" Then I explained to him what we used to do when Dr. Taher was with us in New Jersey.

Let me add that Dr. Taher used to go to Middlesex County Community College on a bicycle for more than three years before he was given a used car that he did not like. (That was my car!) Dr. Taher also went to Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, along with Brs. Abdul Hakim Babar and Suhail Rifai to ask for help in Ramadan.

Lastly, Dr. Taher and I used to go over the weekends to Paterson, New Jersey, in the 1980s to teach Islam and Arabic language to the weekend school students there at the Chestnut Street School.

May Almighty Allah (SWT) bless the soul of Dr. Mahmoud Taher and let him enter Jannat al-Firdous! Ameen!

Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli quotes some sayings of Dr. Mahmoud Taher: "Do not come to the ISCJ with your ego." "Do not point your finger at another person; if you do, three of your own fingers will be pointing at you!" "It is easy to start a small or big project, but it is very difficult to stay in it to the end." "Try to share with others any small or big gift."

The imam adds: Dr. Taher had the first key to the ISCJ. Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli still has that golden key. Many Muslim and non-Muslim families came to Islam through the efforts of Dr. Taher. His family in the United States and in Egypt used to visit him at 28 Richard Road for months. After he fell sick, and before he left for Egypt for good, the ISCJ held a dinner in his honor. Brs. Abdul Hamid Ramadan, Fathy Mousa, and Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli escorted Dr. Taher inside the Egyptian Airline plane to make sure he was fit to fly to Egypt. After a year, he was able to visit the ISCJ again, and that was his last visit to the USA. Dr. Taher used to stay with Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli's family at 28 Richard Road, Monmouth Junction, NJ. Muhammad Hamad Chebli visited Dr. Taher in Cairo during a wedding of the Ramadan family. May Allah bless the soul of Dr. Mahmoud Taher!



Islamic Society of Central Jersey – My Recollection of Events (1977–1987)

Br. Abdul Hakim Babar, MD

It was a chilly December evening in December of 1977 that I received a call from my dear friend Dr. Bilal A. Mian from Somerset, New Jersey. He told me about the Islamic Society of Central Jersey and many of its members in New Brunswick area who were holding regular Sunday meetings and classes for Muslim children in Rutgers University campus. He also mentioned that they wished to have a place of their own and were considering buying a property but were short of funds. He suggested that I gather many of my Muslim friends in Trenton, New Jersey, area and assist this group in this project. A meeting for this purpose was being held the same evening, and I was invited to participate.

Both of us attended this meeting, and I met several members of the group, including Dawud Assad, Dr. Sohail Rifai, Dr. Taher, Dr. Elsaady, Abdul-Rehim A. Riad, and at least three others whose names I cannot recollect. We had a very long discussion about the Islamic society and future of our growing children. We discussed possibilities of buying a modest property for a Muslim community center for prayers and school for children. Considering that there were very few Muslim families living in the vicinity of New Brunswick, and most of us wishing not to take *riba*-based loan from banks, the options to buy any existing property with full down payment did not seem feasible. It was decided to form a committee to look for various options and hopefully invite participation of Muslim families living in Greater Trento area as well.

Alhamdulillah, the response from our brothers and sisters in Trenton area was very encouraging. A fund-raising and pledge campaign was started, and many of us started exploring different options. After several meetings and discussion, two options were considered very seriously. The first option was to buy a house near Rutgers University in a residential neighborhood and convert it into a community center. Mr. Omar Boraie, a realtor by profession and a member of community, presented the second option, a six-and-a-half-acre land available on Route 1 located midway between Trenton and New Brunswick in South Brunswick Township for a price of $70,000.

A long discussion spread over several meetings ensued regarding the pros and cons of each option. The first option had the risk of objection by the local municipality and denial of variance to conduct large gatherings in a residential neighborhood. Furthermore, there was very little flat land available for any outdoor activities by the kids. It was also pointed out that our community is expanding rapidly and this option will not be able to sustain for too long. The second option seemed better for the long-term future of our expanding community and also allowing us enough ground space to start a modest project and later expand it. The problem with this option was lack of enough funds to buy the land and immediately proceed with construction. By a narrow margin of one extra vote, the members very wisely opted for the second option to buy the land on which the existing Islamic center was built.

Our immediate issue was to raise approximately $30,000 to buy this parcel of land without loan. To our surprise and pleasure, this amount was raised within no time from several physicians in Trenton area, and the deal was finalized.

Encouraged by a very positive response by the community, we all proceeded to raise funds both within and outside our community for the construction of Islamic center to be named Islamic Society of Central Jersey. Frequent fund-raising functions were held for the purpose. My wife, Mumtaz, along with many other ladies, was instrumental in organizing a women's auxiliary for fund-raising events.

A committee was formed to select an architect and plan a phased construction project. Members of this committee included me, Dawud Assad, Sohail Rifai, and Omar Boraie. After a thorough search, we picked the architectural firm of Mahoney & Associates of Princeton, New Jersey. The architects were provided pictures of our holy mosques and several other mosques around the world to plan the project. Many plans were made and modified by the architects to come up with the last plans that included a basement and main floor. The main level consisted of a multipurpose

community hall, classrooms, and mosque. A central lobby was designed between the mosque and the meeting hall. Plans were made such that mosque, lobby, and meeting hall could be converted into one long stretch of space to accommodate approximately eight hundred people for Jummah or Eid prayers.

Our fund-raising efforts got a sudden boost because of a donation of $250,000 by Rabitat al-Alam al-Islami (Muslim World League) with efforts of Br. Dawud Assad. A comprehensive fund-raising campaign included an elaborate brochure outlining the community and our project. A campaign was launched throughout the USA and abroad. Funds started pouring in from all over. In those days, there were very few Islamic centers in the USA. We were competing with similar projects in New York, Toledo, Iowa, Chicago, and Los Angeles for donations from Muslim communities. Alhamdulillah, our efforts were bearing fruit. During this phase, we also planned a trip to Saudi Arabia for fund-raising. It was a three-week activity in Saudi Arabia arranged by Dawud Assad. Dr. Mahmoud Taher, Dr. Sohail Rifai, and I made this important trip during the month of Ramadan, and by the grace of Allah (SWT), we were able to raise close to $200,000. With close to $700,000 in our account, we decided to proceed with the construction. A contractor was selected, and a groundbreaking ceremony was held.

In a project of this nature involving people from varied backgrounds, there are always some hitches. Our project was not an exception. We did not have enough funds to complete the entire project. It was decided to complete it in two phases. There was a controversy among board members as to whether we should build the mosque or community center and hall first. The matter could not be resolved between the board members, and it was decided to hold an urgent general body meeting for the final decision. After a hot debate, the membership decided in favor of building the school and community hall during first stage followed later by the construction of mosque. The secretary general of Rabitat al-Alam al-Islami (Muslim World League) and a large number of our community members finally started the project with a groundbreaking ceremony. This was a happy day for the entire community.

Early period of construction was also not without controversy. It may be interesting for current members of ISCJ to know that a basement was dug and had been almost completed when a few members of the executive committee led by an illustrious member (wish to withhold his name) raised serious objections, claiming risk of flooding of basement. This campaign was so intense that it was finally decided to fill the basement and proceed with the rest of the construction. I have always regretted giving in to this

demand with its wasted cost and loss of a very useful space for community events.

The first phase of construction was completed without any further problems or financial constraints. It was inaugurated (do not have recollection of exact date) by participation of entire community. A fund-raising function for the second phase of this project was held on the same evening at Holiday Inn, North Brunswick. By the grace of Almighty, donations of over $60,000 were pledged on that night for the second phase. I am thankful to Allah (SWT) to have graced me with the honor to lead ISCJ as its president during this critical period of its inception. My family and I moved to Lahore, Pakistan, in October 1987. I had the opportunity to visit the center last summer, and am very happy to see tremendous expansion of this project, including Islamic school, and, alhamdulillah, making of a very vibrant Muslim community. My appreciation for all senior members, young new families, and especially Imam Chebli for their persistent effort to develop Islamic community and center. Will be looking forward to visiting again in near future. May Allah (SWT) bless you all.

Abdul Hakim Babar, MD
Lahore, Pakistan

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Earliest Days of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey

Br. Suhail Rifai, PhD

It was between December 26, 1973, and January 1, 1974, that a meeting was held by five people who would eventually become the founding members of the ISCJ—Dawud Assad, Dr. Mahmoud Taher, Dr. Suhail Rifai, Izzeddin Assad, and Nabeel Taha. Nabeel Taha was a teacher in public high school, Suhail Rifai was a PhD in chemical engineering and was working for Bechtel Corporation, Dawud Assad was a mechanical engineer and was the director of administration of the Rabitat al-Alam al-Islami office in New York, Dr. Mahmoud Taher was a professor of entomology at Middlesex County Community College in Edison, New Jersey, and Izzeddin Assad owned a surveyor outfit.

We discussed the importance of Islamic education for our children. But the difficulty was that we were living far away from Rutgers University, where a weekend school for our children was being contemplated. It was difficult for the parents to drop off their kids at the school, go back home, and then come back to pick up their children after the classes ended. The abovementioned people decided to organize a seminar for the parents, along with the weekend school for the children in two classrooms. The seminar would compose of two parts: one for Qur'anic interpretation and the other for general subjects. Alhamdulillah, the weekend school opened in September 1974 at Rutgers with the help of Nabeel Taha, who was a teacher at the high school. People came from long distances, such as New York, Pennsylvania, and North and South New Jersey. Initially, we had some difficulty with Rutgers as the halls were not available at the time that we required them. Our classes started first at Scott Hall building located

on College Ave. in New Brunswick, New Jersey, at Rutgers University and then moved to the dormitory building on George Street, overlooking the river. Classes were held on Sunday mornings.

Nabeel Taha's wife, Sister Sharon, was the first one to volunteer to be the teacher. Sr. Farida Ali started a year later; other sisters followed later. I, Suhail Rifai, volunteered to be the seminar speaker. I would recite certain Qur'anic verses and explain its meaning. The second session of the seminar would address general subjects. Unless someone else volunteered to be the seminar speaker, I would conduct the seminars.

From the beginning, we had to focus on raising funds for our Islamic center. We went door to door to people, asking for their donations, but the collection was very meager.

Then we came to know that some Muslim Pakistani doctors in the Trenton area were interested in joining this group if they could participate in the administration of the project and if it could be located in a place easily accessible to both communities. The coordinator from the Trenton side was Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, a plastic surgeon who was practicing in Trenton. The money raised by the Trenton group was about $14,000. At that time, it was difficult to raise even $1,000. Many Muslims made great sacrifices to raise this amount of money individually. For example, Br. Dawud Assad took a loan against his house to contribute his share to the ISCJ project. The Trenton group that included Dr. Babar, Dr. Riaz Iqbal, and Dr. Hanif Choudhry donated about $14,000. Dr. Suhail Rifai contacted his personal friends in Saudi Arabia; they donated $11,000 through a friend, Br. Ahmed Khoraigi. Br. Suhail Rifai and Sr. Hanna Rifai went to see him at the Waldorf Astoria hotel in New York to collect the subject donation.

The Council of Masjids of USA donated $50,000. Br. Dawud Assad was the chairman of the subject council at that time. A copy of the historical check is attached at the end of this document.

The combined group from Rutgers and Trenton area chose the name of the new organization as the "Islamic Society of Central Jersey" (ISCJ). The ISCJ Constitution was drafted after reviewing several other local religious organizations' constitutions, including the World Council of Churches of America, obtained by Dawud Assad, the Constitution of the United States, the Constitution of the state of New Jersey, and so on.

The first president was elected by consensus before the constitution was formally adopted. Dr. Suhail Rifai was chosen as the first president of the society in 1975 from among the group of five people, namely, Suhail Rifai, Dawud Assad, Nabeel Taha, Issam Taha, and Mahmoud Taher. This election took place in the parking lot of Scott Hall, Rutgers University, as

we did not have any room besides the two rooms where Arabic language classes and Qur'an-related seminars were being conducted. After the incorporation of the ISCJ in 1975, Dr. Babar was elected as the first president and Br. Dawud Assad as the first chairman of the board.

It soon became apparent that the Muslim community could not depend on borrowed places, such as Rutgers' Scott Hall rooms, as the community was growing. The search for a suitable land started. All the core active members were looking for a place, including real estate broker Omar Boraie.

The group decided to send Dr. Babar, Dr. Suhail Rifai, and Dr. Taher to Saudi Arabia to collect funds for the project. Dawud Assad facilitated obtaining the visa and recommendation from the Rabitat and the Saudi consulate. This letter of recommendation was needed to present our credential to the prospective individual, nongovernmental donors in Saudi Arabia. A brochure describing the project was developed to be presented to the prospective donors. Rabitat paid for the hotel. Dr. Babar stayed for two weeks, and Dr. Suhail and Dr. Taher stayed for three weeks. They brought $130,000 with them, and an additional $40,000 was received from a few individuals later.

At this time, we focused on firming up the constitution of the new combined organization. The ones who were most instrumental were Dr. Nazeer Ahmed until 1978 when he moved to California, and then Dr. Shaikh Moizul Matin, and Br. Shoukat Ali until the constitution was finalized and adopted by the ISCJ general body in March 1981.

Dr. Suhail Rifai is a founding member of the ISCJ and its first president.



My Days with the ISCJ and Beyond

Br. Nazeer Ahmed, PhD

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed was born in Tumkur in the princely state of Mysore, India, in 1939 into a farming family. His father, Abdul Azeem, was an Islamic scholar in the Qadariya order. Nazeer achieved the first rank in the state in the public examination of 1952 and won the Maharaja of Mysore gold medal. In 1961, he proceeded to the California Institute of Technology as institute scholar and obtained his MS and AEE degrees in aeronautics from Caltech. In 1964–1965, he worked in Huntsville, Alabama, on the Saturn, Apollo and Lunar Land Rover Projects at the Marshall Space Flight Center. In 1967, he obtained a PhD in theoretical and applied mechanics from Cornell University. He studied management under Peter Drucker at New York University and obtained an MBA from Rider University, New Jersey.

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed was the president of the ISCJ in 1976–1977 and was instrumental in reorganizing the society and getting it registered in the state of New Jersey. In these efforts, he fondly recalls his associations with Dr. Taher, Dawud Assad, and Brs. Abdel-Rehim Riad and Abad Ahmed. In 1977, he returned briefly to India and was elected a member of the Karnataka Legislative Assembly. Between 1979 and 1982, he was a project manager on the Hubble Space Telescope, which enabled humankind to penetrate the edge of the known universe. Between 1984 and 1997, he was a program manager on several strategic and tactical programs of national importance. Nazeer holds twelve U.S. patents in advanced composites and space-based lasers.

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed was elected a delegate to the Democratic National Convention, Forty-Second Congressional District in California in 1988. He was a candidate for U.S. Congress, 46 CA Congressional District in the Democratic primaries of 1992.

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed has written an encyclopedia of Islamic history (www.historyofislam.com). His two-volume study *Islam in Global History* was published by Suhail Academy, Lahore, Pakistan, and was translated into Urdu. Currently, Dr. Nazeer Ahmed is the director of the American Institute of Islamic History and Culture in California and a senior advisor to the World Organization for Resource Development and Education in Washington, DC and to HMS Institute of Technology, India. In 2013, Dr. Ahmed was appointed a member of the State Knowledge Commission in Bangalore.

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed translated the Qur'an into easy-to-read American English. The translation was released by Imam Maulana Rashdi of Jami Masjid Bangalore. It is available on www.historyofislam.com and has been read by more than a million people around the globe.

In India, Dr. Ahmed set up a scholarship fund that has helped thousands of poor children over the years. He has constructed a unique Eidgah prayer complex in Tumkur, India, combining space age and traditional themes that accommodates more than twelve thousand worshippers. He currently lives in Concord, California, with wife, Maimoona Ahmed. They have two children, Ameena and Akbar, and three grandchildren—Naila, Aliya, and Zaid.

Dr. Nazeer Ahmed is a former president of the ISCJ. He is also a brilliant space scientist, an author, and a successful, acclaimed, and honored political activist.



A Tribute To Br. Riaz Iqbal, MD: ISCJ Has Lost a True Friend

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD, Br. Zahid Baig, MD, and Br. Abdul Hakim Babar, MD

Dr. Riaz Iqbal was a very kind, good-natured, soft-spoken, friendly, and most generous gentleman who was a dear friend to all of us. He was a gentle giant in many respects. He supported the ISCJ since its inception with his time and, of course, with his donations. As a founding member, and a close friend of Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar (one of the ISCJ's early presidents), he took the role of the first fund-raising chairman and raised funds to lay the foundation of our now beautiful and growing ISCJ campus. He served as a board of trustee from 1979 to 1982. During this time, he made long-lasting friends with most of the founding members. I remember Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad speaking at Dr. Iqbal and Khairunnisa's *walima*.

On the ISCJ's fortieth anniversary celebration, keeping in mind that he was retired, I still asked him for a small donation, not expecting a big amount. He told me that the ISCJ's fortieth anniversary was a great accomplishment and that he was delighted to contribute generously, which he did. Even though his children or grandchildren did not attend Noor-Ul-Iman School, he supported the school with wholehearted enthusiasm because he strongly believed in it.

Just a week prior to his death, he told me because of ill health, he would not be able to attend Taraweeh prayers anymore but would continue to come for Jumu'ah prayers as long as he lived. We would often talk about activities and new projects at the ISCJ as well as exchange notes about the well-being of our families. The ISCJ was very near and dear to him.

Dr. Iqbal was a 1966 graduate of the King Edward Medical College in Pakistan. He was a very highly respected physician who served the community for over forty-five years. He was one of the founding members of Hamilton Hospital, now known as Robert Wood Johnson University Hospital. He was also one of the earliest board-certified gastroenterologists who introduced gastroenterology services to the area and had to purchase his own endoscopes to do procedures to serve the hospital and the community. He served as chairman of medicine and a board member and assisted many committees. He was the founder of Hamilton Gastroenterology Group, which now consists of seven gastroenterologists. Under his leadership, Hamilton Endoscopy and Surgery Center was established in 2004. Dr. Iqbal will be remembered by his patients who considered him as one of their own family members.

Dr. Riaz Iqbal is survived by his loving and devoted wife, Khairunnisa, whom he praised often. He has one son and four daughters, along with their spouses and many grandchildren. May Allah (SWT) reward him for all his good deeds and bless his family. The ISCJ has truly lost a great friend and supporter. We will all miss him.

Dr. Sogra Saleem is a founding member of the ISCJ, and Dr. Zahid Baig is a former Noor-Ul-Iman School Board member.

MY TRIBUTE TO MY DEAR FRIEND DR. RIAZ IQBAL

I had been a part of this community and the Islamic Society of Central Jersey for over thirteen years prior to our return to Pakistan in 1989. It was on Friday, July 1, 2016 (twenty-fifth day of Ramadan), that I received a message that my dear friend had passed away.

Inna Lillahe wa Inna elahay Rajeoon. (To Allah we belong, and to him we return.)

Indeed! "Whatever Allah gives or takes belongs to Him and everything is predestined by Him" (Sahih Bukhari and Sahih Muslim).

Riaz Iqbal was more than a friend; he was a brother and a family member. Our association started more than fifty-seven years ago at the Government College in Lahore and continued at King Edward Medical College, where we graduated together before proceeding to the USA for postgraduate training. We traveled in the same plane and joined Christ Hospital for internship. We parted from each other for a few years, only to get back together again in Trenton, New Jersey, where we started our

respective private practices and even shared our office during the initial years.

Our families and our children shared the same close relationship throughout our long association. Riaz was a very kind-hearted person, sincere, loving, and very considerate of others and always there on all occasions. During our college days, I was the conservative religious type, and he was more of a social liberal. There was a special bond between our families, and we enjoyed numerous picnic outings and birthday parties of our children.

In early 1980s, we were both deeply involved with the organization of our community and especially in starting the Islamic Society of Central Jersey. He was always by my side for many of those fund-raisers and community functions.

He had a brilliant, enviable professional career and was a great gastroenterologist and served as chief of staff at Hamilton Hospital for many years. After we moved back to Pakistan, we kept in contact with each other and looked for every opportunity to meet during our visits. Last year, it was painful to see him go through so many medical problems, but he faced those adversities with lots of patience and perseverance.

My wife, Mumtaz, and I pray to Allah (SWT) to grant Riaz a very befitting place in Jannah and give Shami Bhabi and children strength and courage to bear this tremendous loss

Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar is a founding member of the ISCJ.



The ISCJ Mosque Project – From Dream To Reality

A Testament of Our Resolve and Help from Allah!
Br. Shaikh Moizul Matin, PhD

I, Shaikh Moizul Matin, and several Muslim friends in New York City had established a mosque on Warren Street near City Hall in the early 1970s. Almost all of us were living in New Jersey near Rutgers University. We started an Islamic Sunday school for our young children at Rutgers University. Soon, for some unknown reason, the Rutgers University decided to terminate our arrangement.

At that juncture, we all concluded that we must have a place of our own. Soon, this desire gave birth to the decision to build a mosque that should look like a mosque, a place of our own for religious activities. We were only a few young families, all wage earners in early stages of our careers, living in the vicinity of New Brunswick. There were only three mosques in New York City—one at 1 Riverside Drive, one in Brooklyn at 143 State Street, and one on Warren Street.

There was a group of Muslim doctors in Trenton area who were organizing exactly for the same purpose. Somehow these two merged and pooled their resources, and the ISCJ was born. Omar Boraie, a Muslim realtor, located a 6.4-acre plot of land in South Brunswick on Route 1 South. We all liked the location, price, and commercial zoning. However, some of us were lukewarm with the idea of building a mosque. They wanted to buy a house and use it as mosque and Sunday school. We discussed and debated the pros and cons and formed a committee to decide.

The committee met at my house in Piscataway one evening and decided to build a mosque on the 6.4-acre plot on Route 1 South in South Brunswick Township. So we purchased that plot of land immediately.

We did not know at that time that a motel chain from New Hampshire was also negotiating for the same plot of land and that they were very angry with us. The motel group was plotting to stop the mosque project. We inherited an adversary on the very first day without any fault of ours and were not even aware of it.

The motel group publicist organized the Richard Road residents' community and scared them by telling them Islam and Muslims were the Antichrist. This was easy preaching by them at that time because Iranians students were holding American hostages in Tehran (1979), Muslims and Christians were fighting a civil war in Lebanon, and Egypt, Syria, and Jordan were making headlines through saber rattling each day.

This group, fully charged and energized, began making representations and agitations against the mosque project to the township officials. When township officials alerted us, we were alarmed, and three of us—Dr. Matin, Br. Dawud Assad, and Dr. M. Taher—volunteered to interact with the residents and educate them about Islam and Muslims in America. We were the members of the dialogue with Cardinal O'Connor Archdiocese and separately with the American Jewish Committee. The residents were impressed by the fact that our group was made of doctors, professors, engineers, and other highly respected professions. I also detected a faint apprehension in the minds of the group members. They were concerned about the Muslim community center and the mosque, but they all were far more terrified of a go-go bar so close to their houses, affecting their children and the morals of their youths. We, of course, caught on and echoed their concerns to win them over to our side.

Hence, by the grace of Allah, we were able to give back to the motel group a taste of their own medicine. The residents were now in our favor and against the bar, nightclub, and motel. Our adversary was determined to defeat our plans, however. The motel group quietly purchased the three acres of land in a hurry, on the north side of Richard Road, to build their bar. Their strategy was to start construction of the bar before the mosque. There is a law that a church has to be a certain distance away from any bar. The mosque plot was within this limit from the Richard Road. Hence, the mosque could not be built if they started the construction of the bar first. I was like a zombie, in a state of shock. "We lost the mosque project,"

I told my wife. She was laughing. "What do you think about Allah? Allah, who helped you all along to bring you to this point, now suddenly,

he will let you down? Don't you have any hope, faith, or confidence in Allah?" I was smashed.

Three weeks later, the residents called me to inform me that almost all the three acres are wetlands and nothing could be built on it. That meant our mosque could be built after all. We did not lose the mosque project.

Thanks to Almighty! This reminded me of the verse in Qur'an 8:30: "The enemy is plotting and Allah is planning. Allah is the wisest and the best planner of them all."

This did not break the resolve of the motel group. They became more adamant and came back at us with furious vengeance, this time with different consultants. Their plan was to purchase all the land between the south side of Richard Road and our plot for the mosque. That would have been large enough for them to do their project and knock us out. Somehow I was able to guess the strategy of the motel group before they could act. I alerted the two homeowners whose houses were on the front of the south side of the Richard Road.

I told them, "Please do not sign any document or accept any funds from the motel people. Just tell them that you would not do anything without consulting your attorney. I can get you far better terms and money than their offer." Sure enough, within days, they made the offer to each one. Based on their and my circumstances, I made an offer greater than the motel's offer to each and gave each one $5,000 to execute a three-year option to Dr. Matin. My plan was this: "Everyone should think that I am buying the house for me to live and the other smaller house for my wife's office to see patients. It has visibility and convenience." No one should be able to guess that it was really to block the motel and make the mosque viable. This made the motel group more angry and vengeful. However, this also created more in-house problems for me.

First, my own Muslim brothers, Dr. Taher and Dawud Assad, on one hand and my wife on the other became angry. Mosque group members began to accuse me. Finally, I had to share the plan with them and explain Imam Ghazali's dictum: Not all knowledges are for all the people. (Only those who have the need to know should know and none other.)

While I was busy with these internal misunderstandings, the motel group started negotiations with the landowners between the two houses. These two owners were not willing to even see me. It was disappointing. I was tired and disenchanted with this chess game and had exhausted all my financial reserves by now, which were meager to begin with.

Once again, I felt that the mosque project was not yet secured and slipping away from us. I was in need of the guidance and help from Allah. The next day, I saw my attorney for another reason. He inquired about the

mosque project and advised that we should really start the construction and put a big sign, Islamic Mosque Coming Soon. The motel group will disappear in a jiffy. I told him that since we have no funds left, how could we? He replied, "Just start moving the dirt around on that site, and make it look like construction has begun. Money will come, and the motel will take a walk."

While I was busy here, Suhail Rifai, Dawud, Shoukat, Dr. Babar, Dr. Saleem Baig, and Br. Hakim Irfani, who were on the first building committee of the ISCJ, were working with the architect Mahoney. The building plans of the mosque were already discussed with the engineering and planning department of the South Brunswick Township.

So I asked Mohamed Elsaady to find out from the contractor what funds he would need to put up a sign, clear the boulders, and move the dirt around. The answer was $12,000. We did not have this much money, and there was no time to run around and do a fund-raising. I never felt so close and yet so far from the mosque project.

I came home and started looking at all the possible places where I could find some money. I found about $10,000, saved for tuition for my son and my daughter. So I transferred the money to my checking account, wrote a check, and asked the contractor to start pushing the dirt and boulders around. When my wife found out what I had done, she was quiet, and from then on, she began to have anxiety and panic attacks. Her fear was that one of these days, she would be standing on the street with the children because I had donated away everything and all that we had.

Regardless, that worked. The motel disappeared, and the remaining landowners were anxious to sell their real estate to us. I was not responding because my objective was fulfilled. NOW MOSQUE WILL BE BUILT. I was concerned about the land in between. Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad rose and bought all the remaining land plots for the mosque so that the mosque, school, and other facilities were now possible.

However, a new confusion arose. The township construction department had issued the permit to move the dirt around, thinking the project was approved by the planning board. It was not; it was only discussed with them in meetings. A formal hearing had to take place with voting from board members. Also, the original plan was to have a mezzanine and a basement, which was later abandoned. The contractor was digging for the basement when the inspector came. He stopped all the work till the final plans were voted upon. This created confusion. People thought the project was now put off. However, the confusion was clarified and corrected, and the construction resumed. And so the mosque was built, and since then, the mosque has expanded repeatedly.

It was a strange coincidence when I recall it. When we laid the cornerstone for the mosque on the plot of land, it was wilderness all around. A guest asked us where he could wash up and offer two Rakat Shukr and pray Asr. We were dumbfounded. I had just bought this house in Princeton but had not moved in it because the school year was not yet over. So I came forward and suggested that we go to my house in Princeton. It was empty, without furniture but with clean water, light, and heat. We could pray in privacy and peace. The dream of building a mosque began from my house when we decided to purchase the land, and the physical shape began to take form also from my house.

However, a very tense and serious issue arose among us—Dr. Taher Dawud Assad, Abdel-Rehim Riad, and me, Matin. Dr. Taher became serious about owning the house, which later became the imam's residence. Dr. Taher was due for retirement from the college in three years. His legitimate intentions were to own the house, live in it for three years, and then sell it to the ISCJ and go and settle back in Egypt with his sister for his last days. Dr. Taher and Dawud began negotiating with the owner of the house. The owner refused Dr. Taher, saying he could only sell to Matin. They all were pressing me to terminate the option or to sell the option to Dr. Taher. I refused.

I explained that it was my firm commitment to Allah that the mosque must own it and only the mosque, and I would not budge from it for anyone or for any reason. I had seen how quickly circumstances make people shift from their pure and sincere intentions. Dawud mediated and came up with the solution, which was acceptable to Dr. Taher and Dr. Matin. The solution was to close on the house. When Dr. Taher left, he could receive funds in three annual installments. The owner wanted guarantees from three doctors for his payments. I gladly arranged for Dr. Babar, Dr. Zuhair Abbasi, and me to guarantee the payments. In this process, my wife, looking for an office, became interested in one of the houses. Seeing my firm resolve, she settled for an office on Witherspoon Street, Princeton. Looking back, I realize that all this was a test of our resolve and sincerity. We all should thank Allah that we all came through with full glory. What is important is to realize and understand that Allah's help is sure and one must not lose hope. Allah does not like those who give up on him.

O, Allah, accept this and help us fulfill all our obligations. Ameen.



Navigating The ISCJ Through Its Turbulent Early Years

Br. Dawud Assad

My association with the ISCJ began in 1970 when a nucleus of the Islamic community in Central New Jersey was formed. Four Rutgers University students and five families who lived in the New Brunswick area formed this group under the name of Islamic Society and Friends or ISF. Between December 26, 1973, and January 1, 1974, a meeting of the group was held. They discussed the importance of the Islamic education for their children and the necessity for a weekend Islamic school. They planned to use the Rutgers University classrooms for teaching their children the basic tenets of Islam.

As it was difficult for the parents to drop their children off and go home and then come back to pick the children up, it was decided to acquire an additional room to hold seminars for the parents as they waited while their children attended classes. We faced some difficulties with Rutgers with our request for more rooms. Fortunately, it worked out, and the classes were held on Sunday mornings. These humble beginnings are the precursors to the founding of the ISCJ and the Noor-Ul-Iman School.

The seed of the ISCJ was planted on this spot in Central Jersey, and by the grace of Allah (SWT), it has grown and blossomed under his care and goodly pleasure. Area Muslims have continued to water it with their time, affection, and resources to keep it thriving. Alhamdulillah, Rabbi al Alameen. The ISCJ is a part and parcel of my life since its inception. My daughter was a student in the weekend school before the Noor-Ul-Iman School was established. My mother-in-law was a fixture during the ISCJ's Rutgers years. Everyone called her Sittee (Grandmother). She was always

cooking and bringing trays of food for the seminar attendees to eat during the break. My wife, Aminah, still accompanies me to most of the ISCJ functions. I had to overcome many struggles after my arrival in the USA on September 13, 1951. I landed at "Idlewild Airport" (which was renamed John F. Kennedy Airport on December 24, 1963) on a student visa. The immigration officer demanded that I pay a bond of $500 as a guarantee of my leaving the United States after the completion of my education. I made the mistake of telling him that I wanted to marry a U.S. citizen so that I could stay in America. Also, I only had $16 in my pocket and clearly could not pay the $500 the immigration officer had demanded. Because of my inability to pay, I was detained at the Ellis Island for three days for further investigation and processing until I could come up with the bond. At that time, Ellis Island was like a prison, and anyone whose travel documents were not in perfect order or was perceived to have questionable intentions was detained there. For complete details of this episode, please read my book *Palestine Rising*, published in February 2011, pages 44–45.

The first place I came to after I was released from detention was New Brunswick, New Jersey. I attended Rutgers University for one year (1951–1952). While taking classes, I took a job in New Brunswick and made cigar boxes to be shipped to Havana for the famous Havana Cigars. This was to enable me to cover my expenses and finance my education. However, as this job paid only 60¢ an hour, I had to leave Rutgers after one year. I went to Boston, where I was able to get a job paying $60 a week. I also took admission to Boston's Northeastern University. This job covered my tuition, which was $385 a semester. In 1953, I was ready to marry my fiancée, Aminah. I could not find any imam in New Jersey. Therefore, we traveled to State Street in Brooklyn, where we were married by Imam Dawud Faisal, who was from Ghana.

I have a bachelor's degree in mechanical engineering and a Master of Science degree in industrial management. I also hold an honorary doctoral degree. My résumé is attached.

My family and I have lived in New Jersey for many years, and I am one of the proud founding members of the ISCJ. I have continued to patronize this masjid for all its educational and philanthropic services and for the model it has become for other Islamic institutions in the surrounding area as well as around the nation.

I served the ISCJ as the chairman of the board of trustees for twelve years. Over the years, I was privileged to be the first chairman of the board of trustees and chairman of the building committee (BC), which accomplished the task of building the original classrooms and the multipurpose room (MPR). Additionally, I served as chair of the religious

committee (RC) for five years until it was restructured as the religious events planning committee (REPC) in 2015. This office I hold to the present day.

One of the memorable incidents that I recall at the ISCJ was at a board meeting in Br. Shoukat Ali's office in Robbinsville, New Jersey. The main purpose of the meeting was to take a vote on whether to build the school classrooms and multipurpose room (MPR) first or the masjid first. I prayed, asking Allah to let me get to the right decision (Salat al Istikharah), that we, the board of trustees, would come to a unanimous decision. After two hours of deliberation of the pros and cons, one called for the members to vote. The result was a 4–4 deadlock. According to our constitution, the chairman, which was me, was supposed to break the tie. I refused to do so because I found that the two parties were split along national origins, four members of Egyptian origin and four of Pakistani origin. In my heart, I wanted the school first. Every board member wanted me to break the tie, but since I could not, or would not, some of them accused me of being a weak chairman because I had refused to exercise my constitutional obligation.

They were right, but my policy was to maintain harmony among my board members. I called my son, who is a lawyer, and asked for his opinion. He explained to me a term I was not aware of, "referendum." He went on to point out that to have a referendum, a general assembly of members should be gathered, including the board and all paid members, and that they should decide the issue through a vote. This would relieve the pressure on the BOT and me. At that time, it meant an expenditure of at least $300 for renting a hall and typing letters and postage, when we were begging for money to build the ISCJ. So I decided that I would pay the cost from my own pocket, and we rented a room at the Holiday Inn on Route 1. The final vote was 66 percent in favor of the school first. The masjid was built after the school. I always thought that this was the right way to resolve the disagreement. Afterward, some board members came to me and told me that after all, I was not a weak chairman but a wise one.

Br. Dawud Assad is a founding member of the ISCJ. He is also the ISCJ's first chairman of the board of trustees. In April 2017, Br. Dawud Assad received an award from Mayor Jim B. Clarke of Culver City, California, for his lifelong work promoting multi-faith harmony and conflict resolution throughout the United States and the world.



Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad's History With The ISCJ Community

Since coming to the United States in 1969 with my family, and after deep thought and reflection, I came to the personal realization and conclusion that Allah (SWT) did not bring us to America from different parts of the world, holding professional degrees, only so that we can live "the good life," including buying big houses and fancy cars. Allah (SWT) blessed us with this opportunity so that we can carry the *da'wah*, the message of Islam, to this new land and our new home, America.

This is what drove my involvement in our society dating back to October 1976. At that time, the society was not formally established; rather, it was in the form of the Islamic Society and Friends, a Muslim Students Association (MSA) group at Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey. The founders and active members of this group at that time consisted of both university students and members of the Rutgers University staff and faculty as well as other individuals and Muslim families like ours that resided in the Central New Jersey area.

The pioneers of that MSA group consisted of several individuals, including Arab Muslim students. Among them, the most actively involved were Dr. Mahmood Taher, Dr. Morad Abou-Sabe, Nabeel Taha, Dr. Essam Taha, Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dawud Assad, and others. Our primary goal of meeting together regularly at that time was to teach our young children the basics of the religion of Islam so that they could grow up and remain Muslims in our new country of America, which we called home.

I remember that in 1976, I served the Rutgers MSA group as vice president. At that time, Dr. Suhail Rifai was the president, and Nabeel Taha was the treasurer. Our total cash balance in our bank account at

that time was $3,500. With that humble beginning, we began the effort in earnest to raise sufficient funds to establish a masjid, fully owned and operated by the society that was growing fast.

At around this time, there was a group of Pakistani Muslim physicians who moved into the area and were also interested in building a masjid in the Princeton-Trenton area. Prominent among them were Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, Dr. Riaz Iqbal, Dr. Sarfaraz Ahmad, and others. After several conversations, meetings, and discussions, it was agreed by all involved at that time that the best way forward was to come together and pool our resources and talents and build a single masjid to serve as our center for our spiritual, religious, educational, and social needs.

Ours was a community that from its early days was based on universal brotherhood and sisterhood irrespective of ethnic background or national origin. It is something special that set our society apart from other Muslim communities throughout the region at that time, which were based on ethnicity or country of origin.

Going back, in 1977, Br. Omar Boraie was instrumental in finding approximately 6.4 acres of land on Route 1 (where we are Alhamdulillah until today), and we were able to pool our financial resources for an offer for the property. We were short by $5,000, and Br. Omar Boraie covered this shortfall, and we were able to purchase the land. Alhamdulillah!

For us to put the title and deed of the property in the name of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ), we had to write a constitution and establish ISCJ's tax-exempt status as a nonprofit institution. While there were several brothers involved in the writing of the constitution at that time, Dr. Moizul Matin was central to that process.

At the first formal election of ISCJ, Dr. Suhail Rifai withdrew his name, and we elected Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar as president; me, Abdel-Rehim A. Riad, as vice president; Dawud Assad as chairman; and Br. Montasser Soliman as treasurer. This was a time characterized by true universal brotherhood and sisterhood. Nationality was never an issue for us then.

Everyone worked sincerely and was dedicated to making the construction of the masjid a reality. Special recognitions are due to Br. Abad Ahmed and Dr. Riaz Iqbal, who worked tirelessly to raise and collect funds for the masjid project. Others like Dr. Salam Shahidi tried innovative ways to collect funds by bringing the Qawali singers to perform. The idea of bringing religious entertainment as part of a masjid fund-raising campaign, which now seems commonplace, I think originated from our society.

At that time, we also sent a delegation, consisting of Dr. Hameed Baber, Dr. Suhail Rifai, and Dr. Mahmood Taher, from our society's leadership

to Saudi Arabia during the first Ramadan after the establishment of the society to collect donations. These brothers undertook this journey at their own expense.

During those times, we viewed the funds of the society as being exclusively an *Amanah*, trust, from Allah (SWT). We did not view these funds that were entrusted to our care just as Other People's Money (OPM), which we could spend as we wanted. During that time, we took care not to spend the society's money without first spending our own, even when it came to organizing fund-raising activities on behalf of the society.

When we had succeeded in collecting sufficient funds, we reached out to several architects in the area to help us design a masjid. We ourselves were not experienced in this matter or had a clear picture of what a masjid in the USA would look like or what its construction would entail. Also, no one knew what a "masjid" was at that time among certified American architects or had ever designed a mosque.

Finally, we were able to select Mahony & Zvosec, Architects & Planners to help us design the masjid (14,000 square feet). Because of the high costs of the masjid construction, we decided to construct the masjid in two phases (masjid and the multipurpose room [MPR]). The majority of the society members (not just the board of trustees alone) voted to go ahead with the MPR section first, which we then all got behind and supported. Alhamdulillah, in 1980, the MPR section was completed.

Many of us had thought at that time that this building was too big for the thirty-plus families who made the core of our society at that time. *Subhan Allah*, how Allah has blessed our society in its exponential growth! The building of the MPR, which also served as our masjid, was to my knowledge the first occasion where a Muslim community on the East Coast of America had built its own masjid on its own land from its own funds. The ISCJ was historically a pioneering Muslim institution in America, taking the lead, and setting an example. I pray that it continues to be so in the future as well.

Needless to say, as time progressed and more Muslims relocated to the area, the MPR became overcrowded and could no longer accommodate the needs of a growing community. Because of my extensive experience in management and strategic financial planning, I have had the honor to have been elected to serve the society since its inception through the year 2000 in various leadership roles, including president and chairman. During my work as chairman of the society, I impressed upon our brothers and sisters in the ISCJ board, through my vision (gift from Allah), the necessity of expanding the current society's land to meet the future needs of its members and securing the society's assets to achieve stability and

sustainability. Under my leadership, the society's property expanded from roughly 6.4 acres to 14.5 acres, of which I had paid for from my personal funds, $450,000, as a donation to the society for the specific purpose of buying the new home for the Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI).

I was blessed to have had the opportunity to serve side by side over these years with wonderful brothers and sisters, among them Brs. Sobhi Khalil, Shoukat Ali, Montasser Soliman, Galal Badr, Dr. Bakr Orabi, Mazhar Hassan, Dr. Mohamed Ali Chaudry, Dr. Mohamed Elsaady, Ahmed Elmoslimany, Dr. Omar Mansour, Dr. Parvaiz Malik, Br. Aly Abdel Aziz (CPA), Dr. Sogra Saleem, Sr. Nadia Younes, Sr. Atiya Aftab, Esq. (whom I had originally appointed to the BOT), Br. Riaz Siddiqui, Br. Mohommed Siddiqui, Br. Muhammad Ashraf, and other good Muslims.

On this occasion, we have to recognize the important roles played by our SISTERS for keeping our society in outstanding shape. Though we did not always agree on all matters, in the end, these dedicated individuals put the interest of the society above personal agendas, their relatives and friends, and the narrowness of ethnicity and nationality. We always had to keep our vision in mind and balance the competing interests of how to go about completing the building of our masjid; building of the new Islamic school and a funeral home, which was strongly advocated by our late sister Attiyaat Elsaady; and building income-generating projects to generate funds to help finance the operating expenses of the society and subsidize the tuition of the needy students.

After building the MPR, we actively sought to recruit an imam, religious leader, for our society. During the early 1985, though Rabitat El Alam Al Islamy, we had interviewed many candidates to serve as our imam. In 1986, after a couple of false starts, we were able, with Allah's guidance, to agree on Imam Hamad Chebli, who, in keeping with the distinctive character of our society, was a scholar from Al-Azhar University and who put the wider interests of the community above narrow interest of ethnicity and nationality.

Over the years, there have been several obstacles that our society encountered and, alhamdulillah, was able to overcome. One such obstacle that comes to mind was when KFC was looking to purchase the 4.5 acres of land adjacent to ISCJ. Despite all our efforts (I was directly involved in negotiations with the seller of the land), it was not until I made it clear to KFC our position that they withdrew their offer, and we were able to purchase the land for $450,000. I was able at that time to donate this amount of money to the society, provided that this land be used to build the Noor-Ul-Iman School building, which would be used by the full-time Noor-Ul-Iman School students, and the weekend school students as well.

I am proud of the fact that the society's parcel of land had by then reached nearly 14.5 acres, purchased and paid by the members of the society with no outside help or donations. With this acreage of land in our hands, the society began on a systematic strategic planning process to develop a master plan for the developing of the entire land. This process involved numerous in-house meetings with all the concerned members of the society actively participating. As part of this process, (a) we hired lawyer, engineers, and architects to put a conceptual plan based on the decisions arrived at our community meetings (approximately 16 acres); (b) we went to township meetings through October 2001 for it to vote on a new plan; and (c) the township voted to approve our conceptual plan, and the society started to raise funds to build the school, but some members had cold feet when it came to building the new school. To encourage the members, and to implement the vision, I donated $1 million in cash to be used for the concrete slab and steel frame foundation of the first and the second phases of Noor-Ul-Iman School building.

I joined NUI School after I left my responsibility as chairman/president of ISCJ Board of Trustees (BOT). I had left the society in good hands with energetic, vibrant members and on solid financial footing (free from all debts) and, most importantly, free from the stain of nationalism as the overriding basis upon how to decide and vote for leadership. Our votes instead were based on the qualifications and the sincerity of the candidates and their track record of service to the society. I am thankful to Allah (SWT) that through my managerial and strategic planning, I was able to facilitate, encourage, and empower many of the members to select qualified individuals who could truly and effectively serve this community. Regarding my relationship with NUI, I was one of the founders and early supporters and financial backers of the school dating back to its inception in 1993. Among the challenges we were able to successfully meet during my tenure of service with the school board of directors (BOD) were (a) the creating of a fund for the needy students, (b) stepping in on several occasions when the school was in danger of insolvency, and (c) working with brothers like Parvaiz Malik and Riaz Iqbal to ensure that the school had sufficient funds to meet its expenses, including salaries of teachers and staff. In the year 2005, Br. Aly Abdel Aziz (CPA) presented to NUI BOD certified financial report that the school encountered losses of $375,000.

In 2005, to address this serious issue, I was appointed school's treasurer by NUI BOD, and I served as the treasurer and chairman of NUI. Within a short time, I was successfully able, working with the NUI parents, to recover the losses of $375,000 and to raise the teachers' salaries by 40 percent. In addition, under my leadership, we were able to accumulate a

surplus of over $1 million to be used for the construction of the new NUI School building.

For NUI to become financially sound, NUI has to increase annual student enrolment to reach ninety.

The Prophet Muhammad (Salal Lahu Alehi Wasalam) said regarding tribalism/nationalism, "Leave it. It is rotten" (Bukhari and Muslim). This refers to all forms of *Asabiyyah*, nationalism, racism, and ethnic chauvinism.

Grouping Muslims on tribalistic lines is clearly forbidden in Islam. It is narrated by Abu Dawud that the Messenger of Allah (Salal Lahu Alehi Wasalam) said, "He is not one us who calls for 'Asabiyyah,' (nationalism/tribalism) or who fights for 'Asabiyyah' or who dies for 'Asabiyyah.'"

My vision for NUI is to expand the education provided to all Muslim children, provided they can afford it according to my slogan, "Quality Islamic education at affordable tuition."

These days, I have once again felt the call to serve our community. At present, I am doing so in the capacity of working with the society's steering committee, which consists of a group of highly qualified engineers, including Brs. Rizwan Baig, Magdy Haggag, Michael Conaboy, and Wajid Syed, to prepare the necessary documents required to realize the other elements of my vision and components of the approved conceptual master plan. These include the building of the following:

1. Housing units for the senior citizen members of our society, consisting of thirty units. The plan is that the society will build and be able to sell these units as townhouses, making the project self-financing.
2. Sports bubble with various indoor athletic fields and courts for our YOUTH. Unfortunately, our society is not doing a good job of meeting these needs of our youth. It is about time for ISCJ BOT to appoint a youth coordinator prior to building this athletic bubble. This will be an income- generating project.

On this occasion, we should not forget our brothers and sisters who have fallen along the road to our progress and achievements: Dr. Salam Shahidi, Dr. Mahmood Taher, Dr. Omar Mansour, Br. Mazhar Hassan, Br. Ahmed El Moslimany, Br. Syed Sajad, Dr. Bakr Oraby, Br. Fouad El Ishmawy, Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady, and others. May Allah (SWT) bless their souls and reward them for their hard work and their contributions to our community. AMEEN!

Finally, my dear brothers and sisters, I thank you for giving me the opportunity to serve you all these years and to be an active member and

part of this society since its inception. I pray that my work and service throughout these many years be accepted by Allah (SWT), for I have always tried my best with the *Taqwa* (fear of Allah [SWT]) in my words and deeds. I am asking for forgiveness from Allah (SWT) and from every one of you for any mistakes I may have committed along the way.

My sincere hope from Allah (SWT) is to see these two projects completed before I meet HIM. Let it be so. Ameen!

Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad is a founding member of the ISCJ. He is also one of the three founders of the Noor-Ul-Iman School. Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad has served the ISCJ in numerous capacities and is a major benefactor of the ISCJ.

Alibris



An Overview Of The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey History

Br. Morad Abou-Sabe, PhD

I got involved with the ISCJ from its inception. It was forty-seven years ago, but it feels like it was yesterday. I am talking about the creation of one of the first Muslim students organizations in New Jersey, if not in the United States at large. At the time, I had just been appointed an assistant professor at the Department of Bacteriology at Rutgers University, September 1968. After joining Rutgers and having a son and a daughter, six and three years old, respectively, it was important for me to look into my children's introduction to our Muslim heritage, teaching them the Arabic language and instructing them about Islam.

That was the beginning of establishing a Muslim Students Organization (MSO) at Rutgers University, and I served as the faculty advisor for the organization. It was called "the Islamic Society of Rutgers Students and Friends" and became an official student organization at the university since. The establishment of the student organization gave us access to the university facilities and lecture halls to use to conduct weekend classes for our children. I remember when we started using classrooms at Scott Hall on the College Avenue Campus every Sunday morning to teach our children Arabic and the principles of Islam.

At that time, there were only a few families, mostly friends, who began to share in conducting these classes every Sunday. Among these families were Rida and Sawsan Ali and the Taha family—Nabil and Sharon Taha and Issam Taha. There was also Mahmoud Taher, who was a faculty

member at the Middlesex County College adjacent to Rutgers, in addition to the Abou-Sabe family.

As the news about our Sunday classes at Rutgers began to break out in the local community, more and more families joined and participated in the effort.

The scope of our activities began to widen and include the Eid celebrations, Ramadan *iftars*, and the like, which we held in larger halls as well as in the student centers on both George Street and College Avenue. I even gave the khutbah in one of the Eid celebrations, something I was not accustomed to doing.

It is important to point out that the original set of families began to expand as well, to include the Dawud Assad family and the Suhail Rifai family, among others. These activities and the community expansion continued from 1969 through 1974 when the community began to look into building its own center. During that period, the Rutgers University community of Muslim families joined with another Muslim community in the Trenton/Princeton area. Dialogues between the two communities resulted in the choice of the current location of the ISCJ in South Brunswick.

Until that time, the ISCJ as an organization had not existed. The idea, however, of creating such a society to serve the Muslim community in New Jersey was born from these discussions between the Rutgers and the Princeton area's Muslim groups.

On May 27, 1975, the Islamic Society of Central Jersey was officially born. It was incorporated with the state of New Jersey under the corporate name Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ). Its first board of trustees who signed the incorporation papers with the state of New Jersey were the following:

Morad Abou-Sabe
Omar Boraie
Ibrahim Sheriff
Mahmoud Taher
Nabil Taha
Issam Taha

The goals of the society were "to foster the interest of Muslims and Islam and to carry on religious, educational, charitable, social, and literary functions in the furtherance of Islam and the religious objectives of Islam. Its activities are designed to accomplish these goals, including, but not limited to, these methods: religious services and prayers, religious

instruction for Muslims children and adults and supplying of lectures and lecturers and religious materials so that both Muslims and non-Muslims may benefit. All monies collected will be used only for the above purposes."

At that time, the idea of building a mosque in the Princeton area, to accommodate all families between New Brunswick and Trenton, took hold and brought a large number of families together to achieve that goal. Br. Omar Boraie, a trustee and an expert in real estate, played a central role in the process, along with other community members. This collaboration resulted in the purchase of the initial parcel of land on Route 1 in South Brunswick, where the ISCJ is now located.

The vision was, as I explained above and as stipulated in the statement of the ISCJ's incorporation, to create a Muslim community center where we could bring our families together, teach our children the religion of Islam, instruct them in the Arabic language, and most importantly, introduce the community to the larger non-Muslim American community with whom we live and flourish through "supplying of lectures and lecturers and religious materials so that both Muslims and non-Muslims may benefit." It was both a self-education and growth for our community and a role model for the larger community around us.

What I remember fondly about those days is that it was a time when we all looked forward to Fridays for the Jumu'ah prayers, and the Sundays for the Sunday school classes for our children, and the seminar for the adults. It was a quintessential weekly meeting of the community. I also remember the fund-raising galas where we brought great speakers to visit with the community and share their ideas and thoughts with us. Guest speakers would come from Canada, California, and even from outside the United States. Those were very crucial times for building the ISCJ community.

Once the first phase of the ISCJ was built, it was used as a multipurpose room in which all activities were conducted. This was followed by the second phase, which expanded the ISCJ into the current shape of the mosque, with the prayer room separate from the multipurpose room and the surrounding classrooms. Eventually, the Sunday classes expanded into a full-time school, the Noor-Ul-Iman School.

Throughout the 1980s, I was fully engaged in the operation of the ISCJ. I served in different capacities, initially as a board member and then as a treasurer, and finally, in 1990, I served as president of the board of trustees. I also served as an overseer at one point.

To summarize, some of the activities and services I had a major role in and was responsible for are the following:

1. I organized at least one of the fund-raising events, which was held at the Crowne Plaza hotel at the entrance of the New Jersey Turnpike at Exit 8A.
2. We published a magazine called *Noor-Ul-Islam*, which was released quarterly. *Noor-Ul-Islam* published news report of the services and activities that took place at the ISCJ.
3. In the mid-1980s, we felt an urgent need to have a full-time imam to serve the community. I was on the search committee. That was when we brought Imam Hamad Chebli to the ISCJ from New Orleans, Louisiana. I was the one who picked him up from Newark Airport and introduced him to the community.
4. We had a mini-conference in which Muslim scholars from New Jersey, New York, and Virginia shared their views with the community about the Islamic calendar. At the time, it was always difficult to assign a specific date for the beginning of Ramadan or when Eid al-Fitr would be. That was the time when these scholars supported the calculated calendar rather than the reliance on sighting of the moon to announce the beginning and the end of Ramadan.
5. During my presidency of the society (1990) I organized and held an Islamic art exhibit in the multipurpose room, which was open to the full neighborhood around the ISCJ. Islamic art was exhibited for all to see. Most of, if not all, the exhibited art were personal contribution of the members of the society. All proceeds from the sale of these art pieces were provided to the ISCJ treasury.
6. As the operation of the ISCJ became difficult to manage by the part-time volunteer board members and other ISCJ members who donated their time, I suggested that the ISCJ should hire a full-time paid administrator. The idea was initially resisted vigorously by the board.
7. Realizing the importance of having a full-time administrator, the only way that I, as president, could bring this concept to fruition was to pay for the administrator myself, which I did initially. Now the ISCJ has two administrators.
8. The ISCJ library was also built around that time. Unfortunately, it has remained as it was some twenty years ago when we built it.
9. There are many other memorable occasions that I cannot forget. One important memory when I served as the society's treasurer was to note how generous our community was. I saw it with my own eyes, counted with my own hands, and reported on it at the annual general body meeting of the society.

10. It was important to connect the society with the state government. We made our best inroads into the state government during Gov. Christie Whitman's tenure as the New Jersey governor. Association with the state government made possible receiving the first official public proclamations from the state for the beginning of Ramadan and the Eid celebrations.
11. Through personal contact with the New Jersey Commerce secretary Guallberto Medina, we set up a workshop for our members and owners of small businesses in New Jersey to introduce them to state business and regulations.

We faced many challenges, challenges of a community trying to grow in a neighborhood that knew little about Islam, and we were not doing enough to integrate ourselves with the larger American community. This challenge grew fiercer and fiercer as the international events and terrorism became commonplace. These challenges were handled though contact with the state government and our local, state, and federal representatives. They were important to the society, and our support for them was also important to them. Holding of interfaith dialogues and opening the society to the outside world through inviting politicians and other elected officials to the ISCJ to educate them about Islam was critical.

I should like to point out our shortcomings in the last forty years. As anyone would attest to, ISCJ has grown considerably in its membership, in its expansions of its physical structures, especially with the ambitious master plan that is being implemented currently. But has ISCJ built a community? The answer will be a resounding NO. While the schools, weekend or full time, provide the religious education for the members' families, that association with the ISCJ ends once the students finish their schools. Parents have no need for the ISCJ once that phase of their children's education is over.

As such, this association is limited to their specific and limited goals. Do the children or their parents come back again to the ISCJ with any regularity? The answer again is NO. Only if they reside in proximity to the ISCJ where it becomes a matter of convenience that they would frequent the ISCJ for the Jumu'ah prayers.

If, on the other hand, ISCJ programs and facilities were constructed with the goal of building a community in mind, a community that shares values and goals outside the religious edicts, you'd have ISCJ members come to the "center" for activities and services other than coming for the Friday prayers.

In essence, building a community requires services and programs other than the Sunday school or the Jumu'ah prayers. What ISCJ's goals going

forward should be are to focus more on building a "community" and less on building structures. That requires not just a mosque but also a "community center," a community center that provides facilities and services geared to Muslims and especially non-Muslims. It should become a center of learning that can appeal to everyone and should include social activities and political activities, from the perspective of educating the community members about their civil rights and their human rights. They should be offered instructions on how to participate and become an effective community in addressing the local, state, and federal issues that confront the community at large. Passion should be stoked among the membership for addressing, if not resolving, social issues that confront the society at large, such as gun control, drug addiction, family violence, among others. The menu of items to be addressed is enormous. The first step is to aim at changing our focus from purely offering a place for prayers to a community center where praying is but one of the services the ISCJ provides.

Another and most important path for the future is for the ISCJ to become a center of learning not only for Muslims but more so for all Americans, focusing on building one community with three faiths—Islam, Christianity, and Judaism. Now we are three communities with three faiths, a status quo that maintains the separation of the New Jersey community along their separate and distinct faith lines, while in fact, the three Abrahamic faiths share more common values than they differ. As such, my motto is "One community, three faiths." I don't know how long it will take to make us one community out of the three that we currently have, but it can be done as it was during the golden age of the Islamic civilization that prospered for seven hundred years. Can it happen again? We can only find out if we study the special features of that era.

Islam's future in America is bright. It is currently at a low point because of the prevailing political atmosphere and the international terrorism that is incorrectly blamed on Islam. However, this is only a temporary setback that will bring out the best in the Islamic values and traditions. It is also dependent on the rejection of the un-Islamic behaviors in the community and the rejection of the radicalization that has begun to spread through unsuspecting Muslims who are taught otherwise. Islamic values focus on the inner strength of the Muslim and not on his or her appearance. It will depend on a proactive approach aimed at bringing the Muslim community closer to the American community at large. It will take some time, but God willing, it will happen.

Br. Morad Abou-Sabe is a former president of the ISCJ and an emeritus professor of Rutgers University.



From The First Constitution Committee To The ISCJ History Project

Br. Shoukat Ali

I came to America in 1968 as a student of electrical engineering and completed my master's in electrical engineering from Drexel University in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. My wife, Farida, and our children, Saba and Basit, joined me in 1970. For the first few years, we were busy acquiring degrees in our respective fields and settling down in our new world. We did not know of any local mosque; therefore, we had to go all the way to New York City for Eid prayers. We were concerned about our children's religious education and wanted to find out if there were any places in New Jersey that were imparting Islamic education to Muslim children.

In 1975, we learned from some Muslim friends that the Eid was being celebrated at Rutgers University campus in New Brunswick, New Jersey. We drove there and learned about a Sunday school that was being taught by Dr. Mahmoud Taher (principal), Dr. Suhail Rifai (seminar leader), and others. Classes were being held in Scott Hall at Rutgers University, New Brunswick. We were so happy to find this place that we started driving there every Sunday morning with our children. There were a couple of classrooms where our children learned basic Arabic and memorized and learned the meaning of the suras while the adults attended a seminar.

We chose to join the ISCJ because of the diversity of cultures among its membership, moderate religious views, and men and women could sit in the same hall without a curtain between them as was the custom in many other mosques. We also liked the open forum of discussions where

both men and women could ask questions about the religion and discuss subjects without fear of intimidation or anyone being judgmental. We liked the seminars, the social functions, the picnics, and the weekend school for the children. We did not find any other mosques that were as organized and provided equal participation for men and women. Some mosques were involved in litigation because of infighting among its members.

It was not easy for us to get ourselves and our children involved in the ISCJ in the beginning. More than me, my wife, Farida, was very particular about getting our children to the ISCJ every Sunday for the weekend school classes. We made this a priority and scheduled all other activities around our Sunday morning trip to the ISCJ Weekend School. It was a tough juggling act to manage the obligations of our professional careers, graduate studies, and other daily life activities. We are glad we were able to do so. We found direction in our lives and made many friends from different cultures at the ISCJ, and our children learned the Islamic way of life.

Before the ISCJ was established, while attending the Sunday gatherings at Rutgers, I learned that a group of Muslims at Rutgers were joining hands with another group of Muslims from Central New Jersey and organizing the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) as a religious nonprofit organization and getting the state's approval. I was intrigued by the whole concept and the vision of these pioneers.

I became interested in joining this organization in whatever capacity I could. I was impressed by the enthusiasm and dedication of the organizers, which included Dr. Babar, Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dr. Mahmoud Taher, Dr. Riaz Iqbal, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, Dr. Nazeer Ahmed, Dr. Matin, and several others. We often held meetings in the parking lot as we did not have a dedicated room to conduct such business.

Later, we held formal meetings at rented spaces at various hotels. At one of these meetings, there was an election of the board, the executive committee, and the Overseers. I was nominated by Br. Abad Ahmad for a secretary's position and was confirmed by majority vote. This was the beginning of my serious involvement with the ISCJ. At that time, the main working committees were the constitution committee, the fund-raising committee, and the building committee. I joined the constitution committee that was headed by Dr. Sheikh Moizul Matin and participated in the discussions leading to the framing of the first ISCJ Constitution.

After Brother Matin retired as the chairperson from the original committee, I was appointed chairman of the constitution committee. I served on this committee for about fifteen years. During my tenure, the constitution was amended with some twenty-five-plus amendments

that were adopted to strengthen the constitution and provided additional safeguards for the society with detailed procedures to conduct the general elections and resolve conflicts. This was a highly rewarding experience for me.

Besides the above, I served the ISCJ in various capacities on the board of trustees, the board of overseers, and other committees. These included chairman of the board of trustees, the president, and the chief overseer.

Currently, I am serving as the chairman of the ISCJ History Project Task Force that consists of Br. Dawud Assad, Sr. Sogra Saleem, Br. Arif Khan, Imam Ahmad Chebli, Sr. Dawlat Chebly, and Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed. The idea of writing the history of the ISCJ was proposed by Imam Chebli in a general assembly meeting in June 2014. We have been working at it diligently for the last two and half years and hope to publish the ISCJ history book and a DVD by the middle of the year 2017.

The ISCJ influenced our whole family by inculcating an awareness of our religion and its guiding principles in us. We became more knowledgeable about the Islamic way of life, which prevented our children from getting influenced by non-Islamic ways of life. We are glad that we succeeded in doing that. Our children are now grown-ups, and they brought their children, Sister Sanna and Sister Jenna, to the ISCJ from their early age. We believe that because of their attending the Sunday school at the ISCJ, they are now practicing Muslims.

Our hope is that the ISCJ, with its schools, imams, and visiting scholars, will continue to provide a source of true knowledge of Islam for Muslims and non-Muslims for a long, long time, inshallah, and shine its light until the end of time. We are very thankful to AllahuTalla for his blessings.

Br. Shoukat Ali is a founding member of the ISCJ and the chairman of the ISCJ History Project Te a m. He is an original member of the ISCJ Constitution Committee, which he headed for fifteen years. Br. Shoukat Ali also served the ISCJ as the chief overseer, the chairman and the president of the ISCJ.



The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)—Then And Now

Sr. Farida S. Ali

In 1975, my husband, Shoukat Ali, and I, along with our two children, Saba and Basit, went to Rutgers University, where Eid prayers were being performed. There we found out about the Islamic school that was operating in Scott Hall building. There were hardly forty students with very few teachers.

Dr. Taher was the school principal with handful of teachers assisting him. Since I was a regular teacher at a high school in America, with teacher's education and a few years of teaching experience, I was requested to teach Islamic studies at the Islamic school held in Scott Hall building. Apart from regular classroom teaching, I was very much interested in helping out with various noncurricular activities, such as helping organize various religious celebrations like the prophet's birthday celebration, Eid celebrations, and cultural programs for end of the year school graduation program.

In 1970s, our Islamic society was more open-minded. What may be considered not proper today was not improper then. For instance, not wearing a headscarf by the ladies, performing religious programs that included singing religious songs by the ladies and the students of the Islamic school, was not considered improper.

I also used to organize plays in which the students of the Islamic school participated. You will be seeing pictures taken on various occasions pertaining to the period that I have mentioned above.

At the end of each school year, I used to help organize sports events for the students of the Islamic school. The photographs of these events,

along with the teachers who participated in helping the school organize and conduct these activities, are included.

I could not have done it without the help of Allah Subhanahu-wa-Ta'la and the tremendous help given to me by brothers and sisters. In early 1980s, I went back to college for higher studies and was not able to continue working for the Islamic school of ISCJ.

From1989 to 1998, I got involved with helping the board of ICOC in establishing the Islamic School of Ocean County, where I lived. After a long absence, I came back to the ISCJ and was asked by the ISCJ's president to organize a women's committee.

In the Sunday school's seminar, with the permission of Imam Chebli, I addressed the ladies to help me organize a women's committee. I received a tremendous response from the ladies. We organized Eid festivals, principal and teachers' appreciation days with great success with the help of Allah Ta'la. Several photographs of that period are being included.

The ISCJ school committee wanted to replace the women's committee by a parent-teacher organization, which was an excellent idea. I handed over the responsibility to the brother who was elected for this job.

I lived in Virginia for the next few years with my husband. We came back to New Jersey some time back, alhamdulillah. With great humility and gratitude, I thank Allah Ta'la for giving us all this opportunity to help each other in writing this forty years of the history of ISCJ. My special thanks to Imam Chebli for coming up with the idea of writing the forty-year history of ISCJ, alhamdulillah.

Sr. Farida Shoukat Ali is a founding member of the ISCJ and a founding member of the ISCJ Weekend School.



The Genesis Of The ISCJ

Br. Mohammed N. Elsaady, PhD

The genesis of the ISCJ goes back to a few Muslim students studying at Rutgers University in the early 1970s. Since there was no way to celebrate Muslim holidays publicly, these students and their families used to get together on those occasions for private celebrations. They would cook food at home; sometimes meet at Scott Hall, Rutgers University; and invite friends from other colleges to partake in the food and the festivities. They would bring homemade Halwa and spend hours discussing and teaching each other topics related to Islam.

By the early 1970s, the nucleus of an Islamic community was formed at Rutgers University. The students formed an organization with the objective of bringing the Muslim students of Rutgers and Muslims living in the surrounding areas together so as to better understand and practice their faith.

As more and more Muslims in the area became aware of the activities of the Rutgers University students, the need for an Islamic center/society, separate from Rutgers University, became apparent. In 1973, the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) was formed with Br. Dawud Assad as the chairman. On May 27, 1975, the society was incorporated as a nonprofit, tax-exempt, religious organization in the state of New Jersey.

In 1975, by the grace of Allah, and the generous and enthusiastic support of local Muslims, 6.4 acres of land were purchased for $70,000 to establish the Islamic Society of Central Jersey. Another $100,000 was raised in April 1979. In addition, the society also received pledges from generous supporters.

The society was looking to house the ISCJ at a good location in Central New Jersey. It chose the junction of Route 1 South and Stouts

Lane in Monmouth Junction in South Brunswick Township as the site of the ISCJ. The site is conveniently located roughly fifty miles from New York City and Philadelphia.

The zoning variance for building a mosque and constructing a community center was granted by the South Brunswick Township Zoning Board in March 1979. Land survey was completed, and a Princeton architecture firm was contracted to draw up the plan for the society.

As the construction costs were rising steeply, it was imperative that the project be completed in the shortest possible time. Several fund-raising events here and from individuals abroad collected about three quarters of a million dollars for the society.

It was decided to build the society in two phases. The first called for the construction of a multipurpose room, which also functioned as the mosque, and a few classrooms and office rooms. This phase was completed and became functional in 1983.

The second phase, which included a proper mosque, was completed in 1990. The mosque is a symbol of religious services based on *Taqwa*. Over the last thirty years, the attendance at the Jumu'ah prayers has increased exponentially, requiring two *Jama'as*, the first one conducted by the imam at noon and the second by a guest scholar at one o'clock.

The mosque is open for all five daily prayers. Every Friday evening, there is a Halaqa, discussing religious topics. During Ramadan, the mosque is open twenty-four hours a day for the worshippers, and *Iftar* is provided every evening for those wishing to break their fast at the ISCJ.

The ISCJ has a library that houses the Qur'an, Hadith, and Islamic books in several languages. The ISCJ offers free medical clinic, newborn baby services, and matrimonial services throughout the year.

The ISCJ offers weekend school for Muslim children—Saturday from 3:00 p.m. to 6 p.m. and Sunday from 10:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m. Concurrently with the weekend school, the society conducts educational seminars for adults that covers Islamic and important non-Islamic topics.

The Islamic school, Noor-Ul-Iman, was established in 1993. In 2004, the first batch of students graduated from high school and went to college. To date, Noor-Ul-Iman School has graduated fourteen batches of students and sent them to prestigious U.S. colleges.

My wife, Attiyaat (may Allah bless her soul), and I are the founding members of the ISCJ.

Dr. Sogra Saleem adds: Dr. Mohamed Elsaady was the treasurer of the ISCJ twice, from 1982–1983 and 1983–1984 (two years). He was a member of the ISCJ Board of Trustees for two years (1984–1986). Dr.

Elsaady served as an overseer for two years (1986–1988) and one year as the chief overseers. He also served as an overseer between 1994 and 1995.

Br. Dawud Assad remembers: I remember that when Dr. Mohamed Elsaady's term as the treasurer of the ISCJ ended, he insisted that I, as the chairman of the board, must sign, acknowledging that I received the last balance of the money in the bank and that he had returned all the ISCJ official documentation to me. He was very proficient, and he also has a certificate and stamp for notarization that he helped us to use always. He wrote the Hajj and Umrah manual and distributed it free to those who needed it.

Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed adds: Dr. Mohamed N. Elsaady was the chairman of the Hajj and Umrah committee of the ISCJ for over thirty years, beginning in the early 1980s. Every year, immediately after Ramadan, Dr. Elsaady would host "Hajj classes" every Sunday after Zuhr prayers. He would cover the religious aspects of performing the Hajj in detail, including a demonstration of how men should wear the ihram clothes. The Hajj classes would culminate in a three-hour (10:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m.) Sunday seminar, which would be addressed by Dr. Elsaady, Imam Chebli, Dr. Suheir Ramadan, and Dr. Elsaady's assistant, Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed. Dr. Elsaady would also advise the would-be Hajjis on mundane matters such as how to conduct oneself in Saudi Arabia. He stressed the necessity of physical fitness for the Hajj. "Hajj is not a picnic," he would say. "It requires physical fitness." He would also advise the would-be Hajjis about the necessity of *Sabr* during the Hajj. "If the travel agents can deliver 80 percent of what they promise, you are lucky!" he would caution the would-be Hajjis.

Dr. Elsaady wrote a booklet on how to perform the Hajj and Umrah. He would distribute the book to everyone performing the Hajj, or intending to perform the Hajj in the future, at cost price ($10), which he would donate to the ISCJ.

In the early years, before Imam Chebli took over the responsibility, Dr. Mohamed N. Elsaady would accompany and act as the religious guide of the ISCJ members performing the Hajj.

Late Dr. Mohamed N. Elsaady and Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady were founding members of the ISCJ. Dr. Elsaady was a former treasurer, member of the board of trustees, chief overseer, and founding chairman of the ISCJ Hajj and Umrah Committee, which he chaired for over thirty years.



A Tribute To Founding Member Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

The name Attiyaat Elsaady may not resonate with many of the current ISCJ membership, however, for those who have been associated with the ISCJ long enough not only know her name but also cherish her spirit and memory. Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady passed away on November 10, 2013. I should like to take this opportunity to reintroduce her to the community.

Sister Attiyaat was one of the most active and enterprising ladies in the formative years of the ISCJ. She, along with her husband, Dr. Mohamed Elsaady, are founding members of the ISCJ. She was a board of trustee in the 1980s and was active on the fund-raising committee, where I had the pleasure of working with her. Before that, she, along with Mumtaz Babar (another founding member), initiated the ladies' auxiliary committee that later transformed into the social activities committee. Sister Attiyaat not only organized social events but also loved to bake and cook for all.

Sister Attiyaat may have been small in stature but had a commanding voice that was well respected by men and women as well as young and old. She was outspoken and passionate about issues for the betterment of the ISCJ. She was a proponent of having a funeral home as one of our first projects. She looked out for women and personally encouraged me to get on the board. She was particular about teaching kids the etiquette of the masjid.

Since she retired and moved away from the ISCJ, she was not able to be physically present, but her heart was always with the ISCJ. She was one of the first members to advocate absentee ballots for seniors. In 2012,

when the constitutional amendment passed the board, I informed her, and she was delighted.

Professionally, Sister Attiyaat worked in the Department of Youth and Family Services. In that capacity, she helped many Muslim and non-Muslim families deal with myriad of personal issues and heal their emotional wounds.

Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady is survived by her husband, Dr. Mohamed Elsaady, a son, and a daughter, along with six grandchildren.

We are going to miss Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady. On behalf of the ISCJ community, I would like to recognize her services and thank her family. May Allah (SWT) reward her in Jannah.

Dr. Sogra Saleem is a founding member of the ISCJ.

Xlibris



The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ): Our Spiritual Beacon

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

We had just moved to Central New Jersey in 1976 when a physician, Dr. Irfanul Huq, who worked with the late Dr. Riaz Iqbal (both founding members of the ISCJ) approached my husband, Mohammed Saleem, MD at the hospital and told him about the ISCJ trying to buy a land to establish a mosque. We soon met with Dr. Abdul Hakim Babar, who happened to live in the same apartment complex as we did. We were invited to their apartment where we met Dr. Riaz Iqbal as well. After that, we became friends with all of them. Our children happened to go to the same schools, and we celebrated Eid together, mostly at Dr. Riaz Iqbal's house. Dr. Riaz Iqbal was the first chairman of the ISCJ Fund-raising Committee.

As Dr. Babar furnished more details of the project, we were completely sold on the idea of the ISCJ. First, because of the Islamic school and second, because of the multiethnic community the ISCJ envisioned, which was very important to us. As we were undergoing our residency training, we could not allot much time to the ISCJ, but we did make a financial commitment to the project. For the next two years, Dr. Babar would periodically update us on the project and, after 1978, remind us without fail about the annual general body meetings.

In 1978, we enrolled our daughter to the Sunday school program, which was held at Rutgers campus. Because of our busy schedule, and a baby at home, we were unable to go to Rutgers regularly. However, we were fortunate to have some friends give our daughter a ride, and Br. Mazhar

Hassan, who happened to be the principal of the weekend school, would usually bring our daughter back, and we would pick her up from his house. In 1983, when the multipurpose room, along with some classrooms, came into existence at the current Route 1 facility, we became regular attendees of the Sunday seminars. Our son also enrolled in the weekend school in 1984. At this time, the seminars were conducted mostly by learned volunteers and founding members like Dr. Suhail Rifai and Dr. Mahmoud Taher. Soon, ISCJ hired its first imam, Imam Sharkawy. Arabic classes were offered, which I took. Those classes helped me learn some basics of the Arabic language.

In 1985, I joined the school committee. However, my tenure was short-lived because of internal turmoil with committee members who were very strong headed. The conflicts could not be resolved; therefore, as a last resort, Chairman Br. Dawud Assad dissolved the committee.

In 1986, I started helping out with the school snack program and got involved with the ladies' auxiliary committee (a precursor to the social activities committee), which was headed by Sr. Mumtaz Babar and the late Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady. We started organizing monthly potluck dinners, Eid celebrations, and so on. A little later, Srs. Nadia Younes and Nasim Din joined in this effort. Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady encouraged and motivated me personally to get involved with the ISCJ board because there were very few active female members on it. I took her advice. Most of these ladies became dear friends to me. In 1986, we had the pleasure of welcoming Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli to the ISCJ. He started a formal Qur'anic Tafseer program every Sunday morning. He also taught some Arabic classes. Attending which became a part of my routine. Over the next three decades, Imam Chebli has become a renowned figure not only in New Jersey but also throughout the USA. We are lucky to have him as our spiritual leader, who is also endowed with enormous interfaith communications and public relations skills.

Continuing to expand my involvement with the ISCJ, I joined the fund-raising committee, where I took an active role and became the chairperson in 1990, when we expanded the masjid to its current size. To this day, I remain a part of the fund-raising committee, and now the expansion funding group (EFG). For a brief period, we operated a scholarship committee to help our graduates financially. Because of lack of funding, this committee did not last long. At the weekend school graduations, I personally started giving gifts to the graduating high school seniors, which became a tradition and has now been adopted by ISCJ Board of Trustees.

I was a member of library committee when we started cataloging all the books and purchased new bookcases to house these books. I was the

only female member of the long-range planning committee, which came up with several projects, including prioritizing Noor-Ul-Iman School building and operating a burial preparation home. Interestingly, till the late 1980s, only past presidents and chairmen could be members of this committee, all of whom happened to be men. I objected to this practice, and after that, the policy was amended, and female members of the board of trustees were also included.

For the last fifteen years, I have been, and continue to be, a member of the constitution committee. I have also worked on several task forces, such as the constitution committee, steering committee, NUI School, present masjid renovation/expansion, and currently the ISCJ history project.

The ISCJ's free medical clinic was started in 1994 with a handful of physicians. Dr. Amar Bukhari took charge of it for the first two years. It was open to Muslims and non-Muslim patients alike. At that time, Dr. Zuhair Abbasi, along with my husband, Dr. Mohammed Saleem, and Dr. Soheir Ramadan helped furnish the clinic and stock it with medical supplies and medication. I helped coordinate the activities of the clinic from 1996 to 2016. My husband, Dr. Mohammed Saleem, has been involved with the clinic since its inception; he has been the major contributor to the running of the clinic.

The clinic has provided free flu shots, arranged for Hajj vaccinations at cost price, and given much-needed help to the elderly of our community as well as young children and youth. An automated external defibrillator (**AED**) was donated by my husband to ISCJ in 2014 for any emergency. As we embarked on the burial preparation home, as a pathologist with expertise in dealing with the agency, I advised the committee on how to navigate through the New Jersey State of Mortuary Science to accomplish this goal.

From 1991 through 2011, I have served as a trustee on the ISCJ board for seventeen years (five three-year terms and two one-year appointments), including seven years as the secretary and three years as the executive secretary. In addition, I served as an overseer for two years as well as one year on NUI board. As the executive secretary, I was the first to start recording the annual general body meeting (AGBM) proceedings.

At NUI, I helped revise their current bylaws. During my tenure as a trustee, I had the opportunity to work with many members, chairpersons, or presidents like Br. Mahmoud Taher, Br. Dawud Assad, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, Br. Morad Abou-Sabe, Br. Riaz Siddiqui, Br. Mohommed Siddiqui, Br. Ghouse Ismail, Br. Tarik Abdala, Br. Khan Zafar Iqbal, Br. Parvaiz Malik, Br. Magdy Hagag, Br. Alan Bowman, and Br. Muhammad Ashraf to name a few. As an overseer, I worked with Br. Saffet Catovic,

Br. Abbas Shaikh, Br. Arif Khan, and Sr. Atiya Aftab. May Allah (SWT) bless them all.

Br. Mahmoud Taher's handwritten list of founding members was entrusted to the board, and I, being the secretary, kept it. Although this list was printed earlier in the *Noor-Ul-Islam* magazine, it was never displayed. In 1993, when Br. Ghouse Ismail was the president, the board authorized a plaque to be made with all the names as a tribute. This was accomplished and displayed in the library at first.

Over the years, I have had the pleasure of working with many old and also young tech-savvy members of the ISCJ, who do and accomplish things efficiently. One of the young females is Atiya Aftab, whom I know for a long time and have had the pleasure of working with in multiple settings, from the ISCJ Board of Trustees to the constitution committee and task forces. In 2012, when she was elected as first female chairperson of ISCJ, it was a great accomplishment for women at the ISCJ. This prompted me to write an article titled "Women Are an Integral Part of ISCJ."

We have lost some dear friends like Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady and, more recently, Dr. Riaz Iqbal, whom we will miss. (See their tributes.)

The ISCJ holds a unique place in our lives. Both our daughter and son are alumni of ISCJ Weekend School and have learned a lot from their teachers. To this date, their close friends are from ISCJ. Imam Chebli performed our daughter Asra's marriage, and our son, Asgar Saleem, comes to the ISCJ as a guest Khateeb occasionally. Although there are other mosques that have come up in our neighborhood, we still cherish the ISCJ and do not mind traveling longer distance to be a part of our beloved community. We get not only the feeling of being at home but also a spiritual uplifting every time we are at the ISCJ. May Allah (SWT) preserve the ISCJ. Ameen!

Dr. Sogra and Dr. Mohammed Saleem are two of the founding members of the ISCJ. They have served the ISCJ for decades in numerous capacities. They are two of the stalwarts of the ISCJ.



From Rutgers University In The Early 1970s To The Present

Br. Mohommed Siddiqui

The idea of establishing an Islamic center in Central Jersey started in early 1970s. While there were Islamic centers existing in Paterson and Jersey City, there was no masjid or Islamic school for children from Edison to Trenton in New Jersey.

During the period 1971 through 1978 when I was a student at Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey, I was also the vice president and later president of Rutgers University's Muslim Students Association (MSA). Brs. Muhammad El-Nakah of Egypt and Ghulam Hussain of Pakistan were also with me in the association. There were about eight or ten other Muslim students in the university at that time.

Initially, we started praying our Friday Jumu'ah prayers regularly in graduate students lounge on College Avenue. In 1972, Br. Mahmoud Taher, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad of Egypt, and Br. Suhail Rifai of Syria approached me and requested to reserve few classrooms on Sundays for teaching Islamic studies to children. The university gladly permitted us to avail the facility in the basement of Scott Hall on College Avenue.

That is how a weekend Islamic school for children started functioning at Rutgers University, where teachers like Sharon Taha, Nabil Taha, Farida Ali, and others taught the children. Br. Suhail Rifai conducted sessions for the adults. Very soon, the number of children exceeded the capacity available, and we were moved to Douglass University campus area. We also used other facilities of Rutgers University, such as Tillet Hall in Livingston College, Gibbons Hall in Douglass College, and so on for Friday and Eid prayers.

We had some fund-raising dinners at Douglass campus to raise money for establishing a possible Islamic center in the area. Br. Mahmoud Taher,

the Taha Family, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, Brother Fakhry, and others were very actively involved in looking for a suitable site. We had few meetings at Brother Riad's residence in North Brunswick in this regard.

From 1978 through 1982, I was out of the area and lost touch with the community. I moved back to South Brunswick in 1982 and joined the community again. I was glad to see that an Islamic society had been incorporated and a meeting hall with five classrooms were constructed. We were praying in the multipurpose rooms while the *Mussallah* was being constructed.

From 1983 through 2007, by Allah's blessings and support from the community, I was able to get actively involved in many capacities with the ISCJ. I served the society as member or chairman of fund-raising committee, library committee, membership committee, and building committee. I was elected to board of trustees in 1984 and served the board as treasurer, secretary, and president for multiple terms.

During this period, the society grew by leaps and bounds. Our membership exceeded more than five hundred families, and expansion continued in all sectors. Imam Chebli and some other members of the society were recognized at city, state, and federal levels as community leaders. I was appointed to the library foundation board and human relation commission by the mayor of South Brunswick. Working closely with South Brunswick Library, I cultivated a very positive relationship with them. In particular, they were very sympathetic to our needs and provided book mobile services to serve the Noor-Ul-Iman School. They also allocated a portion of the township library building for Islamic books, copies of the Qur'an and Hadith. The society also donated a large sum of money to the library and a front-end desk. The ISCJ's name was displayed prominently at the entrance of the library. The Noor-Ul-Iman seniors were the chief speakers at their annual dinner parties for several years.

In late 1990s, when we embarked upon a plan to open an Islamic school, we ran into some hurdles with the neighborhood as well as with the township. However, with the help of many interfaith meetings and open houses and meetings with our neighbors, we were able to iron out the issues, and Alhamdulillah, today we enjoy excellent relations with our neighbors, the township, and the local police. As a result, the phase 1 and phase 2 of our school expansion project have been successfully completed, and we are now on our way to starting phase 3.

We are blessed with a very generous and cooperative community. May Allah bless all of us with peace and harmony and guide us to the right path.

Br. Mohommed Siddiqui is a former president of the ISCJ.



Our Journey Through The Good And The Bad Times

Br. Parvaiz Malik, MD

In 1985, I moved from California to Central New Jersey to raise my family here because I had heard great things about the values and traditions practiced by this growing Muslim community. Almost immediately, I was welcomed with open arms, furthering my resolve to get involved with the ISCJ. We have been blessed with great friends we made at the masjid over the years. Our kids graduated from the ISCJ Weekend School, and our daughter was a student of Noor-Ul-Iman School.

After being actively engaged for ten years in various roles with the ISCJ, I was elected to the board of trustees in 1996 (for the first of two terms). In 1997, I was appointed as treasurer, which was quite a challenge for a physician. Alhamdulillah, for the first time in ISCJ's history, I was able to introduce QuickBooks and computerized the accounting system to manage our finances more efficiently.

I was selected to serve as ISCJ liaison to the board of directors of Noor-Ul-Iman School in 1998. The NUI was established in 1993 after two previously failed attempts at opening a full-time Islamic school on the ISCJ premises. During this period, I worked with the board to improve the essential business policies and keep the school functioning despite limited resources and financial challenges. The popularity of the school was on the rise with many families moving to the area primarily to have their children enrolled at Noor-Ul-Iman School. I continued to serve on NUI board after getting reelected to second three-year term to ISCJ Board of Trustees. I was also involved with the weekend school and invited local, state, and federal politicians

and professors from Princeton University to participate in graduation ceremonies.

By 2000, the ISCJ was a respected and admired community. The community was well known to the political community as many Muslims were being elected to various public offices, from the township to the state level. As a nonprofit organization, the ISCJ did not endorse any political candidate, but we started inviting all candidates to the mosque so that they could interact and get to know us and help our community decide who they wanted to vote for.

The ISCJ made the headlines in the national press when newly elected New Jersey governor Jim McGreevy chose to come to ISCJ mosque to strengthen relationship with the Muslim community. Earlier, he had apologized to Muslims for denunciation of a Muslim group during his election campaign. I was proud to be a founding member and the first president of the American Muslim Council, New Jersey Chapter, which was created and supported by many ISCJ members and leaders. Around the same time, I was also elected to be the chairman of ISCJ Board of Trustees for years 2001–2002 with Mohommed Siddiqui as president. At this time, our community was lauded as one of the most actively engaged large Muslim communities in the USA. The future of Muslims in America appeared to be bright.

And then came 9/11, which changed our political and cultural landscape forever. Being close to ground zero, the ISCJ leadership was extremely concerned about the safety of the Muslims and the expected backlash against them. Within hours of the tragedy, our congressman Rush Holt called to extend his support and assistance to deal with the situation. We invited the local and federal law enforcement agencies to the ISCJ to ensure the safety of our members and the masjid.

Two days after the tragedy, we held a *Janaza* prayer for the Muslim victims of 9/11 as well as prayers for all souls that were lost on that day. I called for a press conference on September 14 at the ISCJ library after Jumu'ah prayer, and we released a statement of condemnation of the attack. That same evening, there was a vigil at Palmer Square in Princeton after a peace rally, where all religions participated. I spoke at that event, and I remember trying to comprehend how these attacks could be perpetrated by people who claimed to belong to our faith. In that moment, I remember being fully aware of the gravitas of the task of representing all Muslims at this event as well as ISCJ in particular.

We had originally scheduled an open house for the neighbors on September 30, 2001, as routine yearly event. This particular year, it turned into an interfaith meeting. Representatives of several faiths, churches,

synagogues, temples, local police, and fire department participated. This historical gathering of 1,500 was the very beginning of interfaith events at the ISCJ. Interfaith gatherings are now held every year at the ISCJ.

We collectively took out a full-page advertisement in the state's largest daily, the *Star Ledger*, honoring the 9/11 first responders who lost their lives to save many others. We participated in other vigils in the area, including one at Robert Wood Johnson Hospital in Hamilton, where I addressed the gathering and offered prayer. Our Imam Hamad Chebli participated in similar event at the Princeton University, where the wife of Vice Pres. Dick Cheney also spoke. Not only did we lose community members in this terrorist attack, but also several of our members came down with post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). We offered counseling services for those who needed it and held many informal gatherings at the masjid after *Isha* prayer.

Our response to the horrors of 9/11, both as a masjid and as a community, is something that we should all be proud of. We handled ourselves with dignity and respect and held fast together, along with the greater community of our neighbors and friends.

Over the next several years, our community continued to grow. We acquired several homes and land on sale adjacent to the mosque and became a seventeen-acre large society. We attended several South Brunswick Township Zoning Board meetings and finally received approval of substantial portion of the master expansion plan that we had applied for. I continued my involvement with ISCJ as chairman of the membership committee. I was reelected to the ISCJ Board of Trustees in 2007–2009, working with Br. Aly Abdel Aziz as president during my tenure as chairman of the board of trustees. I had an excellent team of board members to work with, and we had very productive three years. The influx of new families meant a growing school, and we finally settled on expansion plans for Noor-Ul-Iman School, followed by fund-raising efforts, groundbreaking, and finally the construction of the first phase of the school.

During this term, we had some other great advancements within the masjid community, in some of which I am proud to have played a part. For example, I worked with Imam Chebli to start two Jumu'ah prayers to ease the parking problems as suggested by my son Shiraz, who was living in the Chicagoland community at the time. We also made the decision to follow National Fiqh Council to celebrate Eid al-Fitr and follow Saudi Arabia to celebrate Eid al-Adha so as to be able to celebrate the Day of Arafat the same day. I also spearheaded designation of ISCJ and the entire property as a "smoke-free zone."

Today as I reflect on my time as a member of this community, I am humbled and blessed to have been able to serve Allah (SWT) and our community at the ISCJ. My family is also blessed, having had my children in the weekend school growing up, my daughter a student of NUI, and now my grandson in the first grade at NUI.

The ISCJ is not just a mosque; it is a diversified Muslim community, strategically located between two great academic institutions, Princeton and Rutgers universities, and is a resource of information on Islam and Muslim life for the students of both. A masjid, a full-time Islamic school, a weekend school, a Qur'an Academy, and many other activities make the Islamic Society of Central Jersey a unique Islamic organization. "Honor the Religion, Realize the Vision" is our slogan.

In this historic journey with ISCJ, I had an incredible companion, my wife, Adeeba Malik, who has been the source of guidance and advice for me. May Allah (SWT) reward her.

I am very proud to be able to serve Allah (SWT) and our community at the ISCJ. May Allah (SWT) reward us if we did something good and forgive our shortcomings.

Dr. Parvaiz Malik is a former president and Chairman of the ISCJ Board of Trustees.



Recollection Of My Association With The ISCJ

Br. Muhammad Ashraf

My association with the Islamic Society of Central Jersey began in 1977 when we moved to Central New Jersey from New York City. At the time, our eldest daughter was four years old. My wife and I thought that she was ready to take lessons in Islamic education, along with her regular school. Since there were no mosques in Central Jersey at that time, we found out that Islamic classes were being held on weekends at the Rutgers University campus in New Brunswick. Our daughter started attending weekend school at Rutgers, which was truly a blessing. My other two daughters also attended the weekend school and then volunteered to become assistant teachers.

At the weekend school, we started getting acquainted with other parents. I can count many whom we now refer to as the founding members of the ISCJ. Few have passed away; others are still around, Mashallah.

In June of 1986, when Br. Hamad Chebli joined the ISCJ as its imam, as I recall, the first Khatme Qur'an ceremony was for my daughter Sofia. The celebrations were held in the first permanent building of the ISCJ, which at that time was used as prayer hall and multipurpose room as well as for all other gatherings.

As I recall, in those days, the ISCJ did not employ any person/s or company to clean the premises. Many sisters helped clean the masjid and adjoined support areas as volunteers. Many sisters used to bring home-cooked food and sold those to school children to support the masjid.

During 1990s, I started getting involved with the ISCJ Board of Trustees. During 1993–1996, I was elected the treasurer of the ISCJ. At that time, we used to write checks for staff and vendors by hand.

In year 2001, while I was the president of the ISCJ and Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad the chairman, a fast-food chain attempted to purchase about four acres of vacant land north of the ISCJ and filed an application with the South Brunswick Township for the construction of a restaurant. The ISCJ community, with the active support and participation of its neighbors, vehemently opposed the zoning change and succeeded in denial of the application. In fact, the seller was pressured to cancel the sale to the restaurant chain. Eventually, the ISCJ purchased the land. Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad was the sole donor for the purchase of that piece of land. Had the ISCJ not been successful in persuading the South Brunswick Township not to change the zoning, the ISCJ would have had no chance for future expansion. In years that followed, the ISCJ also purchased contiguous residential properties along Richard Road. With all those purchases, the ISCJ accumulated sixteen acres of prime land on its premises.

Over the years, the ISCJ has functioned very professionally under the leadership of many dedicated brothers and sisters. Many ISCJ committees have done commendable job to serve the community.

Most challenging job for the ISCJ and its members was during the years 2005–2012 when the ISCJ embarked upon a project to expand its existing facilities and applied to the South Brunswick Township for the approval of its master plan.

The master plan was composed of expanding the existing masjid; constructing a permanent building for the Noor-Ul-Iman School, an office building, and senior residential housing; retaining an existing structure for a burial preparation house; and providing for an on-site multilevel parking structure. Numerous meetings were held at the South Brunswick Township as the master plan was scrutinized by the South Brunswick Township Zoning Board. Eventually, the South Brunswick Zoning Board approved all that the ISCJ had applied for except the senior housing.

Construction of a permanent school building was of paramount importance because of the rapid growth in the enrollment at the Noor-Ul-Iman School. After multiple fund-raising events, and thanks to the generosity of the ISCJ community, the school building opened to students in two phases, first in September 2012 and second in September 2014. This was made possible because of the remarkable participation and generosity of the members of the ISCJ community at large. Another less- talked-about but vitally important facility that is regularly used is the burial preparation house.

Br. Muhammad Ashraf is the current president of the ISCJ. He was the Chairman of the Board of Trustees (ISCJ) when the history project was started.



My Contributions To The ISCJ

Br. Manzoor Hussain, PhD

I came to the USA in June 1966 for graduate studies. I received my MS in entomology (1968) from the University of Nevada, Reno, and PhD in chemistry (1973) from the University of California, Riverside. In 1973, I married Jana Hussain (1973), who converted from a Catholic to Muslim before the Nikah. In 1974, we went to Iran. I served for two years as an assistant professor at the University of Shiraz. We moved to New Jersey in 1976 to work as a research chemist at American Cyanamid Company in Princeton, New Jersey. In 1983, I took up a senior level position with the government of Pakistan in Islamabad.

I returned to the USA in 1985 and worked in environmental remediation industry. In 1987, I took up a position as the head of agrochemical laboratory of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) in Vienna, Austria. I worked there for the next twelve years.

I returned to the USA in 1999 and taught chemistry, first at Fairleigh Dickinson University (FDU), Morristown, New Jersey, and later at The College of New Jersey (TCNJ) in Ewing, New Jersey. I taught Islamic studies at Noor-Ul-Iman School for twelve years (2004–2016). Currently, I am active in several interfaith programs in West Windsor.

Involvement with Muslim Community of Central Jersey and the ISCJ
I got involved with the Muslim community of Central New Jersey in 1976. My contributions include the following:

1. Before the ISCJ was built, the community members used to hold Islamic studies classes on weekends at Rutgers University. Dr. Suhail Rifai and Dr. Mahmoud Taher were the main lecturers. I lectured sometimes.

2. I am a founding member of the ISCJ.
3. My wife, Jana, and I participated in the ISCJ interfaith dialogue programs.
4. I was a member of the family support committee during 2003–2004. I was the only male member of the eight-member group, and I assisted Dr. Fatima Aziz, the chairperson, in providing support to local Muslim families (see page 49 of the ISCJ Annual General Body Meeting Report for 2003–2004).
5. The group addressed issues such as domestic violence, unemployment, youth issues, marital discord, grief cases, economic despondency, and health problems. For example, I assisted in organizing a symposium on domestic violence on April 20, 2003 (see attached copy of flyer). Participants included a representative of Manavi Shelter, West Windsor Police Department, and a clinical psychiatrist from the Islamic Center of Long Island. On September 14, 2003, I assisted the Family Support Group in organizing a seminar titled "Legislation Affecting Families and Children in New Jersey." New Jersey assemblywoman Linda Greenstein was the keynote speaker.
6. I have also been one of the Khateebs for the Friday Salat at the ISCJ and have delivered several Khutbahs.
7. I have taught Islamic studies to high school students at Noor-Ul-Iman School for twelve years (2004–2016).
8. I authored a book in 2012 titled *ISLAM: An Essential Understanding for Fellow Americans* published by Vantage Press, New York.

Dr. Manzoor Hussain is a founding member of the ISCJ. He is also a university professor, former Islamic studies teacher at the Noor-Ul-Iman School, a Khateeb, and an author.



Why I Was Drawn To The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Riaz A. Siddiqui

In the name of ALLAH, the most compassionate, the most merciful.

All praises are due to ALLAH (SWT).

I grew up in the city of Hyderabad, India. After graduating in mechanical engineering from Osmania University, I taught for approximately four years in the Engineering College. I then came to the USA in 1966 for graduate studies and completed master's degree in 1967. During 1967–1980, I worked in different industries in Connecticut, New Jersey, and New York states. In the early 1970s, I met Br. Dawud Assad, who is also a mechanical engineer, as both of us were attending evening graduate courses at Newark College of Engineering, which has now been renamed the New Jersey Institute of Technology (NJIT). Around same time frame, I met Br. Suhail Rifai during Eid prayers, which used to be held at Rutgers University premises.

In 1980, we were living in rural Upstate New York and were concerned about Islamic education for our son. I was actively seeking to relocate to an area that offered Islamic education for Muslim children. Among the offers for job that I received, the most desirable was from a Princeton-based company, where my first supervisor who hired me was Br. Muhammad Ashraf. Alhamdulillah, the move proved to be very productive.

The ISCJ at that time used to hold weekend classes for Muslim kids at Rutgers University. I thank ALLAH (SWT) first and then the community for giving me the privilege, honor, and pleasure to serve the ISCJ community in various capacities. My involvement started with a brief (about a year) appointment as the secretary of the weekend school committee. It was

followed by about nine years on the ISCJ Board of Trustees as secretary, executive secretary, president, overseer, and chief overseer. I also had the privilege of serving briefly on the Noor-Ul-Iman School Board and about five years each as chairman of the seminar committee and the religious committee.

These experiences were challenging and rewarding at the same time. Our community faced many challenges, but ALLAH (SWT) blessed us with a good imam, many generous and wise community leaders, and members to pull us through those. Our community is blessed with a collection of diverse nationalities like a little United Nations. There were times when we were on the brink of being divided along nationalities, but Alhamdulillah, ALLAH's guidance kept us united.

One of the early challenges was the decision whether to build a prayer hall first or a multipurpose room first. We did not have sufficient resources to build both. In a general body meeting, we decided to build the multipurpose room first.

We also successfully opposed a KFC franchise from locating close to the ISCJ.

Our community learned an important lesson when we applied to the South Brunswick Township for expanding our parking lot in the 1990s. For Jumu'ah prayers on Fridays, we needed extra parking space. Some members parked on side streets, for which our non-Muslim neighbors used to complain. To solve the problem, we decided to expand the parking lot, even though we were short of funds. To our surprise, when public hearing was held for township's approval, many neighbors objected. The mayor of the township postponed the decision and wisely advised us to hold an open house to educate our neighbors about the ISCJ's activities. We did that and were shocked to hear some of the questions that our neighbors had asked and the misconceptions they had about Muslims.

Alhamdulillah, we satisfied their concerns and obtained the approval from township in the next hearing without any objection from the neighbors. We learned that "fear of the unknown" makes people associate all undesirable characteristics with the unknown. Since then, the ISCJ has been holding regular open houses and participating in interfaith activities throughout the year.

In summary, I thank ALLAH (SWT) for giving me the opportunity to associate with and serve the ISCJ. I encourage all members of the ISCJ to actively participate and volunteer whenever they can.

Br. Riaz A. Siddiqui is a former president of the ISCJ, who has also served the society in numerous other capacities.



A Tribute And Write-Up To Br. Mohammed Aziz, MD and Sr. Fatima Aziz, PhD Two Of The ISCJ's Distinguished Members

Sr. Zareen Ahmed, PhD

Dr. Mohammed A. Aziz and Dr. Fatima Aziz were part of a core group of Central New Jersey Muslims who devoted a significant amount of their time and resources to help build the ISCJ and to improve its services and facilities to better serve the growing Muslim population of the area. Dr. Mohammad Aziz and Dr. Fatima Aziz are two of the most distinguished members of the ISCJ.

Dr. and Mrs. Aziz joined the ISCJ when they moved to New Jersey in 1980 and were longtime senior members. Dr. Mohammed Aziz, a native of Faridpur, Bangladesh, and a physician by training, was a highly accomplished researcher at Merck laboratories, where he pioneered a research on river blindness, a research that benefited thousands of people in rural Africa and culminated in the award of the 2015 Nobel Prize in Medicine.

Sadly, Dr. Aziz passed away in 1987, and although the Nobel Committee held a special presession to recognize his contribution, he could not be formally named in the 2015 Nobel Prize winning team because the Nobel Committee does not award Nobel Prizes posthumously.

Following in his father's footsteps, Dr. Aziz's son, Dr. Shahid Aziz, has founded a nonprofit organization named Smile Bangladesh. Several times

a year, Dr. Shahid Aziz takes a team of surgeons and surgically repairs facial cleft deformities of children and adults for free in his father's native Bangladesh and in the rest of the world.

Dr. Fatima Aziz is one of the most qualified sisters at the ISCJ. She has a PhD in microbiology from the University College, London, UK, and has taught at the University of Maryland before moving to New Jersey. Originally from Bangalore, India, she comes from a highly educated family; is very well-read; has diverse interests, including in religion, medicine, and politics; and is a prolific writer whose articles have been published in the *Trenton Times* and in other newspapers in the area.

After the untimely demise of her husband, Dr. Fatima Aziz bravely and single-handedly raised her two brilliant teenage sons, Dr. Shahid Aziz and Dr. Abid Aziz, who are alumni of the ISCJ weekend school and are now physicians living and practicing in New Jersey. Dr. Fatima Aziz sacrificed her own professional career to take care of her teenage sons and to devote herself to community service, both in the West Windsor Township, as well as for the Muslim community at large in Central New Jersey.

In the West Windsor Township, where she has lived since 1980, Dr. Fatima Aziz is a well-recognized and respected citizen, was the chairperson of the Human Relations Council, was an active member of the senior citizens center, and was instrumental in building bridges between Muslim and the non-Muslim community. During Ramadan and Eid, Dr. Fatima Aziz organized displays of Muslim artifacts and Qur'anic calligraphy in the township building lobby and arranged to share traditional Eid delicacies with the township officials. She was also active in other West Windsor Township activities, such as participating in the Memorial Day parade, sponsoring an annual prize to a West Windsor-Plainsboro high school graduate, and volunteering at the after-school program.

At the ISCJ, Dr. Fatima Aziz has always strived to initiate and improve the quality of the social services and was never bashful in being the voice of the silent sisters. She strongly objected to ethnic and gender discriminations and was very outspoken about ensuring equality for all members for the betterment of the society. She was always very active in the seminars, gave her input on a variety of topics, and engaged the speakers with incisive questions. She was also involved in the weekend school committee in the 1980s and served as an overseer on the ISCJ board for two years from 2000 to 2002.

Another of Dr. Fatima Aziz's major contributions at the ISCJ was the formation of the social services committee, which she chaired. She helped the distressed women going through divorce and physical and emotional

abuse, and assisted them emotionally and financially, and also offered recommendations on legal options after consultation with attorneys.

In addition to Dr. Fatima Aziz's in-depth knowledge of the Qur'an and Sunna, and command of Qur'anic Arabic, she is also an avid reader and is very well versed in both English and Urdu languages and literature. She also has a melodious voice and participated in heartfelt renditions of *Nasheeds* at the ISCJ and in private functions.

Dr. Fatima Aziz has been a role model for many Muslim sisters. She has inspired them not only to be active within their own Muslim communities but also to engage with their neighbors, to participate in interfaith meetings as well as in social and cultural events. Dr. Mohammed A. Aziz and Dr. Fatima Aziz have been major financial backers of the ISCJ.

Dr. Zareen Ahmed, a scientist, is a longtime member of the ISCJ. Founding member Dr. Sogra Saleem also contributed to this tribute.

Xlibris



A Tribute To ISCJ's Founding Member Br. Mohamed Abul Bashar, PhD

Sr. Mona Bashar, MD

Sundays during my childhood were almost always spent at the various precursors of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey. It was the mid-1970s, and my family had recently immigrated to the United States from our native Bangladesh to find a new life in New Jersey. My family consisted of my father, Dr. Mohamed Abul Bashar; my younger sister, Bela Rosa Bashar; our devoted grandmother Mrs. Kaniz Fatima Mahmuda; and me. My mother was gone, having been killed by a soldier's bullet in December 1971 at the tail end of Bangladesh's war for independence.

My father had tried to make a life for us in newly independent Bangladesh even after my mother's passing, but he found the political climate there too volatile. Disillusioned and probably shaken by the tragedy in our lives, although he was never one to be too open with his emotions, he decided to move us to the United States. Back in those days, there were only a handful of Muslim families living in the Central New Jersey area. Somehow, and I actually don't remember how, my father sought them out, and our weekly Sunday gatherings became a focal point in our lives.

My father was no stranger to the United States. He was born in rural Chittagong, Bangladesh (at that time, it was a part of British India) on March 1, 1925. He was the youngest of five children and showed an early aptitude for academics. Instead of staying to work the family farmland, his mother strongly encouraged him to seek higher education. He went on to study at the prestigious Presidency College in Calcutta and secured

a scholarship for graduate studies at the University of Colorado School of Mines in Golden, Colorado.

He came to the United States alone with a less than full grasp of English but was armed with an amazing spirit of adventure, a deep appreciation of the opportunity, and a keen mind eager for learning. At the age of twenty-nine, he earned his doctorate in chemical engineering in 1954 and remained in the United States to work in the petroleum industry, mainly in California. In 1963, he became a naturalized American citizen. The opportunity to work in Karachi, Pakistan, and be closer to his native land and family drew him back to the Indian subcontinent in 1966. He soon met my mother, Dr. Ayesha Choudhury, through his old college friend. They married in 1968, had a family, and, for a few short years, were able to establish a home in Dhaka.

My father wanted to take what he learned in the United States and bring positive, modernizing change to his homeland. His years of work in Bangladesh was highlighted by his tenure as the chief works manager for Titas Gas Company, which was the nation's first energy company. Under his guidance and through the guiding principles he had learned in the United States, my father laid down the infrastructure that supplies natural gas to the city of Dhaka. I know that he was very pleased to play a part in helping his native country grow. It was his dream to be able to use his education and experience for the betterment of the country. However, the civil unrest that developed in Bangladesh in the mid-1970s forced him to abandon his dream.

My father's return to the United States in 1975 because of tragic circumstances with two young daughters in tow fueled his desire to belong to a Muslim community, where he knew he would find an anchor for his cultural and spiritual identity. In finding the then small community that was the precursor to the ISCJ, there was a sense of belonging and togetherness. The families hailed from all over the world, but what bought us and kept us together was our common religion and shared experiences of being raised as Muslim children in a secular nation.

We had no set meeting place that we could call our own and instead rented space from Rutgers University in New Brunswick. One week it would be Frelinghuysen Hall, another week Campbell Hall, and another week, we would meet at the Douglass campus. Wherever we could find space was where we would meet. We kids would spend the morning learning Arabic, Islamic history, and practices of our religion. Many parents volunteered and selflessly gave their time to pass on these teachings to the next generation. We made friends from all over the world—Egypt, Palestine, North Africa, and Asia. The best part of the morning was, of

course, snack time. While the children were in class, the adults would congregate and have discussions about various topics. The morning would conclude with Zuhr prayers and sometimes a community lunch.

We had no imam in the early days of the ISCJ. The community was instead led by learned individuals who had a strong desire to maintain our Islamic traditions. Eid prayers were also led by these individuals or by visiting imams. Eid prayers were also held in Rutgers University halls. There were other social events as well. I fondly remember the many picnics we had in nearby parks. Even though the Sunday drive from our house to the New Brunswick ISCJ was nearly one-and-a-half-hour round trip, it was well worth the effort. We met many families through the ISCJ with friendships that have lasted decades.

As the years went on, the Muslim community grew, and the space at Rutgers University became inadequate. There was also a strong desire to establish a place to call our own. With this in mind, the members of the core ISCJ community set out to build a masjid and community center that ultimately resulted in the present-day ISCJ building located in Monmouth Junction. It was many years in planning and fund-raising, requiring the efforts and vision of many people. My father was one of these individuals who was dedicated to this vision from its inception and worked diligently through the years, giving of his time, support, and money to see it succeed. My father was never one to speak loudly or need or desire attention. He was humble and preferred to work quietly and steadily. He never needed to be thanked or be praised. He considered the results of his work to be more than sufficient for his efforts. He was honored that he was named one of the founding members of the ISCJ.

My father continued to take us to Sunday gatherings at the ISCJ once the Monmouth Junction building was completed, although by then, my sister and I were well into our teenage years. I was quite happy that in the end, for a year or two, my sister and I were able to attend a mosque and community center we could call our own. The masjid part of the center was actually completed in 1990 after I had left home to attend university, and I was only able to visit sporadically. My father continued to attend and support the ISCJ long after my sister and I left home.

My father was at heart a country boy who grew up among the rice fields in Bangladesh. Somehow through hard work, determination, and a steadfast faith in his religion, he traveled halfway around the world and raised two daughters as a single parent. His life was not easy, but his deep faith transcended the hardships. He had a strong desire to give his children a solid foundation, and he knew that establishing the ISCJ was an essential part of this foundation. As an adult now with two children of my own, I

fully realize the importance of this. My father would be very pleased to see how the ISCJ has flourished today.

My father lost his battle with cancer in March 1997. His *Janaza* prayer was performed at the ISCJ just as he would have wished.

Dr. Mona Bashar and Dr. Bela Bashar are the two daughters of ISCJ's founding member Dr. Mohamed Abul Bashar. They are also the great-granddaughters of the renowned freedom fighter and statesman of Bengal, British India, and Sir Syed Nawsher Ali.

Xlibris



Thirty-Four Years With The ISCJ And The Noor-Ul-Iman School

Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed, D.Phil.

My wife, Dr. Zareen Ahmed, and I, along with our six-month old son, Zareef, moved from suburban Philadelphia into the now demolished Hibben-Magie Apartments of Princeton University, by Lake Carnegie, in September 1983. As Zareen and I carried out postdoctoral research at Princeton University's Chemistry Department (Frick), we looked for a mosque. No mosque was nearby. For the first few months, we prayed Jumu'ah in the basement of Princeton University's church. At the request of the Muslim undergraduate students of the university, the Princeton University authorities allowed the students the use of the church basement for Jumu'ah prayers only.

Students of the university led the Jumu'ah prayers. As the students were rushing from class to class, Jumu'ah Khutbah was short, sometimes less than five minutes long. Muslims working in companies around Princeton who were not associated with the university also attended the Jumu'ah prayers at the basement of the church.

When our younger son, Tamiz, was born in Princeton at the end of December 1984, we renewed our search for a mosque with more vigor. I do not recall who told us about the ISCJ, but I remember that we first visited the ISCJ either in late 1983 or early 1984. I also remember attending the Eid al-Fitr prayer and the accompanying festivities at the ISCJ premises in June 1984. The imam at that time was a genial gentleman from Egypt, Imam Ahmed Sharkawy, who, after about a year with us, left to take up an assignment in Canada. We did not have an imam for a while before Imam Hamad Chebli joined the ISCJ in 1986.

Up until 1990, there was no structure beyond the current multipurpose room, which functioned as the masjid; seminar room; room for other gatherings; and dining room. Adjacent to the multipurpose room were some classrooms and office rooms. The road adjacent to the ISCJ's main entrance was the parking lot with parking facilities available for approximately forty cars. The attendance at Jumu'ah prayers was well under eighty. One could come late and still be confident of finding a parking space.

The current facility opened in 1990. It was this year that we enrolled our two sons at the weekend school. They graduated ten years later. We remain grateful to the weekend school teachers like Sr. Nadia Younes, who taught our two sons the fundamentals of Islam and the way to lead a pious Islamic life in the United States.

By the 1990s, mosque attendance was rising at an exponential rate. The need for additional parking became paramount. The ISCJ applied for an expansion of its parking lot and immediately ran into resistance from the neighbors. The mayor of South Brunswick, the late Frank Gambatese, advised the ISCJ to hold an open house for the ISCJ's neighbors. After the open house, the opposition to the parking lot expansion melted away. The South Brunswick Township granted the ISCJ's application for expansion of the parking facilities in 1995. It is no exaggeration to say that the mosque attendance has increased at least twentyfold in the thirty-four years we have been attending the ISCJ.

A significant event in the history of the ISCJ is the establishment of the Noor-Ul-Iman School in 1993. Sr. Saffiya Turan was the brain behind the school. The school started with the lower grades only. When high school opened in 2001, I handed my CV to Br. Behram Turan, one of the three founders and the first president of the Noor-Ul-Iman School, and applied to teach English in high school. Sr. Saffiya Turan, another founder and the first principal of the Noor-Ul-Iman School, and Sr. Janet Nazif, the longest-serving second principal of the NUI, interviewed me. Although I performed rather poorly in the interview, surprisingly, they offered me the job. (Perhaps no one else had applied.) Except for a break of two years, I taught at Noor-Ul-Iman School from 2001 to 2013. I taught the first eleven classes to graduate from NUI (2004–2014). I could not have taught at NUI School if my wife, Dr. Zareen Ahmed, was not the family's breadwinner during my tenure at the NUI School. I thank Zareen from the bottom of my heart for giving me the opportunity to teach our Muslim boys and girls at the NUI School.

I still remember how excited we were when Ahson Azmat was accepted by Princeton University in 2006. Since then, students from NUI have been accepted by Princeton, Penn, Columbia, Cornell, Yale, MIT, NYU,

Barnard, Johns Hopkins, College of New Jersey, University of California at Berkeley, Cal Tech, University of Chicago, University of Michigan, NJIT, and the favorite destination of most NUI students, Rutgers.

NUI students made a name for themselves in the extracurricular activities as well. Ahson Azmat finished second in the nation among ninety thousand students in his junior year in the Word Masters competition of 2005. He finished first in the nation in 2006. In 2007, Reem Nasr was one of the three winners of a nationwide essay contest on Shakespearean plays organized by Bantam Books.

The NUI decided to compete in the statewide mock trial competition in 2003. Usually the New Jersey Bar Association assigns a real-life attorney to a school to coach the participants. In the fall of 2003, the head teacher coach, Sr. Sufia Azmat, entrusted me with the responsibility of hosting the attorney the bar association had sent and to show him around. Although the NUI did not boast of glittering facilities, I did show the attorney our modest modular units. I still remember the attorney's body language. He could not wait to get away from the ghetto-like setting of NUI. We never saw him again. Next, the bar association sent Norman Epting, Jr., Esq. He took to us and we to him right away. Mr. Epting has been the engine behind NUI's stunning success in the mock trial competition ever since.

Under the superb coaching of Mr. Epting, ably assisted by NUI teacher coaches, NUI mock trial team excelled. It won its first Middlesex County Mock Trial Championship in 2006, the third year of its participation. It won three more championships by 2014. Under the inspiring leadership of Ameena Soliman and Hasna Esseghir in 2013 and Hasna Esseghir in 2014, the NUI School mock trial team finished third in the state of New Jersey in both those years. In 2017, under the superb captaincy of Meryem S. Turan, the Noor-Ul-Iman mock trial team finished runners-up in the state of New Jersey, among roughly 230 schools that competed. It is worth noting that all those other schools had facilities fifty times fancier and student bodies fifty times larger than NUI. I was one of the NUI's mock trial teacher coaches from 2003 to 2014.

The NUI students played a leading role in persuading the South Brunswick Township to grant the expansion of the ISCJ. They attended several meetings at the township, which sometimes went past midnight. Juniors Fatima Ahmed and Reem Nasr escorted newspaper reporters around the school in 2006 to show them how cramped the modular units were and how desperately the school needed a proper school building. Because of their efforts, local newspapers, the *South Brunswick Post* and *Home News Tribune*, endorsed the ISCJ's expansion project in their editorials. Fatima Ahmed made an impassioned speech in front of the South Brunswick

Zoning Board, imploring them to approve the ISCJ expansion project, including a permanent school building. Such efforts by the NUI students went a long way toward the South Brunswick Zoning Board approving, in the face of stiff resistance, the ISCJ's expansion project in 2006.

I assisted editor Br. Zamir Hasan with the publication of the ISCJ's magazine, *Noor-Ul-Islam*, in the 1990s and early 2000s. I had been a member of ISCJ Hajj and Umrah Committee (at Dr. Mohamed Elsaady's request) for twenty-two years (1993–2015) and the ISCJ Religious Committee (at Dr. Suhail Rifai's behest) for ten years (2005–2015). I was also the chairman of the ISCJ Seminar Committee (at Pres. Br. Aly Aziz's request) for five years (2009–2014). I am the chairman of the ISCJ Media and Outreach Committee, which I founded with the support of the then president of the ISCJ, Br. Magdy Hagag, in 2005 (2005–present). We took out advertisements in local dailies, greeting fellow Americans on the occasion of Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha. Over the years, I have published several opinion pieces about Islam and Muslim Americans in the local and national newspapers.

I ran for office only once. In 1993, a prominent member of the ISCJ, Dr. Fatima Aziz, persuaded me to run for the overseer of the ISCJ. However, I ruined my chances of winning by asking voting members present at the candidates' introduction forum to vote for my mentor, Dr. Mohamed Elsaady, who was also running for overseer. Dr. Elsaady won.

The ISCJ and the mosque at Trenton were the only options when we moved into the Princeton area in 1983. Thanks, Allah (SWT), now we have several options. Two mosques, Institute of Islamic Studies (571 mosque) and the Lawrenceville mosque, are less than four miles from our residence. The ISCJ is roughly ten miles away. Nevertheless, because of our thirty-four-year association with the ISCJ/NUI, and the fact that our two sons received their basic Islamic education from the ISCJ, we will, inshallah, continue to patronize and attend the ISCJ. The ISCJ is at the core of our spiritual life.

Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed is a Rhodes Scholar. Originally from Bangladesh, he lives in West Windsor, New Jersey.



A Tribute to an ISCJ Stalwart, Dr. Omar Mansour (June 15, 1946–June 2, 2002)

Sr. Omayma Mansour

Dr. Omar Mansour (may Allah have mercy on his soul) was a dedicated and active member of the ISCJ community from 1983 to his passing on June 2, 2002. He served on the board of trustees from 1986 to 1989, from 1995 to 1996, from 1996 to 1999, and from 2000 to 2002 (one year remained in his term when he passed).

His most notable contributions to the society were his work as weekend school seminar coordinator, helping establish Saturday school; his work on the weekend school curriculum committee; and his help establishing Noor-Ul-Iman School and high school. He also taught at both the Saturday and Sunday schools and was an integral part of the school's planning and organization.

Dr. Omar Mansour was active not only at the ISCJ but also in his own local Muslim communities. While working at AT&T Bell Labs in Holmdel, New Jersey, he helped establish an Islamic studies club that allowed the Bell Labs employees to observe their daily prayers in a private room as well as hold Jumu'ah prayers on campus. He also served as the imam of Asbury Park Masjid from 1988 to 1994, educating many new Muslims on their faith and bringing many new brothers and sisters into Islam. One brother who accepted Islam through Dr. Mansour drove all the way from Virginia when hearing the news of his passing to make sure he made the *Janaza* in time. At the burial, he stated to the Mansour family, "I came to say goodbye to the man who brought me into Islam."

Dr. Omar Mansour was often invited to give Khutbah and lectures at the ISCJ, IIS, ICMC, Masjid Al-Aman, Islamic Center of Old Bridge, and Islamic Center of Asbury Park as well as many other masjids in New Jersey. From his early days in America, Dr. Mansour was actively engaged in educating the broader community about Islam. He worked closely and was dear friends with the original founding members of the Muslim Students Association, Dr. Hisham Altalib and Dr. Jamal Barzanji (may Allah have mercy on his soul). When he was a PhD student at Purdue University, Dr. Mansour served as the prison chaplain at the local detention center in Lafayette, Indiana. Also, after the attacks of September 11, he was asked to work with local law enforcement to educate them on Islam and the Muslim community. Local police chapters invited Dr. Mansour to conduct sensitivity training in efforts to ease tensions between the law enforcement and the Muslim communities. Throughout all these activities, it was evident how generous Dr. Mansour was with his time and that he was involved not only in the establishment of masjids and institutions but, more importantly, in strengthening their communities by teaching, giving Khutbah, organizing social activities, and engaging with all those around him, young and old.

In regard to his professional career, Omar Mansour held a PhD in electrical engineering from Purdue University and worked for much of his professional career at AT&T Bell Labs and Lucent Technologies. He was a brilliant problem-solver and was subsequently awarded two patents in the areas of telecommunications and fiber optics. One of his better-known patents awarded in 1996 was titled FASTAR and was about a robust system for fast DS3 (digital signal) restoration.

Dr. Omar Mansour was an avid reader who enjoyed reading numerous Islamic history books to prepare for his weekend seminar series. He also was a talented artist and won several art competitions in Egypt in his youth. He was an athletic individual who enjoyed swimming, running, and playing tennis, basketball, and most of all, soccer. His passion for soccer led him to start a soccer club at AT&T Bell Labs, and he continued playing leisurely until his passing. Dr. Mansour had a remarkable sense of humor and loved the company of young children. Those who met him will never forget his warm smile and his compassion to all those around him. He lived his life to the fullest and made the best of every circumstance he was faced with. Dr. Mansour never shied away from upholding strong principles, and his deeply rooted sense of integrity was evident not only in his professional life but also in the Muslim community and in his own dealings with his family. Dr. Mansour was very humble, down to earth, and enjoyed the very simple joys of life despite being an accomplished

and distinguished patented engineer. He will truly be remembered for his service to the community and for his passion in all that he did. As one dear friend reminisced after his passing, "Whenever I come to this masjid (ISCJ), I feel as if Omar's heart is hung on the walls."

Dr. Omar Mansour is survived by his wife, Faiza Mansour, and their three children, Ayman, Omayma, and Ibrahim. Sr. Faiza Mansour was a weekend school teacher for both Saturday and Sunday school from 1983 to 1995. She then taught at Noor-Ul-Iman School from 1996 to 2017. She is the former head of the Mathematics Department and former high school geometry teacher at Noor-Ul-Iman School. Ibrahim Mansour belonged to the first batch of students to graduate from Noor-Ul-Iman School in 2004.

Dr. Omar Mansour was an ISCJ pioneer who served the society in several capacities over many years. The ISCJ was overflowing with thousands of mourners who came to pay their respects to Dr. Omar Mansour at his Janaza.

This tribute to Dr. Omar Mansour is written by his daughter Sr. Omayma.



My Association With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Abdel-Moneim Said

I have been associated with the ISCJ since 1977 and became a full-time member when I moved from Long Island to New Jersey in 1985 to be closer to the society and to secure an Islamic education for my daughter, Nancy.

When we first came to America in May 1970, we visited the only masjid in the Greater New York area on Riverside Drive in Manhattan.

We all desired to have masjids near where we lived.

As my wife and I settled in Brooklyn, and my friend Sayed Arafa and his family settled in Jersey City, we were always in touch and following up on all movements and attempts to establish prayer places first in Jersey City and thereafter in Central Jersey.

Although I lived first in Brooklyn and then moved to Long Island, I was always informed about and participated in the meetings and Eid prayers in Rutgers University or in a hotel on Route 1. I met many of my friends—Abdel A. Rehim Riad, Galal Badr, Sobhi Khalil, and the late Zikri Ahmad, just to mention a few. I became bonded to the community of Central Jersey and ISCJ.

Since there was no Muslim community where I lived, and Nancy was four years old, my wife and I started worrying about her Islamic education, and because of our attachment to our friends in the ISCJ, we decided to move close to ISCJ.

With Allah's blessing, my wife, Hayat, and I attended the groundbreaking ceremony for the first phase of the construction, the multipurpose room, which was to be used for community prayers and other activities. We were also present at the groundbreaking ceremonies for the second phase, which

was the masjid, and the third phase, the construction of the Noor-Ul-Iman School. I also recall the first day Imam Chebli came to the masjid and made his first Khutbah, which everybody was pleased with.

Having a master's degree in accounting from Long Island University, and other higher diplomas in finance, I served the ISCJ as a controller from 1996 to 2000, during which I planned and participated with the ISCJ CPA in establishing an automated comprehensive accounting system, which has been in use until now, with the necessary periodic updates and enhancements.

I was then elected as a board member and treasurer from 2001 to 2003, when I participated in enhancing the internal accounting controls and financial planning. I took the initiative, with the board's approval, to audit and straighten out the record of the ISCJ cemeteries, and with Imam Chebli's assistance, we revised the ownership records, which was set up as the basis for future activities.

Thereafter, I became a member of the constitution committee through which I participated and proposed important amendments to the constitution of ISCJ, mainly an amendment in the area of conflict of interest to prevent any board member or overseer from accepting any paid position in ISCJ, its affiliates, or as a contractor. I also participated with the constitution committee in establishing important procedures, such as the preparation and conduct of the general body meetings and absentee ballots for senior members and amending the constitution.

Alhamdulillah, I am so happy to have witnessed and participated in the monumental steps that have helped build a wonderful establishment that has grown into a wonderful community. The paramount objective of this community is to establish Islamic educational institutions beside the mosque to strengthen the *da'wah* while serving current and future generations, which include my daughter, Nancy, who studied at the weekend school; my grandchildren, Ramy and Aleena Abulmagd, who are now students in the ISCJ weekend school; and my nephew, Sherief Shaban's son, Adam, and his daughter, Maya, who are students at Noor-Ul-Iman School. Additionally, my nieces Mona Mostafa, Omneya Said, and Heba Said had graduated from ISCJ weekend school six years ago and have since been volunteering as teachers in the weekend school.

May Allah (SWT) help the ISCJ and its educational institutions continue strengthening the *da'wah*, and may Allah (SWT) bless the imam and all the Muslim brothers and sisters who had served and those who are continuing to serve the community through many years to come and guide people to the beauty of Islam.

Br. Abdel-Moneim Said is a former controller, trustee, and treasurer (1996–2003) of the ISCJ. Currently, he is a member of the constitution committee



Forty Years At The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Sabiha Malik

Hafiz and Sabiha Malik and family joined the ISCJ at its early stages when meetings were held in the Hardenberg Building in New Brunswick. It was basically a Sunday school for children where I (Sabiha Malik) was a teacher and the vice principal and Sr. Riffat Sajjad was the principal. Then we bought a home near the ISCJ masjid. When Br. Ghouse Ismail was the treasurer, I assisted him as the bookkeeper. My husband and I prepared the blood grouping list according to blood type of those willing to donate blood so that blood could be available for the needy in our community. Sr. Soheir Ramadan was the doctor helping us.

My children and I washed all the chairs in the multipurpose room every year as witnessed by Br. Imam Hamad Chebli. Then Sr. Abir Catovic told me that I was getting old for this, and that she would make the school children take over this as volunteer work. We have even helped the Syrian refugees with furniture, bedsheets, pillows, blankets, and various house items.

On June 6, 2010, Sr. Farah Shariff and I launched the first senior sisters' Jamaat at the ISCJ. It was the first one of its kind in New Jersey. I got calls from Fords, Teaneck, West Windsor, Monroe, and other Muslim communities to send them the program. They also came to the ISCJ to see how they could organize similar gatherings in their communities. In our first program, we had the sisters rubber-stamp all the Holy Qur'ans in the masjid with the words "Property of ISCJ. For Masjid Use Only." Over the years, we invited several doctors who imparted their professional knowledge on various health issues and their cure to the gathering.

Princeton HealthCare System helped us with CPR, pros and cons of vitamins and supplements, living wills, joint aches and pains, and so on.

Local Muslim speakers enlightened us with religious and social topics, such as introduction to basic computers; the medical, legal, and Islamic aspects when death approaches; positive thinking; Social Security benefits; Islamic inheritance; widowhood; and many more. We had snacks and "goody bags" in every month's program. Most of the time, snacks were provided by Sr. Naureen Khan. We also had a yearly picnic in the summer and a trip in the fall.

In 2012, Sr. Farah Shariff had to leave, and I, with volunteers Nuzhat Quraishi, Nasim Jilani, Irshad Qadeer, and Nausheen Ahmad, continued the program till I handed it to a most reliable sister, Akhter Rahman, in 2015 (because of trips to India, my health problems, and my family's future move to Chicago). Sr. Akhter Rahman is very efficiently holding the program every other month.

With the help of some of the senior sisters who were doing matchmaking on their own, I was able to form a group called Help to Marry, and we were successful in making matches. Now Br. Asad Mazharullah has helped us computerize the system.

The senior sisters have also helped Br. Zamir Hassan right here at the ISCJ to prepare food for the "Hungry Van," which is feeding the homeless, a program under "Muslims against Hunger."

One of the sisters, Sr. Saima Ahmad volunteered to be the leader for the "Sisters' Support Group." She has helped families at the ISCJ in a remarkable way.

The ISCJ administrator Br. Sayed Hassan had told me that a group of seniors from Princeton would like to see the masjid and learn about Islam. So Sr. Farah Shariff and her family and my family organized a program with a tour of the masjid and an interfaith seminar on May 22, 2011. This was followed by some healthy snacks and distribution of lots of pamphlets on various topics from *Why Islam?* for those interested.

The chairperson, Ms. Jacqueline Rubel of "Aging in Place Partnership" from the board of South Brunswick, wanted to know about our beautiful structure in South Brunswick and what goes on in it. Of course, she meant the masjid ISCJ. Therefore, after the tour, Sr. Farah Shariff and I had the late Br. Moustafa Zayed (may Allah grant him Jannah) give his famous interfaith talk (which was also available on YouTube), followed by lively questions and answers and snacks. We also distributed several brochures about Islam from *Why Islam?*

It is because of the ISCJ that many Muslims have moved into the South Brunswick area. To introduce our community to our non-Muslim

neighbors, I gave a talk to a gathering in the South Brunswick library in August 2014. The topic was "Know about Your Muslim Neighbors." (Printout of the speech is enclosed.) It was introducing the Muslims and educating the audience about a Muslim's way of life. In this seminar, the late Br. Moustafa Zayed conducted a very educational question and answer session. Then we had snacks and distributed a page as "handout." (A copy is enclosed.)

The ISCJ has inspired my children to pray and serve the community. As for myself, I learned Tajweed from Sr. Aaza Shariff and grammar from Sister Rhonda and Br. Nouman Ali Khan. Several lectures from experts in their fields have benefited me personally. I made many friends, which helped in my real estate business too. Along with Sr. Iman Althawadi, I got blessings for helping in some ladies' Janaazah Ghusals at the ISCJ.

Sr. Sabiha Malik and her husband, Br. Hafiz Malik, have been involved with the ISCJ in many activities as noted above since late 1970s. Their dedication and services have been exemplary. They recently moved to Chicago. Our best wishes are with them.

Xlibris



Tribute To Sr. Zahiye Radwan (1910–1997)

Sr. Amena Assad

My mother, Zahiye Radwan, immigrated to the United States in 1933.

Orphaned at a young age, she married my father, Muhammad Radwan, a Palestinian from Beitonya, who passed away in 1959. She had two daughters and a son. I am the eldest daughter and the wife of Dawud Assad, ISCJ founding member.

My mother, Allah bless her soul, attended the services of the ISCJ since its inception in 1975 until her death at the age of eighty-seven. She used to bring sweets and hand out candy to the young children and give them money during the Eids. Everyone call her Sittee (Grandmother).

In the early 1950s, there was only one Muslim family from Turkey that lived on a farm in Jamesburg, New Jersey, by the name Mustaffa Ahmad, and we used to go to his farm and play with his children. Then later, the Taha family came in, and we became friends with them, and in the 1960s, more families moved in, such as the Rifais and others. I remember during the two Eids, we used to go to New York City and pray either in a hotel or in the Egyptian Consulate building in New York City.

When I married my husband, Dawud Assad, in 1953, we could not find an imam in New Jersey to marry us, and we went to Brooklyn masjid there to perform the Nikah for us.

When ISCJ was established, it was a blessing for us. My daughter, Maryam, attended the weekend classes with Br. Salah Awad as her teacher with her friends Kanza Sajjad and Atiya Aftab and other students.

My mother's smile, good cheer, and laughter often lit the room. Her preparation of food for family, friends, and society members was beyond

compare. Whether it was her meat pies, Maqluba, stuffed grape leaves, or sugar bread, we all knew from where it came.

Forever remembered and in our hearts by local surviving family members, Dawud and me, her loving grandchildren—Farid, Rashid, and Maryam—and her seven great-grandchildren.

Thanks, Allah, she had a good burial under the care and directions of Imam Hamad Chebli, and this is a great blessing.

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A Tribute To Br. Waheed Sayed, A Former President Of The ISCJ

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

The late Br. Waheed Sayed was a founding member of the ISCJ who came to New Jersey in 1979 after getting a job with the Power Authority of New York in New York City.

Originally from Puna, India, which is close to Mumbai, Br. Waheed Sayed earned his mechanical and electrical engineering degrees there. He then opted to spend a couple of years in Switzerland before immigrating to the United States. In America, Br. Waheed Sayed spent a few years in Maryland with his wife, Razia, and their toddler son, Omar, while working in a company. However, he had his eyes set on New York City, and as soon as an opportunity opened up to work for Power Authority of New York, he took it and then chose to move and live to West Windsor Township, New Jersey, approximately ten miles from the ISCJ.

He commuted to New York for many years until he retired. His wife, Razia, worked as a realtor, and their sons Omar and Zain attended the weekend school. Both Omar and Zain were Boy Scouts and went on to attain the highest rank in Boy Scouting, Eagle Scout, from Troop 40 in West Windsor. For his Eagle Project, Zain constructed a sandpit on the ISCJ premises. Sister Razia's untiring efforts were primarily responsible for both Omar and Zain earning the Eagle Scout rank.

Br. Waheed Sayed was a down-to-earth person with a great sense of humor and a very charming personality. He was one of the best orators at the ISCJ, and when he spoke at seminars, he captivated the audience, young and old alike. He was a very well-read person whose interests ranged from literature to homeopathic medicine.

Br. Waheed Sayed served as a board of trustee from 1987 to 1990 with one year as executive secretary and then president and then as the ISCJ chairman. He also served for three years as an overseer—two years from 1990 to 1992 and then an additional year in 1995–1996. He was active with the seminar committee and also took great interest with the youth activities. When the Institute of Islamic Studies (IIS) or the Route 571 mosque came into existence in West Windsor in the 1990s, Br. Waheed Sayed became an active member and mentor to it.

About ten years ago, Br. Waheed Sayed developed a debilitating illness and fought it with grace and humility. He passed away in January 2015. A year later, his wife, Razia, also passed away. They are survived by their two sons and three grandchildren. May Allah bless their soul.

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD is a founding member of the ISCJ.

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History Of The Noor-Ul-Iman School

Sr. Janet Nazif

My husband, Zaher, and I and our three children—Omar, Tamim, and Marria—came to the ISCJ in 1985. At the time, we lived in Northern Hunterdon County. There was no Muslim presence in the area. We wanted to find a Muslim community so that our children would be able to interact with other Muslim children and learn about their religion in the fellowship of other families. Dr. Said Shanawani, an old friend of Zaher's family, recommended that we start attending the ISCJ. It was an hour's drive each way from our house, but we deemed it well worth the commute to spend time with other Muslims.

When we joined the ISCJ, there was only the multipurpose room and a handful of classrooms for all activities. However, we found many welcoming families at the ISCJ and soon found a wonderful group of friends for ourselves and our children. Our children learned about their religion in the weekend school classes, while Zaher and I benefited from the seminars. It is hard to express in words the happiness, almost a sense of relief, at being surrounded by a support group after years of living in relative isolation. It truly does take a village to raise children, and we had found our "village."

Those years at the ISCJ are full of fond memories of picnics, potlucks, and sleepovers at the masjid. Our older three children went all the way through weekend school, first in Sunday school and later in Saturday school when the second session opened. Some of the friendships they made during those times endure until today. One highlight for us was attending

the groundbreaking for the masjid and watching the expansion of the building to its current size.

By 1993, our fourth child, Sami, was ready for preschool. That same year, a group of parents decided that they wanted to start a full-time Islamic school for their children. One of those parents was Saffiya Turan. Her mother, Sarah Catovic, who had known me for a number of years, recommended that Saffiya try to get me to join the school since I had a degree in education and a teacher certification. The idea of having my youngest son attend a full-time Islamic school was very attractive to me, and despite living an hour away, I signed on as a teacher and enrolled Sami in pre-K. He ended up staying at Noor-Ul-Iman School all the way through high school. The education he received at Noor-Ul-Iman prepared him well for his college experience.

After five years of teaching at Noor-Ul-Iman School, I became the principal when Saffiya Turan decided to leave that position to teach full time. I served as the principal for fifteen years before retiring from the position. Eman Arafa became the principal in 2013, and I turned my attention to curriculum and mentoring. Having been at Noor-Ul-Iman since its inception, I have had the opportunity to witness many changes and the incredible growth of the school.

Noor-Ul-Iman actually began as a summer program for a group of Muslim children in Saffiya Turan's house. These children were about to enter kindergarten and first grade that fall, but their parents had seen the benefits of having Muslim children learn and socialize together in an Islamic environment. They wanted those benefits to continue, and the decision was made to start a full-time Islamic school. They named the school Noor-Ul-Iman (Light of Our Faith), and the ISCJ generously offered the use of their classrooms. Noor-Ul-Iman full-time school opened its doors in the fall of 1993 with just twenty-seven students in pre-K, kindergarten, and first grade using three classrooms in the ISCJ and the basement of Imam Chebli's house.

It was a humble beginning. There were only a handful of teachers who had to do everything from teaching the students to the necessary custodial work, including moving all the furniture out every weekend so that the weekend school furniture could be moved into the rooms. But the idea of a full-time Islamic school in Central New Jersey caught on, and NUI started its second year with almost double the number of students and the addition of a second-grade class. The school continued to expand by one grade per year, with just one exception when two grades were added in the same year, and each year, the school attracted more students than the year before.

Noor-Ul-Iman quickly outgrew the masjid and added the three modular units between 1996 and 2000. The modular units were used by both NUI and the ISCJ Weekend School as both schools were seeing a rapid growth in enrollment. The community started planning for a permanent school building as part of the master plan in 2001. There were many obstacles to overcome, but the visionaries in the ISCJ and NUI would not let it drop. Through the patience, perseverance, and hard work of many people, and after more than ten years of effort, the first phase of the new school building opened in the fall of 2012 and the second phase in the fall of 2014. Both Noor-Ul-Iman and the weekend school have benefited from having a proper educational facility for their students. They are now looking forward to the construction of phase 3 in the not-too- distant future, inshallah, that will provide a gymnasium, cafeteria, and other benefits for our students and the community.

NUI had its first eighth-grade graduation in June of 2000 in the ISCJ multipurpose room with Dr. Omar Mansour (Rahmatullahi Alaih) as the keynote speaker. There were more teachers than students in the eighth-grade class that year. Then came the big decision, to start the high school or stop at eighth grade. There was a lot of debate about the ability of NUI to handle a high school curriculum and prepare students for college, but the community was ready to move forward. Dr. Omar urged NUI to start the high school and enrolled his son, Ibrahim, as the first student. Noor- Ul-Iman High School was launched in the fall of 2000 with just four students. Many ISCJ community members with expertise in different fields were among the first high school teachers. NUI High School continued to grow and attract more students. In June 2004, NUI held its first high school graduation. All four graduates were accepted into college, and we knew that the high school was a success and was able to fulfill its mission. In the past thirteen years, NUI has graduated 204 students from its high school, including 7 National Merit finalists and 34 National Merit commended students. In all, 100 percent of NUI's graduates have been accepted into four-year colleges, from Cal Tech and Zaytuna College on the West Coast to Rutgers, Princeton, Johns Hopkins, University of Pennsylvania, and many others on the East Coast as well as a growing number of colleges across the country and even overseas at NYU Abu Dhabi.

Over the years, Noor-Ul-Iman School has developed a national reputation of excellence not just for its academic and religious studies programs but also for its extracurricular activities and robust Hafidh program. NUI students compete at the regional, state, and national levels in many areas and continue to do well. Examples are its award-winning

Model UN, Model Congress, and mock trial, debate, and Science Olympiad teams.

In 2010, after an exhaustive process that spanned three years, NUI was fully accredited by the New Jersey Association of Independent Schools, the New Jersey branch of the National Association of Independent Schools. Accreditation provided outside validation for the quality of Noor-Ul-Iman School by requiring that NUI meet fifty-seven separate standards based on best practices in all areas of education, including curriculum, instruction, governance, and administration. NUI passed and was granted the maximum ten-year accreditation.

It is with the blessing of Allah (SWT) that Noor-Ul-Iman School has been able to come this far over the last twenty-three years, and with the help of Allah (SWT), NUI hopes to continue to provide an excellent academic and Islamic education within an Islamic environment to students for many years to come, helping them develop into "good citizens and strong leaders who have a commitment to individual excellence, family, community, and humanity" as stated in the NUI mission statement.

It was also a blessing from Allah (SWT) that my family and I became a part of the ISCJ back in 1985. We have been blessed to be a part of the growth of two outstanding Islamic institutions on this one site. We have been blessed with many friendships, many opportunities to grow and learn, and the very special warmth of being a part of this blessed community.

Sr. Janet Nazif is the longest-serving, second principal of the Noor-Ul-Iman School.

Dr. Kassem Riad's Outstanding Contributions To The ISCJ And The Noor-Ul-Iman School

Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed, D. Phil

Br. Kassem Riad (PhD) has served the ISCJ for over thirty years and the Noor-Ul-Iman School for fifteen years. He was a member of the ISCJ Constitution Committee for several years and very active in the ISCJ Weekend School, both as a principal and a teacher.

Around 1993, Dr. Kassem, in collaboration with the late Dr. Omar Mansour, the late Br. Ahmad El Mouslimaany, and Br. Tarek Abdala, started the Saturday session of the weekend school. He was the principal of the Saturday school and taught the students for three years.

His wife, Sister Fatima, was also a teacher at the weekend school. All three of Dr. Kassem and Sister Fatima's children attended the ISCJ Weekend School.

He served as an overseer of the ISCJ from 1992 to 1994. During those two years, he served as the chief overseer. From 2003 to 2006, he served a three-year term as a trustee of the ISCJ Board of Trustees. For one year, he was the executive secretary of the ISCJ and was the treasurer of the ISCJ for two years (2004–2005).

He founded the Noor-Ul-Iman School's Physics and Mathematics departments. He was the head of the Physics Department. He was an outstanding teacher, one of the best teachers the Noor-Ul-Iman School ever had.

It was because of his superb teaching of physics and mathematics that the Noor-Ul-Iman School's students have excelled in high school and in science and technology in college.

Sr. Fatima Riad has also been teaching in Noor-Ul-Iman School for over fifteen years.

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD also contributed to this write-up.

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Reminescences Of Abdelrahman Aly Abdelrahman - The ISCJ's Muezzin

Br. Abdelrahman Aly Abdelrahman

We joined the ISCJ in 1984 when we were looking for an Islamic Sunday school that would admit our two children, Noha and Khalid, and that was also closer to our residence. At that time, we were living in Old Bridge Township, New Jersey.

We were very impressed with the makeup of the ISCJ membership, a group of diverse, highly talented, and educated Muslims from different of nationalities. In fact, nearly all the friends we made through the ISCJ were from other nationalities. Not only that, the same goes for the friends our children made over the years.

Not very long after we became members of the ISCJ, my late wife, Sabira, and I became very actively involved in the ISCJ's activities, especially in the Sunday school committee, where we both taught Islamic studies and Arabic.

Later on, I joined the school committee as a committee member and, a few years later, as a school committee chair.

A few months after we joined the ISCJ, I discovered that Allah had blessed me with a decent voice, and it became my obligation to sound the Adhan on the weekends and Jumu'ah prayers on Friday. Later on, Imam Hamad Chebli gave me the title of "official muezzin" of the ISCJ, and that is only by the grace of Allah on me.

Under the direction of our beloved Imam Chebli, over twenty years ago, I started and oversaw the annual Qur'anic and reading competition that is still going on.

I also served in other committees of the ISCJ, including the religious committee, the constitution committee, and the social activities committee. In 1990, I started serving in the board of trustees of the ISCJ for two consecutive terms in different capacities as a board member, an executive committee secretary, and as a board secretary.

I lectured on different topics in both the Saturday and the Sunday seminars on a regular basis.

I consider the ISCJ as the best thing that can happen to a growing Muslim family. It represents my second home. It is a place where people can meet, socialize, make friends, and learn about Islam. It has the right environment for our children and our grandchildren to see and feel that they are a part of a bigger community of Muslims.

I beg Allah the Almighty to keep the ISCJ safe and growing as a source of light and guidance to the entire neighborhood, to New Jersey, and beyond and to keep the Satan out of it. Ameen!

Br. Abdelrahman Aly Abdelrahman is the first, the only, and the current muezzin of the ISCJ.



I Feel Blessed To Be A Part Of The ISCJ Community

Sr. Nadia Younes

After coming to the United States from Egypt in 1973, we were kind of settled for approximately ten years in New York City, where my husband, Mohamed Younes, was working. However, we were always in search of a Muslim community in New Jersey, where we would set our roots and bring up our two sons, Emery and Kariem. Between 1982 and 1983, we visited several mosques in New Jersey, but after visiting ISCJ, we really fell in love with it and the community it served, which made us move from New York to New Jersey. Once we settled in New Jersey, Mohamed continued his work in New York and had to commute.

What attracted us to the ISCJ was the very diverse nature of the community with friendly people. The ISCJ's proximity to our home was another favorable factor. It took us no time to feel at home at the ISCJ. One of the first people I met was Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady, who thereafter became one of my closest friends. At this time, the community was small and almost everyone knew everyone else. The physical structure of the ISCJ consisted of only a multipurpose room and some classrooms. For a time, there was no imam.

Br. Salah Awad, who was the principal of the Sunday school, asked me to teach the kids. Since I loved kids, I did not hesitate and started teaching the kindergarten class. That was the beginning of my involvement with the ISCJ. I continued teaching at the Sunday school until 2014 and gave up reluctantly because of health issues. Over time, as the number of kids wishing to enroll in the Sunday school increased tremendously, it was decided to add a Saturday school. Unfortunately, this led to some discord

within the community since everyone was not able to come together under one roof as frequently as before.

There were a couple of committees, like the school committee and the religious committee that I ventured to join, but this relationship did not last long. However, I had a long involvement with the fund-raising committee (for over ten years), where we not only catered but also cooked and raised much-needed funds for the masjid. I was actively involved with the social activities committee, especially with the school picnics, Ramadan *iftars*, and *suhoors*. I still take part in the Lailatul Qadr *iftar* and *suhoors*.

From 1991 to 1994, I served as a member of the ISCJ Board of Trustees, which included one year as the executive secretary. This was followed by a two-year term as an overseer. I served as an overseer again from 2008 to 2010. Both my sons attended the Sunday school, where they received Islamic education and developed long-lasting friendships. Emery took part in seminars and also served one year as an overseer. Emery got married at the ISCJ with our Imam Chebli performing the ceremony. Now I am a loving grandmother of a set of twins. Mohamed worked in the administrative office of the ISCJ for approximately one year before Br. Sayed Hassan took over.

We feel blessed to be a part of the ISCJ community.

Sr. Nadia Younes is a pillar of the ISCJ. She was one of the early teachers of the weekend school and taught many of the students who graduated from the weekend school. She was, and is, an active presence in the ISCJ's social scene, supervising iftars and suhoors and welcoming guests. Sr. Nadia Younes also served the ISCJ as its executive secretary and as an overseer.



From Rutgers Sunday School To The Chairperson Of The ISCJ

Sr. Atiya Aftab, Esq.

My earliest memories are gazing out the car window as we turned off Route 18 North and exited on Albany Street or George Street and entered the Rutgers University campus in New Brunswick. We were on our way to the ISCJ Sunday school, which was held in Scott Hall, Rutgers University. It was 1976 or 1977, and I was eight or nine years old. We had recently moved to New Jersey, and my parents had sought out the local Muslim community.

We would shuffle in the classrooms those Sunday mornings. I recall my teachers: Sharon Taha, Fakhry Saymeh, Farida Ali, and Sobhi Khalil. We learned Qur'anic Arabic, reviewed or memorized short suras, and studied stories from the Qur'an and of the prophets. I am still in touch, and am friends with many of the students who I was in class with at that time, and am lucky to meet most of my early teachers who are still part of the ISCJ community. While we were in class, the adults gathered in the Scott Hall lecture hall, and that is where we prayed Zuhr at the end of the session. Later on, our classes moved to the Rutgers University River Dorms, mainly in Hardenburgh Hall.

We would celebrate the Eids and Milad un-Nabi in the various student centers and gathering spaces at Rutgers University. I recall Eid parties in the Rutgers Graduate Student Lounge and Eid prayer at Rutgers Student Center, Busch Student Center, and even Rutgers Gardens Log Cabin House. Our teacher, Farida Ali, would coach us to perform plays at these celebrations from the classic stories of *1001 Arabian Nights*. We would also

learn Arabic and Urdu *nasheeds* to sing on these occasions. Later, I would be in those same spaces as a college student and even later as a professor.

When the ISCJ established its permanent masjid in phases on Route 1 in South Brunswick, I was already in junior high school and high school. I remember the groundbreaking ceremonies of phase 1 and phase 2. I recall attending a few sessions of Sunday school in the new building. While I was a high school student, however, I volunteered as a contributor and editor to the ISCJ publication, the *Noor-Ul-Islam*, and I volunteered for Sunday school to be the assistant to the principals of the Sunday school, namely, assistant to Principal Mamdouh Fakhry and, later, to Principal Hussein Shehata. I continued that service while I was a college student at Rutgers University.

My volunteer involvement at ISCJ waned while I attended law school in Newark, but I fondly remember attending special events and celebrations at the ISCJ. Eid prayers would take place at the masjid, but as the community grew, we prayed in various parks in South Brunswick and at the local area hotels.

Later, in about 1995, after I had been practicing law for four years, I received a call in my office from Br. Shoukat Ali, who I believe was an ISCJ overseer at that time, and he requested that I apply my professional skills to serve the masjid. I became involved with the constitution committee. Later, I became involved in the building committee, expansion funding group, endowment funding group, masjid expansion, and other committees. I started the government and political awareness committee with voter registration drives and visits by local politicians.

Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, the ISCJ board chair, encouraged me to participate at the governance level. In 1996, I was appointed to the ISCJ board for a one-year term. I was appointed a couple of times after that, and then I agreed to run in the elections for a board position. I am grateful to have served the ISCJ Board of Trustees as a member, as secretary, as acting president, and as the chair of the board of trustees. During that time, when I had mandatory breaks in service, I served on the ISCJ Board of Overseers as a member and chief overseer. This service covered a period of almost twenty years until 2016.

It is my pleasure and honor to continue my service to the masjid in whatever capacity is needed. It is my desire that the ISCJ and the masjid campus be the model of a Muslim community, and I hope to help effectuate that for the rest of my life.

Sr. Atiya Aftab, an attorney, was the first female chairperson of the ISCJ.



The Chebli Family And The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Muhammad Chebli

In 1982, my dad brought me, my brother, and my mom to the United States to settle in New Orleans, Louisiana. He began serving the Muslim community in Downtown New Orleans at the Islamic center on St. Claude Ave. This working-class community embraced the tall imam from Lebanon. In New Orleans, he honed his skills working with families and community leaders and his ability to make people smile.

After four years of service, and two more kids, he learned about an opportunity in the suburbs of New Jersey at the young Islamic Society of Central Jersey. He piled us in the car and made the journey north.

Now thirty years, six kids, and eight grandkids later, we can begin to tell the story of his impact on the ISCJ and the ISCJ's impact on our family. As children of the imam, we've always had a unique perspective on our father's work and his place in the community.

Thirty Years at ISCJ

It may be the longest tenure by one imam at one masjid anywhere in the United States. What did this time mean for his family? What was the nature of his service?

In corporate America, there is an annual tradition where parents bring their kids to work one day per year. As children of the imam, we practiced

that tradition practically every day. My dad would bring us with him to Maghrib and Isha prayers. He enrolled us in both Saturday and Sunday schools (the only kids lucky enough to be in both weekend sessions). We sat front row at every Jumu'ah and Eid prayer because he was always the first one there, and that meant we were the first ones also. When the Al-Huda School (precursor to Noor-Ul-Iman) was founded, he enrolled my sister, Maryam, who was the only one of us in the eligible age range. Khaled and Marwa would continue the tradition when Noor-Ul-Iman began.

He brought us with him to weddings and janazas so we could see our friends and neighbors at their happiest and saddest moments. We went to every fund-raiser and convention. We heard every joke, every *Dua*, and all the stories. We would cringe hardest when the story was about one of us or when his Lebanese humor didn't translate perfectly into English.

The Formative Years

We've seen the masjid grow from one small building to the institution it is today. In the early years at ISCJ, we established our most lasting friendships, experienced our formative moments, and learned the measure of our father's commitment to the community. Our early years at the ISCJ introduced us to our best friends and mentors and established in us the values that would guide us forward. His focus on the community was matched only by my mom's focus on us. She always made sure we were the best we could possibly be.

During the early years, he led the community through one of its most pivotal moments of growth. We saw the opening of a full-time daily school and the expansion of the buildings. At the weekend school, we learned the stories of the prophets, practiced our Arabic, and memorized Qur'an. During these years, the Chebli kids were like any other, more concerned with the parking lot football games, Saturday school pizza dinners, and ice-skating trips.

We weren't aware that our dad was any different than other parents. Seeing him speak in front of the large crowds was just one of the things that he did. It wasn't until we were a little older did we understand that our father played a key role in the life of the community. At home, his private life was, and continues to be, identical to his public life. You know that booming voice he uses to lead prayers from the mihrab? He leads prayers in our living room with that same voice—loud.

Later Years and Today

During the last thirty years, we've seen the ISCJ grow from a few hundred families to a few thousand. We've welcomed governors, senators, and countless state and local officials. From graduation celebrations to funerals, my dad has been at the center of it all, and he's remained humble and gracious. The ISCJ has continued to be a beacon of tolerance and inclusiveness, and it is a model of the ideal American Muslim community. When he was invited by Congressman Rush Holt to give the opening prayer to Congress, he did so with the same message he's given one thousand times from the mimbar during Jumu'ah prayer.

Today the imam's kids are nearly all married (you're next, Marwa!), and are having kids of our own. The ISCJ has been our wedding venue, our day care, and our weekend school. We've tried to give our children the same experiences that we enjoyed when we were their age. The difference today is that the facilities, services, and community of the ISCJ are dramatically larger than when we were young. We're blessed that the ISCJ is here as a foundation for our community to continue to shape the lives of the next generation.

Imam Chebli is loved and respected for his exemplary service to the ISCJ community over the past thirty-plus years. He has established great relationships with the leaders of the Christian and Jewish faith through interfaith meetings and with political leaders at the South Brunswick Township and state government levels so much so that these leaders trust his guidance in making critical decisions involving Islam-related matters.



Journey From A Youth Advisor To The President Of The ISCJ

Br. Magdy Haggag

I arrived in the USA on July 16, 1984, as a student at Wagner College in Staten Island, New York. I struggled in the beginning and worked as a dishwasher, delivery boy, yellow cab driver, and pizza restaurant owner to finance my education. I transferred to and finally graduated from Rutgers University with a bachelor of science degree in civil engineering. I am currently the vice president of Michael Baker International, a five- thousand-employee company. It was a real struggle, but I truly have lived the American dream.

I have been a member of the ISCJ for twenty-six years. It all began in 1990 after I graduated from Rutgers. I found a job nearby and settled around the ISCJ area. I began teaching the Qur'an to adults on Friday nights (Friday halaqa). I continue to teach the Qur'an to this day, alhamdulillah. As I was in my twenties, some of the founding members of the ISCJ asked me to take care of and tutor their youth and became the director for the youth committee. This is where I met my beloved future wife, Amira Riad, who grew up in the ISCJ community as a child and later became a weekend school teacher. And her father, Br. Abdel-Rehman Riad, was a founding member and a past president of the ISCJ.

Amira and I got married on July 31, 1994. Our beloved Imam Hamad Chebli conducted the marriage ceremony in the ISCJ masjid and multipurpose room. I continued to teach Qur'an to adults and youth and became more active in various ISCJ committees, including the religious committee, zakat committee, and weekend school committee.

In 2001, I was nominated and elected to the ISCJ Board of Trustees. I was soon elected the president of the ISCJ and became one of the youngest

serving presidents in the history of the ISCJ. The terrorist attack of 9/11 happened during my first year on the board. The board scrambled to put out a statement and seek protection of the ISCJ premises from the South Brunswick Police. I remember that tragic day clearly. I was in my office right on Route 1 (at my engineering job) when the news hit, and it became clear that something terrible had happened. I left my office, three miles from the ISCJ, and came running to try to work with the rest of the ISCJ board members, Noor-Ul-Iman School board members, and the South Brunswick officials to dismiss the NUI students early and to get them home safely. Alhamdulillah, we were able to dismiss and send the student home safely without encountering any problems. 9/11 made us all more active at interfaith meetings. It became imperative for us Muslims to do more to defend and explain our faith to non-Muslim Americans. Alhamdulillah, we succeeded in that task.

I continued to serve on the ISCJ board for three terms (2001–2012). I was lucky to have several well-qualified members serving on the board at that time. Br. Alan Bowman, the board chairman and a practicing attorney, was one of them, and I was lucky to always have him by my side. Sr. Sogra Saleem and Sr. Atiya Aftab were also very active board members during my tenure on the board.

In 1998, the ISCJ decided to develop the lands it owned in its premises and put together a master plan. The long-term and building committees were born. Being a civil engineer, I became a member of this committee and, soon after, the chairman of the committee. We applied to the South Brunswick Township Zoning Board for the approval of our master plan. After several hearings, we successfully gained an approval to build a permanent structure for the full-time Islamic school (Noor-Ul-Iman School), masjid expansion, and an office building. The master plan included a senior citizen housing plan to serve our community founding members, but unfortunately, it was rejected by one vote.

The approval of the master plan took lots of years, time, and discussion with local and state officials. I was lucky and blessed to have gained the approval of the master plan during my tenure as the president of the ISCJ and lucky to be able to work with many officials to accomplish it. It was a great working relationship between the ISCJ and many officials on the local and state level. They all helped in making history for the ISCJ. During the zoning board hearings, it became clear that the ISCJ needed to acquire more land. Therefore, I led the efforts to buy the two houses at 31 and 35 Richard Road and include those as a part of the ISCJ's seventeen-acre property. This was a very smart, forward-looking move by the ISCJ Board of Trustees at that time.

The ISCJ has influenced my wife's life from an early age, and the Noor- Ul-Iman School, as a part of the ISCJ, has influenced my children's life. Without the ISCJ, there would be no Noor-Ul-Iman School.

Br. Magdy Haggag is a former president of the ISCJ.

Xlibris



My Decades-Long Memories With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Saffet Abid Catovic

My earliest memories of the ISCJ date back to the mid-1970s when my parents, Dr. Saffet and Dr. Sarah Catovic, used to occasionally drive me and my siblings on Sundays from our house in Teaneck to their alma mater, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, where they were previously involved in Islamic activities with about ten other families in the preceding decade. At Rutgers, we attended the Sunday school activities of the Islamic Society and Friends (MSA) and also attended special programs and events like Milad un-Nabi. At that time, my father, who was classically trained as an imam, graduating from the prestigious Gazi Husrev-beg Medresa in Sarajevo, of his native Bosnia and Herzegovina (before pursuing higher education in the sciences in America), had instructed and trained me and my siblings in the recitation of the Holy Qur'an with Tajweed and the singing and performance of traditional Islamic songs (*Illahiya*, qasida, and *nasheeds*) in Arabic infused with English Islamic poetry, set to rhyme under the title "I Am a Muslim," which we were asked to perform on such occasions. I distinctly remember us joining on the stage with Sr. Farida Ali, who was the vice principal of the Islamic Sunday school back then and used to lead a group of the students in chanting Salawat and Darood on Prophet Muhammad (SAAWS) during those festive occasions.

Though my family was not at that time actively involved in the day-to-day functioning and administration of the organization (we lived in Northern Jersey), my parents had always supported the society whenever

and in whatever capacity they could. My mother, a convert to Islam, used to say that this was the only place of the many masjids and communities we had frequented (all of whom were "ethnic" mosques) where she could learn more about Islam because the adult classes were in English, conducted by Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dr. Mahmoud Taher, and others, and where she could socialize with fellow Muslim brothers and sisters from many different nationalities who did not look strangely or down at her because she only knew English or because she was a convert. She and all of us truly loved the multiethnic and multicultural composition of the society. I remember taking my first ride around that time in a big moving truck when my parents were helping Dr. Suhail and Sr. Hana Rifai and their sons, Aiman and Hamdi, move to their new home back then in East Brunswick.

I also recall the hot summer day when ground was broken for the building of the multipurpose room (MPR) during the month of Ramadan in the early 1980s. We were all fasting that day. Even my little brother, Sami, was trying to fast part of the day, and it was very hot. An ice cream truck had come to the location. I remember many of the children who were present running to the ice cream truck and that despite his pleas to my mother, she told him he would have to wait until after the program. Once it was finished, only then did she allow him to have ice cream. The lesson that my mother (and father) had taught us that day (and many other days as well) was that as a Muslim, our first duty is Allah and in following Islam (in this case, the Siyam-Fast of Ramadan) and, after that, respect and support for the Muslim community and the care of one's family and home.

I remember the times when the society used to have regular social get-togethers in the MPR. These were always potluck and dishes with origins from every corner of the world. As I think of it now, the ISCJ was a metaphor for the unity through diversity. On summer weekends, this same experience was taken outdoors at Colonial Park and also included barbecues and games (including water balloons) and even paddle boating. But when the time for prayer came, we all stopped what we were doing and responded to the Adhan. Though I did not attend the ISCJ Sunday school, I was acquainted with the community because of the community and social events that our family attended regularly. I remember being a part of organizing the first formal youth group run by a youth at the society. The group was headed by Srs. Abir Riad (later to be my wife) and Sohaila Soliman and others. I remember working with them to put on the first ever youth-organized dinner, which was held in the MPR. Subhan Allah, as soon as the program began inside, so too did the rain begin to fall, a sign and manifestation of Allah's mercy.

In the fall of 1986, while I was still working on my MBA, I had the opportunity to work with and participate in different programs with the Rutgers MSA students. At that time, I was on the board of Masjid Ul Huda (New Brunswick Islamic Center), along with some of its other founders like Zaid Shakir, Yaser Soliman, Behram Turan, Mohamed Esseghir, and others. We often jointly organized programs with the society. It was during these programs that I came to know Sister Abir better and shortly thereafter asked for her hand in marriage. Alhamdulillah, she said yes, and her parents accepted our union. When it came to deciding where to have our engagement party in January 1987 (and a year later, our marriage and *walimah*), the choice of venue was obvious to us. We were engaged and married in the ISCJ MPR by Dr. Mahmoud Taher and Imam Hamad Chebli, respectively, and my father-in-law, Abdel-Rehim Riad, made both occasions an open invite for the entire community at that time. My wife, Abir, insisted that all the children, many of whom were her students in ISCJ Sunday school, also attend. It was the right way to start our new life together, from the masjid, the house of Allah that we both had been connected to since our childhood. To my knowledge, this was the first engagement party and marriage feast (*walimah*) of the children of ISCJ founding families to take place in the masjid (but not the last, alhamdulillah!).

Some years later, in 1990, seeing the need for a children-friendly Islamic studies book that Muslim students in America could relate to and connect with, my wife, her sister Amira, ISCJ member Sofia Dasti, and me embarked on a multiyear endeavor to author just such a series of books for grades first through third. That time, we had to draw our own graphics and designs without the help of computer programs. The book series, *I Am a Muslim*, was well received and has been the basic Islamic studies textbook of the society for those grades since then.

I was asked by the late Br. Mamdouh Fakhry to team-teach the society's first teenage youth class with Sr. Mary El-Moslimany. We met in Imam Chebli's house on Richard Road, which was donated by one of the society's founders and close family friend, Dr. Mahmoud Taher. That was an amazing year and a wonderful learning experience as the class included not only religious lessons and instruction but also open and honest discussion of the many issues that teenagers face and wrestle with as they move into adulthood. One of the memories I have of that time is regarding an incident that took place when a new student to the class, and the only African American youth at that time, had apparently used some inappropriate language (along with some of the other male students in the class) toward some of the female students during recess. While the

inappropriate behavior of the children of the immigrant male students was somehow excused or ignored by many of those in various leadership roles in the society, the same excusing of misbehavior was not afforded to the African American youth despite all my efforts to rectify the situation by having all those involved in the incident to be treated the same way. Unfortunately, the African American youth and his single mother were not made welcome and had to leave the society.

While I and my family have always been proud of the multicultural and multiethnic composition of ISCJ, there was (and still is) a long way to go for it to become a truly multiracial society. This is evidenced by the fact that the number of African American members of the society can be counted on one hand, and it was not until 2001 that the society elected one of these members, Br. Alan Bowman, to the board of trustees (BOT), and he was reelected for a second term. However, since then, he has not been elected. The ISCJ needs to do a lot more in this regard to be in keeping with the statement of and admonition of our Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) during his Last Sermon in Minâ when he said, "O people! Your Lord is one Lord, and you all share the same father. There is no preference for Arabs over non-Arabs, nor for non-Arabs over Arabs. Neither is their preference for white people over black people, nor for black people over white people. Preference is only through righteousness." Then he said, "Have I conveyed the message?" and the people declared that he had (*Musnad Ahmad*).

When Allah blessed us in 1990 with our first child, Ibraheem, once again, the choice of where to have his *Aqeeqah* was obvious, our masjid, ISCJ. The same was the case with his four siblings—Ismael, Mariam, Sarah, and Fatima—who followed. As Ibraheem approached his pre-K years, my wife, Abir, and I took a decision to homeschool him, owing to the very difficult moral and social circumstances we, like so many Muslim American children, were exposed to on a daily basis while going through the public school system. At the same time, my sister, Saffiya Turan, was in a similar situation, along with several other close family friends with young school-age children. A summer playgroup was formed in 1993, operating out of the house of my sister, Saffiya. By September, my sister, Saffiya; my wife, Abir; and a couple of other families transformed this playgroup into Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI). That first year, we had classes in Imam Chebli's house on Richard Road with twenty-three students pre-K 3. These were the pioneers of NUI. Today, alhamdulillah, we have over six hundred students and a thriving and nationally recognized school of high achievement both in Islamic education and secular education circles at the national level. Our three eldest children (Ibraheem, Ismael, and Mariam)

have graduated from NUI HS, and our two youngest (Sarah and Fatima) are still attending the school, alhamdulillah.

In 2001, my family was contacted by the Council on Islamic Education to be the subject of a book about *Celebrating Ramadan*. This book, which was published in August 2001, is a winner of the 2002 Middle East Outreach Council Award and is widely available in libraries, bookstores, and classrooms across the nation and highlights ISCJ, NUI, and the community that we are a part of.

In 2001, I worked with a couple other senior members of ISCJ, including Br. Aly Abdel Aziz, Zahir Nazif, and others to establish New Jersey's first official Muslim Boy Scout troop—Boy Scout Troop #114. A few years later, we also established Pack #114 for boys age five to ten. As troop committee chairman and later as scoutmaster, I had the honor to work with our teenage boys from age eleven to eighteen and to guide them through the various ranks and advancements in the Boy Scout of America (BSA) program and develop them into men of character and responsibility. Alhamdulillah, as of this writing, we have had over 150 scouts go through the BSA's time-tested, values-based youth development and training program, including 15 who have earned the highest coveted rank of Eagle Scout. As a result of our scout interactions with other troops and Boy Scouts of America volunteers and staff over the year, we have been recognized as one of the leading Muslim troops in the nation and have been a model of Muslim and Islamic scouting nationwide. We have also been featured by BSA in their promotional and outreach to the Muslim communities across America.

Br. Saffet Catovic has served the ISCJ in numerous capacities and is a Khateeb and an indispensable part of the ISCJ. He leads the Green Muslim movement and is a climate activist. Brother Saffet is the founder of Muslim Boy Scout troop, Troop #114. He is also a Noor-Ul-Iman School teacher. He has also served as the ISCJ's chief overseer and is a member of the constitution committee.



My Reflections On The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Abir Catovic

I tell people that if I were opened up, I would find ISCJ written inside me. Why? Ever since I came to reside permanently in the United States in 1975 (yes, I am older than twenty), ISCJ has been my home.

My sister, Amira, and I grew up in North Brunswick, attending public school. My parents, Abdel-Rehim and Nagda Riad, did all they could do to ensure that their children would grow up as Muslims. Although they both worked in New York and left our house before we did in the morning for school and arrived much later than we arrived from school, they did everything in their power to imbibe us with the teachings of Islam. Every sit-down opportunity that I can remember had an Islamic teaching in it, alhamdullilah, and like the other good Muslim parents of the time, my parents enrolled us in the weekend school.

Back in the times that I am mentioning, I don't believe we were called the Islamic Society of Central Jersey or the ISCJ. There was no masjid, multipurpose room, school building, and so on. The plot of land where the ISCJ currently resides was a large plot of grass on Route 1 South. So where did we attend weekend school? At Rutgers University! The original members of ISCJ rented classrooms that we attended as students. I remember going to classes on College Avenue on Sunday mornings to attend weekend school. Members of the community volunteered to teach classes as they do today. Most importantly, all the parents of the weekend school students attended classes too. This reinforced the idea that Islamic education was important for all ages. While the children were attending classes, the adults attended lectures. Imam Hamad Chebli was not a part

of the society at that time. I remember my parents speaking about the lectures of a Brother Mustafa and Dr. Suhail Rifai, who is still part of our community today.

I am truly grateful for my experience at the weekend school, even though I wasn't that grateful while I was going through it. I actually tried to convince my parents every Sunday that I was too sick to attend Sunday school, but alhamdullilah, they caught on pretty quickly. I thank the countless teachers who volunteered to teach us—Dr. Taher, Mr. Fakhry Saymeh, Mrs. Farida Ali, Mrs. Sabiha Malik, and many more whose names have escaped me. (I am so sorry, but I ask Allah [SWT] to reward you all!)

So why wasn't I grateful at the time? As I recall, at the beginning of every year, I'd be put in a class, and a teacher would come in and ask what suras we knew so that the sura of study could be determined for the year. Every year I was placed in a class with some student who, for some reason, always failed to recall Surat Al-'Asr (I'm not sure if he did that on purpose or not), so our sura of study for the year would always be Surat Al-'Asr. Well, I knew Surat Al-'Asr, and if that was what we were going to study, I wasn't interested. On top of that, our breaks were not the fancy breaks that had pizza, snacks, and assorted treats. Our breaks consisted of the same thing every week, two cookies and half a cup of juice. Oh how I wished for a third cookie or perhaps a full cup of juice! But it wasn't going to happen. If you asked for more, you would be reminded that the allotment for each student was two cookies and a half a cup of juice.

It wasn't until my senior year, my last year as an ISCJ Weekend School student, when a new teacher, Mr. Salah Awad, walked into the classroom, and things changed. He came into the classroom, seemed to notice right away that I was not interested, asked me a question, reprimanded me, and began his class. I was taken aback. Then guess what. He didn't make us study Surat Al-'Asr. He made us begin learning Surat Al-Baqara. It was as if I just realized that there were other suras in the Qur'an besides Surat Al-'Asr. Thanks, in part, to my weekend school teacher, Mr. Salah Awad. A spark was ignited that led me to learn as much as I could about Islam, alhamdullilah.

Sometime during my weekend school days, the adults of the community purchased some of the land for establishing the ISCJ. There was an agreement in the community that construction was going to take place in phases and that there would be a phase for classrooms and a multipurpose room and a phase for the masjid portion. There was a difference of opinion in the community as to which portion would be built first, the multipurpose room and classroom part or the masjid. Alhamdullilah,

because the founders of the ISCJ were righteous people, they put the decision to a vote in the community. I remember my parents wanting the masjid to be built first.

The vote resulted in the community wanting the multipurpose room and classrooms being constructed first. Again, because the community shared the same vision of eventually getting the entire masjid, multipurpose room, and classrooms constructed, the disagreement about what to build first really didn't get in the way. The process by which the community voted allowed every community member's opinion to be heard, and in the end, the majority opinion prevailed. Since the community members were respected, alhamdullilah, the fund-raising was successful and the masjid building was built in two phases, starting with the multipurpose and classrooms and then with the masjid. Looking back, this process may have been one of the most important precedents established by the founders of the ISCJ.

After the construction of the first phase, the community decided that they needed an imam. I remember going through community imam interviews. Imams would come on a regular basis and give a lecture, and the community would provide input. There was an imam before Imam Chebli who worked at the ISCJ for a few years. I remember attending that imam's sessions with my parents. Once that imam left, there was another round of imam interviews, and Imam Chebli joined the ISCJ in 1986.

After graduating from the weekend school, I was inspired to be a weekend school teacher myself. I applied, and I was accepted. I began teaching a first-grade class when I was a college freshman. I wanted to ensure that whatever I taught was of interest to my students and that no student would want to pretend to be sick as I had done as a student. This led to my first attempt at curriculum development. With the help of my sister, Amira Riad; my husband-to-be, Saffet Catovic; and our good friend Sofia Dasti, we developed the first Islamic studies curriculum at the ISCJ for first through the third grade.

Some of the most important moments of my life happened at ISCJ, alhamdullilah. During my teenage years, we established a youth group at the ISCJ. We ran programs for youth and adults. We did community service work, such as painting all the classrooms of the ISCJ (my sister and Sophia picked lime green for all the classrooms one year, and I remember one of the members of the ISCJ board having a difficult time finding the right words to thank us for our effort!). It was through this youth group that I met my husband-to-be, Saffet Catovic. Imam Chebli conducted both our engagement and marriage ceremonies in the multipurpose room of the ISCJ.

Through all this time, I was connected to the ISCJ Weekend School. I was a teacher, and I became part of the weekend school committee. It was after my first son, Ibraheem, was born and about ready for preschool that we came up with a new idea. My sister-in-law, Saffiya Turan, had her eldest son, Muhammed, in the public school for kindergarten, and she came to the decision to homeschool. During that summer, Saffiya ran a Muslim summer camp in her home and started thinking about establishing a full- time Islamic school. Having gone the route of public school and weekend school, my husband and I were in full support of the idea. With the help of my dad, Abdel-Rehim Riad, and Montasser Soliman, a group of us approached the ISCJ to start a full-time Islamic school.

There was resistance at first. What would happen if the school failed? How would this new school affect the ISCJ? It took some convincing, but in 1993, the Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI) opened its doors in the ISCJ. The school served students from pre-K 3 through first grade. There were twenty-seven students that first year. Because of school code regulations, the pre-K 3 classroom couldn't be in the ISCJ building; therefore, it was set up in Imam Chebli's house. Imam Chebli and his wife, Mona Chebli, were gracious enough to allow their house to be used as a school. The pre-K 4, kindergarten, and first-grade classes were in the ISCJ building. There were no modular units or school building at that time. The ISCJ building that housed the masjid was used during the weekdays by NUI School and, on the weekends, by the ISCJ Weekend School. Saffiya Turan was the first principal of the school, Mrs. Janet Nazif was the first certified teacher of NUI, and I was the teacher of the religious subjects (Arabic, Islamic studies, and Qur'an) for the kindergarten and first grade. I eventually gave up my engineering profession at IBM to become a full-time teacher at NUI School.

NUI did not fail the first year as many thought it would. In fact, it grew each year, adding a grade every year (one year two grades) to accommodate its students. The number of students went from twenty-seven to fifty in the second year to almost one hundred in the third year. The school was getting too large for the ISCJ building, so the first modular unit was purchased. It cost $60,000. Shortly thereafter, the second modular was purchased. NUI was bursting at the seams. As the time came to start the ninth grade, the decision to start or not to start a high school had to be made. Could NUI provide an education that would get its students into college? Dr. Omar Mansour (Rahmatullahi Alaih) was a big supporter of the NUI High School. He had enough faith to put his own son through the high school, and he believed others would follow. So NUI High School took flight.

The biggest addition to the school was the third modular. The third modular took some time to get operational. It sat in the ISCJ parking lot for a year. When the third modular was finally approved by the township for use, the students were so excited they actually carried their desks into the third modular themselves.

A lot has happened to NUI over the years. (NUI needs its own memoirs.) The first high school graduation took place in 2004. Four high school students graduated from NUI, and more than two hundred guests came to watch the graduation. It was a tear-filled graduation. Oh how far NUI had come! Alhamdullilah, NUI continues to grow and prosper within the ISCJ. NUI is twenty-four years old. It has graduated many high school students who have gone on to be successful in college and beyond and has become an important part of the ISCJ community. May Allah (SWT) continue to bless the ISCJ and its child, NUI!

Sr. Abir Catovic has served the ISCJ as a youth and an adult and is a pillar of the Noor-Ul-Iman School (NUI).

Xlibris



My Contributions To The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Syed M. Moinuddin

Bismillah Ar Rahman Ar Rahim.

Assalamu Alaikum!

My association with the ISCJ began in 1978 when we moved from New York to Central New Jersey.

We came to know of the ISCJ through different sources and wanted to get our daughter admitted to the Sunday school classes that were being conducted at the Rutgers University premises in New Brunswick at that time. Also, we were friends with Br. Shoukat Ali and, through him, came to know of more details about the ISCJ. We started visiting the ISCJ often to participate in its activities and attended Sunday seminars.

One day Br. Shoukat Ali called me and asked if I would be interested in masjid activities and would take the responsibility as the treasurer of the ISCJ. I declined the offer because of my prior commitments. Later on, I became an active member of the ISCJ and took part in various activities, especially in the fund-raising activities. I was asked and nominated by Dr. Mahmoud Taher, one of the founding members of the ISCJ, to seek election to the ISCJ Board of Trustees. I was elected for this post for one year (1990 to 19991). I got reelected for the periods from 1991 to 1994 and from 1997 to 2000.

I was the chairman of the fund-raising committee for approximately ten years and raised much of the needed funds for the ISCJ expansion and the expansion of the main masjid. At one time, when the land adjacent to the masjid was being purchased by a non-Muslim investor for commercial business, we raised over $450,000, the cost of the property, and acquired

the property. The ISCJ members and Muslim community came through during this period of dire need.

I was also elected to the first and founding board of directors of the Noor-Ul-Iman School, where I made constructive and lasting contributions. My wife, Dilnaz, was also an active participant in the ISCJ activities.

She and others started the tradition of serving food and *iftar* during the month of Ramadan at the ISCJ. They used to cook food at home and serve it at the masjid. Also, my three daughters attended the Sunday school at the ISCJ and graduated from it.

From the year 2000 onward, my activities with the ISCJ decreased because of my involvement with the founding of the Islamic Community of Old Bridge (ICOB) masjid on Route 35. Although we have moved to Texas, my love and affection for and relations with the ISCJ remain strong. I regularly receive the ISCJ's e-mails and contribute to its causes. I have very fond and sweet memories of my involvement with and contributions to ISCJ and cherish the relationships I made with its members.

May Allah (SWT) bless the ISCJ, and raise it to loftier heights, and make it an exemplary institution to benefit the Muslim *Ummah*.

Jazak Allah Khairun



My Journey To Islam And My Association With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Br. Alan Dexter Bowman, Esq. (Sharrief Muhammad)

I was born in Cincinnati, Ohio, in 1951. My father, Wilburn Bowman, was born in Macon, Georgia, in the mid-1920. My mother, Maud Freeman, was born in Athens, Alabama, in 1931. My mother's family migrated north to Ohio and Kentucky, and my father's family migrated to Detroit, Michigan, and Cincinnati, Ohio. The parents of both my parents were born in America. And the parents of their grandparents were also born here. It is easy to trace five to six generations of my American-born ancestors, and not all of them were black. My ancestors included Native Americans and Caucasians.

In 1951, as now, America was essentially segregated. I attended all-black elementary schools. In the seventh grade, I was admitted to a mixed-race college preparatory school for gifted children. It was at eleven years of age that I had my first experience of a mixed-race interaction. Prior to this, I was completely unaware of the cultural and ethnic difference between races. I had not really previously "met" a white person.

I graduated from high school in 1969 and attended Ohio State University. In 1970, I was exposed to the Nation of Islam. I sympathized with the group until 1978 when I was given a copy of the Holy Qur'an by a Pakistani doctor. I read it cover to cover five times and repudiated any other beliefs outside the Qur'an and Sunna. At that time, I became an Orthodox practicing Muslim. I graduated from Rutgers-Newark School of Law in 1976. I have been practicing law for forty years.

In 1992 or 1993, I became a member of the ISCJ. I enrolled my son in the Saturday school. I became very close to Imam Hamad Chebli and accompanied him to Hajj in 1997 and 1999.

From 2002 to 2007, I was chairman of the ISCJ Board of Trustees. I am most pleased by the human and civil rights seminar, which was conducted annually at the ISCJ for many years. A governor, supreme court justices and attorney general of New Jersey, assistant United States attorneys, lawyers, and other accomplished people attended and spoke at these seminars. They were all enlightened and inspired by the ISCJ environment.

Br. Alan Dexter Bowman (Sharrief Muhammad), an attorney, was the chairman of the ISCJ from 2002 to 2007.

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Summary Of Activities And Achievements At The ISCJ And NUI School (2001–2012)

Br. Aly A. Aziz

Below is a summary of my activities and accomplishments during my twelve years of services to the greater ISCJ community and the Noor-Ul-Iman School:

- From 2001 to 2006
  - During this period, I served as the chair of several key committees at the ISCJ:
    - Chair of the policies and procedures committee: Developed the ISCJ Policies and Procedures Manual that includes the basic governance to guide ISCJ operations and to provide external and internal auditors with the standards to use in reviewing the operations. In addition to the policies and procedures, the manual includes all of ISCJ governances: the constitution, the bylaws, the organization structure and responsibilities, the internal financial and administrative control, the board resolutions and minutes, the chart of accounts, forms used, job description, and so on. The manual has been reviewed in detailed with the ISCJ Board of Trustees before it was officially approved for implementation.

        - Chair of the expansion funding group: Started and chaired the first expansion funding group at the ISCJ during the period the plans were developed for the expansion of the ISCJ and construction a new school building for NUI and developed a long-term expansion plan to raise the funds for expansion. The plan included innovative fund-raising ideas and implementation plans with organizational responsibilities. The plan has been successfully implemented throughout the expansion stages 1 and 2 to provide the funds for the construction based on timely cash flow management.
        - Financial advisor to the building committee: Acted in this capacity to provide financial advice to the building committee during their master expansion plan development and approval by the South Brunswick Township.
        - Chair of the steering committee: This committee was responsible for coordinating the activities of the expansion plan performed by the building committee, the expansion funding committee, and the board of trustees.
    - During the same period (2001–2006), I served as a member of the board of directors and treasurer of NUI School and provided improved financial planning and reporting and cash flow management to avoid insolvency, introduced enhanced siblings and teachers tuition discounts, implemented new fund-raising ideas, and established an endowment fund for the school. I introduced the first Boy Scouts troop for the Noor-Ul-Iman School and acted as the scoutmaster.
- From 2006 to 2012
    - I served as president of the board of trustees during this critical period of expansion implementation, performed the responsibilities entrusted to the president, and introduced new implementation and organizational ideas by
        - implementing a new monthly cash flow management to control and coordinate cash collections and disbursements for the expansion;
        - introducing and establishing new committees for endowment funding, burial services, technology services, seniors group, and maintenance services;

- renegotiating major services contract between ISCJ and third parties to reduce operating cost;
- introducing and establishing a new endowment fund to provide long-term recurring revenue to sustain ISCJ's increased need for funds and raising the seed money for the fund and investing it in successful Islamic long-term investment;
- coordinating the activities and attending meetings of key committees: the religious committee, the expansion funding group, the social services committee, the technology group, the burial services committee, and the endowment fund group; and
- introducing enhanced procedural controls of some key activities, such as zakat disbursements controls.

Br. Aly A. Aziz is a former president of the ISCJ.

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My History With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey Since 1976

Br. Syed Wasti

My journey as an immigrant to the United States and with the ISCJ has, alhamdulillah, been a long, fruitful, and interesting one, filled with learning, blessings, family, friends, and faith.

When I first came to America in 1974, I struggled quite a bit and worked odd jobs to make ends meet. I landed my first professional career job in April 1977 as a statistician for the state of New Jersey, and I just recently retired after thirty-eight-plus years of service as a data processing analyst. I have also been working as a real estate agent in New Jersey since 1987.

Over the years, I have served the Islamic Society of Central Jersey community in many different official capacities, including the following:

- Fundraising committee member – for over ten years.
- Board of trustee member – 1989 and 1991.
- Treasurer – 1991.
- Membership committee – Since 1988, I have been maintaining the membership list for general body meetings and elections. I review the entire membership record in January of each year to determine the eligibility of members for voting in yearly elections, general body meetings, and special meetings.
- Publication committee – For over five years, I helped publish the self-funding annual *Green Pages* during Eid and did extensive work with ISCJ *Communicator* and the *Noor-Ul-Islam* magazine.

My association with ISCJ began in 1976, during the very early days when we operated out of Rutgers University. My late father and I were fortunate enough to be able to witness the land purchase for our current site in July of 1978. It was a monumental occasion and a wonderful honor to be a part of it as a recent immigrant. Another one of my proudest ISCJ memories was during the time I served as treasurer, and we completed the construction of phase 2 and paid off all our Qard-e-Hasna.

My family's relationship with ISCJ took root when my firstborn began attending the Sunday school in 1984. Since then, all four of my children graduated from the weekend school program. My children—Neelofur, Zainab, Jawwad, and Atif—then continued to serve there as teachers and youth group leaders for many years. Now three of my grandchildren attend the Noor-Ul-Iman School.

My wife, Shahnaz, and I always made our children's participation in the weekend school a priority over extracurricular and social events, and as a family, we remained active in the society in any way we could. I am proud to see that even after their education at the ISCJ was completed, my children continued to serve the Muslim community in various leadership roles in the Islamic centers of their universities as well as with MYNA (Muslim Youth of North America). Even now, they remain active through leadership roles and participation in NYU Islamic Center and alumni association and professional group as well as activities with Noor-Ul-Iman School.

The ISCJ provided an anchor for our community to gather in celebration, grief, study of faith, and community service, and it has played a major role in helping our children develop their identities as Muslims and first-generation Americans. It provided them with exposure to their Deen, chances to see it in practice, and opportunities to teach and help guide others. Most importantly, it has provided them with a culturally diverse faith-based community that they are involved in to this day.

I believe our early and consistent involvement with the masjid instilled in us a love of service that will continue through multiple generations. The ISCJ has been and will always be a part of our family's life for many years to come, inshallah.

Br. Syed Wasti is a former treasurer and a member of the board of trustees who has been a member of the ISCJ since 1976. Every January, Brother Wasti checks and certifies the eligibility of the ISCJ members to vote in ISCJ elections.



My Memories Of The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Naheed Rahmet, MD

My first visit to the ISCJ was in the winter of 1984. I attended a wedding ceremony that took place in the newly constructed multipurpose room. The community at that time was small, and it took great pride in the masjid. My husband, Mehmood, and I enrolled our daughters in the weekend school in 1992. Every Sunday, it took us an hour to drive to the ISCJ. (We later found a shorter way by following Sr. Heba Al Towhky.) Kids had to be in the classroom before 10:00 a.m. The doors would then close, and no one would be allowed to enter. Brother Fakhry was the principal, and Sr. Nadia Younes was the kindergarten teacher. The first poem they were taught was as follows:

We have five fingers in our hand.

They all stand up to say
A Muslim has to pray
Five times a day.

Fajr, Dhuhr, Asr, Maghrib, and Isha.

I thought it was so cute. The imam did the recitation of the Qur'an, and this was followed by the discussion of its meaning. Sr. Dr. Fatima Aziz was always at the forefront of this discussion. My father, Sahib Dad Khan,

was always seated in the front row and continued to be an active participant while most of us just listened.

To bring the parents together and to create a more sociable environment, a women's committee was formed under the leadership of Sr. Farida Ali.

Its purpose was to provide fun activities for the Sunday school children. We were involved in essay competitions, teachers' appreciation lunches in recognition of their hard work all year round, and commemoration of the Eids and the accompanying festivities. The name of the women's committee changed over the years to Sunday parents' association and then to the present-day parent-teacher association (PTA).

In 2000, I became involved with the weekend clinic, which operated under the leadership of Dr. Sogra Saleem. Around the same time, a group of well-meaning brothers and sisters formed the social activities committee. I continued to be an active participant in both.

In 2008, upon the recommendation of Sr. Atiya Aftab, I stood for the board election and was elected to the board of trustees, where I served for three years. It was a most humbling and rewarding experience. I would strongly recommend other members of our community to run for these positions and serve the community.

Our daughters, Unum and Amna, who would have rather spent their Sunday mornings at home if they had their choice, graduated from the weekend school and went on to become assistant teachers and then teachers in the Sunday school until they went off to college. One day when Unum came home from college, she sat next to me and said, "Mom, I am so glad you took us to the ISCJ. The lessons will last us a lifetime." Thank you to the teachers and staff of the weekend school for making a difference!



Our Contributions To The ISCJ And NUI School

Br. Behram Turan and Sr. Saffiya Turan

- Joined the ISCJ community in and around 1985 as we (Saffiya and I) were going to Rutgers Graduate School.
- Participated in ISCJ board meetings as representatives of Rutgers Muslim Students Association (MSA).
- Organized and helped set up Eid prayers in area parks.
- Was actively involved in the construction of the current ISCJ masjid in 1989 and 1990.
- Brought the mihrab tiles from Turkey and hired the laborer to install the tiles.
- In 1993, prepared site plans and designed the parking lot extension behind the masjid and adjacent to Route 1; testified before the South Brunswick Zoning Board as engineer on behalf of ISCJ.
- August 24, 1993: Became one of the three founding members of Noor-Ul-Iman School and president of NUI from 1993 through 2014; starting with twenty-seven students in pre-K and first grades, extended the services to the community through high school with over six hundred students.
- 1994 to present: Became a member of the ISCJ building committee.
- Provided design and engineering services for modular 1, modular 2, and modular 3 in 1995, 1997, and 2000, respectively, for the Noor-Ul-Iman School and the weekend school.
- Assisted with the weekend school growth as the student capacity increased with modular units and the permanent school building.

- Became one of the founding members of the ISCJ Expansion Steering Committee from its inception until 2014.
- Provided engineering support in selecting ISCJ engineers and architects and assistance with the township approval in developing the conceptual and final master plan from 2002 through 2008.
- Became one of the founding members of the ISCJ's Expansion Funding Group.
- In 2010, organized the groundbreaking ceremony for the implementation of the master plan improvements.
- Was an instrumental in getting the concept and approval for the ISCJ's access road to Route 522.
- Provided engineering support during the construction of site plan improvements and the school phase 1, completed in 2012, and phase 2, completed in 2014.

Grateful to Allah (SWT) for providing us the opportunity to serve the ISCJ community.

Sr. Saffiya Turan came up with the concept of the Noor-Ul-Iman School. Br. Behram Turan is one of the three founders of the Noor-Ul-Iman School. Sr. Saffiya Turan is the founding principal of the Noor-Ul-Iman School, and Br Behram Turan was the president of the Noor-Ul-Iman School for the first twenty-one years.



Our Historical Journey With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey

Sr. Sufia Azmat

My journey with the ISCJ began when my husband and I moved to New Jersey from Chicago, Illinois, in July of 1996. Because we had two small children, it was imperative that we find a location near an Islamic school. Our commute to an Islamic school in Illinois had been one hour each way, and we absolutely did not want to subject our children or ourselves to the same situation. We came to look for housing in May of 1996, and a friend who lived in the area told us of a school that had opened up three years ago. We drove down Route 1 and found ISCJ by locating the beautiful gold dome that stands out in the sky. Alhamdulillah, Allah blessed our intentions to educate our children in the best Islamic manner by guiding us to the ISCJ community.

The day we came to visit the school, it was lunchtime for Noor-Ul- Iman (NUI) students in the multipurpose room (MPR), and my first memory is of Ms. Shabana Quraishi welcoming us and asking us to have something to eat. Impressed by her hospitality, and the potential of the school administration, we chose to live in nearby Franklin Park. I offered to volunteer and to be a substitute teacher that first year and found myself being called in almost every day. I covered every single grade level and came to know every teacher and almost all the families through my affiliation with NUI. Although I had no intention at first of working in the education field, I was asked to be the second-grade teacher for the following school year. The rest, as they say, is history.

So my journey as an educator began. I obtained my New Jersey teacher certification and was asked to serve on the NUI School Board, now known as

the school executive council. I remember staying at school late into the evenings and into the night on some occasions. NUI was a small, close-knit family, and everyone helped with everything to make sure whatever job needed to be done was completed in a timely manner. I remember staying in the ISCJ building well into the night to work on report cards until Imam Chebli told us to go home. I remember working on the NUI yearbook until two o'clock in the morning so we could meet a printing deadline; our children were sleeping on the floor.

ISCJ was a very supportive community, and before long, we had two and then three modular units. The school grew exponentially. The administrative team worked together to bring the best of programs to NUI. Our success was a success not only for NUI or the Muslim community of ISCJ but also for the Islamic education community throughout the country as we shared what we were doing with other educators by attending the ISNA Education Forum. The entire staff contributed to the students' success in extracurricular activities. I served as a founding coach and advisor for the student council, the *Oculus* (school newspaper), and the mock trial team. The success of our mock trial team brought attention to NUI as our victory was published in the local newspaper as well as ISNA's *Horizons* magazine. The story of our girls' basketball team led by Mrs. Abir Catovic was highlighted in local newspapers as well and served as an inspiration to Muslim girls throughout the country. Local and state government officials came to speak highly of ISCJ and NUI as we set an example of good citizenship and civic engagement.

Allah (SWT) blessed us by providing the means for us to build a school building and achieve accreditation status. This was no small task, and it could not have been done without the support of the entire ISCJ community. Our graduates have gone on to achieve success in their personal and professional lives. Some have come back to teach or to enroll their children at the school from where they graduated. I myself, after serving as the middle school division head for over ten years and serving NUI for twenty years, have gone on to work with Islamic schools throughout the country to empower them to achieve excellence. I pray that our community prevails in overcoming the "mission drift" that often afflicts organizations as time passes. It is imperative that ISCJ and NUI remain focused on a shared community vision, work together to fulfill the societal obligations placed on us by Allah (SWT), and NUI truly becomes and remains a "guiding light for future generations."

Sr. Sufia Azmat was the head of the Noor-Ul-Iman Middle School Division for ten years. During her twenty years' tenure with the Noor-Ul-Iman School, Sister Sufia introduced several award-winning programs in Noor-Ul-Iman School. Currently, Sr. Sufia Azmat is the executive director of Council of Islamic Schools in North America.



My Blessed Journey With The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Azra Baig

For the last sixteen years, the Islamic Society of Central Jersey community has been an integral part of my life for which I am truly grateful. I have been blessed to have made many friendships through my numerous interactions with the members of the ISCJ community. I am very appreciative of the wonderful ISCJ community and the great experience I have had at ISCJ with so many activities, programs, and educational opportunities that are offered at the ISCJ.

Faith has been a major part of my life, so when my family and I moved here from Cleveland, Ohio, almost two decades ago, I wanted to continue to have a place where my family and I could worship, continue to learn, and educate my young daughters. My daughters attended the Saturday weekend school at ISCJ from kindergarten until the ninth grade, where they learned about Islam and the Qur'an and became a part of the ISCJ community.

During the time my daughters attended the weekend school, I participated in the weekend school PTO and helped with various school activities, such as Eid celebrations, family dinners, break time sales, and the end-of-the-year parties. I was also a part of the ISCJ Fund-raising Committee and the ISCJ Social Activities Committee. As a part of the fund-raising committee, I helped organize ISCJ fund-raising events and was in charge of the children's program. As a part of the ISCJ Social Activities Committee, a committee I continue to serve on, I have helped with the Ramadan *iftars*, Eid prayers, and annual picnics and was responsible for

introducing the Muslim Matrimonial Dinner program. As an actively engaged member in the ISCJ community, I was encouraged by many to serve on the ISCJ Board of Trustees. I was elected and served on the ISCJ Board of Overseer for a two-year period from 2012 to 2014. It was nice to be able to experience and be more knowledgeable of various issues facing the ISCJ and to have a greater appreciation of the wisdom and dedication it takes to make good decisions for the benefit of the entire ISCJ community. I have helped build bridges of understanding with the ISCJ community and the Greater South Brunswick community and beyond. Presently, I am serving on the South Brunswick Board of Education and other South Brunswick Township commissions. It is important for the members of the ISCJ to be active participants in their communities outside ISCJ as is beneficial to be involved and to give back to the community at large. Some of the activities or programs I have led or helped organize include interfaith events and programs to help bring a better understanding of the Islamic faith and Muslims. I have helped foster excellent relationship between ISCJ and the elected officials, such as Congresswoman Bonnie Watson Coleman, and state and local representatives, such as Assemblyman Andrew Zwicker and South Brunswick mayor Frank Gambatese and town council members. It is very important that ISCJ works with the interfaith community and other community leaders to help bring a broader and better understanding of one another and the importance of helping one another in time of need. Other activities I have led or introduced at ISCJ include voter registration drives, a South Brunswick food pantry drive, Muslims against Hunger-Hunger Van Program, ISCJ Big Chill 5K Team, and an ISCJ table at the annual South Brunswick National Night Out. It is through these varied activities and interactions that ISCJ is well known in South Brunswick, throughout the state of New Jersey, and even nationally. Elected officials look to our community for leadership and support.

Throughout these years, I have also contributed countless images for ISCJ's social media from the various events at the ISCJ and ISCJ-related pictures to help capture the myriad of activities ISCJ community members participate in. I have also provided news and images related to the ISCJ community to the local media. Furthermore, many news organizations, such as the *Washington Post*, FOX News Channel, ABC, NJTV, FIOS, Patch, TAP Into, and Sentinel have all come to ISCJ to cover events since ISCJ is a highly regarded and well-known Islamic community nationwide. The ISCJ is a well-known, large, diverse, well-respected, and resourceful community. Because of this, many Muslim scholars and leaders have come to ISCJ or ISCJ events to share their knowledge and insight. The ISCJ community has been very fortunate and has welcomed world-renowned

individuals, such as Hamza Yusuf, Zaid Shakir, Dalia Mogahed, Nouman Ali Khan, Linda Sarsour, Suhaib Webb, Tarek El-Messidi, Dalia Fahmy, Suzy Ismail, Sohaib Sultan, Khalid Latif, and many others. I have enjoyed listening to them and learning from their words of wisdom and know how blessed I am and the ISCJ community is to be able to experience programs with all these amazing scholars.

My journey with the ISCJ has truly been a blessing. I am grateful for the wonderful people and the many services, activities, programs, and educational opportunities it offers. God willing, I plan to be part of the ISCJ community for a long time and hope to continue to contribute to the success of this organization.

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The Responsibilities Of The ISCJ's Administrator

Br. Yehia Abou-Bakr, PhD

It may be rather difficult to imagine how enjoyable it was to have the chance to be a civil servant at a highly spiritual institution like the ISCJ. For me, the combination was a blessing for which I am deeply grateful to Allah (SWT).

What the ISCJ was looking for was a candidate who could perform the managerial duties serving the fast-growing Islamic community of central New Jersey. The masjid was at the core of all the surrounding activities, both religious and cultural. This was the mission of the ISCJ.

When Dr. Morad Abou-Sabe, the president of the ISCJ at that time, appointed me for the job, it was the first time that the ISCJ was hiring a full-time administrator. My homework involved a thorough, both vertical and horizontal, study of the ISCJ structure as an Islamic organization spiritually, socially, and culturally functioning in an American environment.

My employer, the ISCJ, was responsible for having the place ready for worshippers all year round, along with providing other spiritual- and material-related needs. This required a high degree of coordination at all levels. This coordination was, in fact, made possible through the cooperation among all volunteers, paid officers of the institution, and elected officials. Therefore, I had to establish direct contact with the president and the chairman of the board of trustees, the secretary, and the treasurer. At the same time, the religious needs of the community were looked after by the imam and other religious leaders of the ISCJ.

Another responsibility of the administrator included managing correspondence and financial transactions approved by the president and

the treasurer. Another equally important responsibility was to establish a working relationship with the South Brunswick Township. Education, starting from the weekend school to the full-time Noor-Ul-Iman School, sharing the same premise and facilities, had to be carefully coordinated with the weekend seminars, operation of the library, and free medical clinic offered by the ISCJ in the same building. Safety and security were also among the administrator's top concerns and responsibilities.

One more thing that, along with other ISCJ cultural activities, made my work all day in this highly inspiring house of worship so inspiring was the participation in organizing the Islamic art exhibition. Artifacts representing various parts of the world were on display, creating an atmosphere of shared values. The masterpiece in the Islamic art exhibition was a collection of paintings by the late Ahmad Raif, which brought to the society a glimpse of Islamic life and thought with the spiritual and cultural elements at the root of all the ISCJ activities.

Dr. Yehia Abou-Bakr was an administrator of the ISCJ.

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My Personal Association with the Islamic Sociey of Central Jersey

Br. Arif Patel

My history with the ISCJ is shorter compared with others. During my association with the ISCJ, I have been able to grow through my experiences with all the mentors, coaches, advisors, and friends I have made.

To be able to witness four generations of a family walking in through our ISCJ doors is something that not many places can brag about. The true diversity of Islam and Muslims is what attracted my family to move here. The ISCJ is not a Pakistani, Egyptian, Indian, or Arab masjid; it is a melting pot of Muslims from every corner of the world. I still vividly recall my first time stepping inside the ISCJ and when I saw Imam Chebli. It is not something I can describe in words, but it was a feeling that I knew this was the place where our family would settle.

I am so proud of our accomplishments. I have seen the opening of our new school, the launching of our Qur'an Academy, and so many other things. It is simply a testament to the blessing ALLAH ALMIGHTY has bestowed upon us.

Br. Arif Patel was elected an overseer in 2009, chief overseer in 2010, Secretary in 2013 and President of the ISCJ Board of Trustees in 2014 through 2016.

My Mission with the Senior Sisters' Jamaat at the ISCJ

Sr. Akhter Rahman

My association with ISCJ started in August 2005 when we moved from New York to New Jersey. We went for our first Jumu'ah prayer at the ISCJ, and as we left the mosque, we noticed a car coming along with us. It turned in at Princeton Highlands. After we reached home, it turned out that they were our neighbors. The next day, my husband, Inayet-ur-Rahman, and I went to meet them, and there commenced a lifelong friendship with Rana Khan and Mansoor Alam Khan. Rana Khan asked me to join the senior sisters' Jamaat, then headed by Sr. Sabiha Malik.

I met so many friends from India, Pakistan, Egypt, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka and African Americans representing our Ummah. The mosque is a place where we all come together and enrich our lives. Our Jamaat meetings were a wonderful experience for me. I have spoken on a few subjects and demonstrated vegetable decorations, cutting onion flowers, making frames with pressed flowers, breathing exercises, and Yoga, which reduces pain.

In December 2014, Sr. Sabiha Malik, trusting me, handed over the Jamaat leadership to me. She went through a series of surgeries, but she was very much with me and guided me. The first meeting I conducted was on January 11, 2015. I invited a convert to speak on *da'wah* as I felt that they looked forward to being included in our community. We had collected towels, sweaters, comforters, clothes, and things of everyday use for the four Muslim sisters who lived with her in the shelter. I always concluded my meetings with "the thought of the day." It was "Himmat - e - niswan

madad e - Khuda," which means "The courage of women invites Allah's help." We made it our slogan for the empowerment of women.

I am thankful to Princeton HealthCare System for arranging lectures at my request. We had Lauren Nolan on July 26, 2015, speaking about health promotion and fitness management, and Alexis Rice on November 1, 2015, speaking about exercise science and kinesiology, the kinetic science of human movement. They showed us knee exercises, which most of us needed to do. I invited Dr. Farah Said, clinical audiologist, on November 1, 2015, and Dr. Samia Hossain of RWJ Hospital on August 7, 2016.

I have arranged meetings once in two months and invited speakers to present seminars on religious topics, such as Dr. Heba Elkhateeb, who is a professor of English at Rutgers University and also teaches New Eastern studies at Princeton University; Ustada Rahela Ansar of Zainab Center; Ustada Najiha Hashmi; and Ustada Azra Pervez.

We have two picnics a year at Beachwood Park and at Rose Garden. I have arranged two sessions of computer training, one with Br. Danish Syed and one with Br. Asad Mazharullah. They are both IT professionals. We oldies were so enthusiastic about learning.

Juanell Boyd of Nassau Presbyterian Church was so impressed by our Imam Chebli's speech that she asked ISCJ for some members for an interfaith organization she wanted to start. ISCJ president Arif Patel e-mailed me to contact her. I was the first one to call her, and then she reached out to others. Now we have Jews, Christians, Hindus, and Muslims in the interfaith group. Rana Khan, Shafia Jalil, and I are in the steering committee of the "Central New Jersey Interfaith Stitchers for Peace."

Our first meeting was held in the church on May 1, 2016. Juanell asked me to initiate the opening meditation. After that, I read out three prayers of Muslims, Hindus, and Christians, which amazingly meant almost the same. We were asked to make items for a Syrian refugee family. We did that, thinking it was a Christian family. It turned out to be a Muslim family. The church had arranged for them a house and maintenance with the help of the government. So our friendship was cemented with love and goodwill. I distributed my article "Children of Adam and Eve."

Rana Khan, Shafia Jalil, and me will be hosting a meeting at our beloved mosque. New members will join us, and we will be teaching knitting, crocheting, sewing, and so on and making items to send them to the refugees and the needy. May Allah accept our contribution and efforts to build bridges across different communities because now more than any other time, it is needed badly. We are made by one God and have a common descent, and he made us different. A bouquet looks beautiful with

flowers of different colors and fragrances, and so are we. Let us celebrate this unity.

We are like the wonderful colors of a rainbow, different, but blend and spin it and it becomes the pure white divine light, diversity unified. This is the time to reach out to each other and make our earth a more beautiful place to live in. This will be my endeavor as always been, inshallah.

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The ISCJ Weekend Seminars

Br. Fakhruddin Ahmed, D. Phil

The ISCJ Seminar Committee has a storied past. The earliest seminar speakers and attendees were the founding members themselves and their families. The founding members drove their children to the Sunday Islamic school at Rutgers University's New Brunswick campus on Sunday mornings. As their children were learning the basics of Islam and the Qur'an, their parents would be attending the Sunday seminar. The school and the seminar would end at the same time, and the parents would return home with their children.

Founding member Dr. Suhail Rifai was not only the first chairman of the seminar committee, but he was also the first seminar speaker. Dr. Rifai would devote the first part of the seminar to interpreting various Suras from the Qur'an. In the second part, he would address nonreligious yet pressing issues. Unless someone else volunteered, Dr. Suhail Rifai would conduct the seminars in the earliest days.

The original seminar speakers were the founding members, such as Dr. Suhail Rifai, Dr. Mahmoud Taher, Br. Shoukat Ali, Br. Abdel-Rehim Riad, and Br. Abad Ahmad. Later on, especially after the Sunday school mutated into the weekend school beginning in 1983, outside speakers were also invited to present seminars.

Religious, social, economic, medical, scientific, and political topics were addressed by seminar speakers. Every year the seminar committee hosts a Hajj seminar. Some memorable seminars include discussion of the Patriot Act and Black History Month with a civil rights and human rights symposium (organized by Br. Alan Bowman every February) with attorney and judges as speakers. Famous professors explained the big bang theory, physicians gave demonstration of CPR, and scholars instructed on

the language of the Qur'an. Many weekend school students also presented seminars. The board of trustees and some committees (such as the building committee and the expansion funding group) updated members of their activities through the seminars.

Br. Hussein Hanafi was the longest-serving chairman of the ISCJ Seminar Committee. Others who served as the chairman of the seminar committee include Br. Mahmood Ghori, Br. Riaz Siddiqui, and Dr. Fakhruddin Ahmed. When the Saturday school opened in the 1990s, so did Saturday seminars. Br. Omar Mansour was the host of the Saturday seminars from the beginning until he passed away in 2002. Br. Mubasher Dar has been in charge of the Saturday seminars ever since.

The early founders were dedicated members of the ISCJ. They stayed at the weekend school as long as their children attended classes. Over the years, interest in the Saturday and Sunday seminars has plummeted. Many members prefer to gather information about Islam from the Internet and do not spend as much time in the masjid. Besides, the ISCJ offers competing programs at the time slots previously reserved for weekend seminars, siphoning off potential seminar attendees.

Founding member Sogra Saleem, MD has also contributed to this report.

Social Role And Academic Contributions Of The Women At The ISCJ During The Early Days (1975–1981)

Sr. Farida Ali

Women have played a significant role in the educational, social, and cultural development of the children of ISCJ, thereby ensuring a bright future of the ISCJ right from the beginning of its foundation.

In September 1975, the Sunday school of the ISCJ came into existence with Dr. Mahmoud Taher as its first principal. The Muslim parents living around the Rutgers University campus in New Brunswick, through the Muslim Students Association (MSA) of Rutgers, persuaded the Rutgers University authorities to make available to them the use of some classrooms at Scott Hall to start a Sunday school for the Islamic education of their children.

Three lady teachers taught at the Sunday school from the beginning: Sr. Sharon Taha, Sr. Afaf Fayoumy, and Sr. Farida Shoukat Ali. They taught at the Islamic school, along with some male teachers. Sister Sharon taught the stories of the prophets to the lower grades, Sister Afaf taught Qur'anic Arabic, and Sister Farida taught Islamic studies to the upper grades. Sister Farida also carried a portable library for the students of the upper grades to prepare research papers that were presented to the class.

The class instructions were followed by discussions. Topics such as "Was Islam Spread by the Sword?" "Polygamy in Islam," and "Marriage in Islam" were covered. As the student enrollment increased, two more

sisters, Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady and Sr. Razia Mazher Hassan, volunteered and became teachers.

In 1978, Sr. Sharon Taha left the school. The same year, a school committee was formed, and Sr. Farida Ali was nominated as the chairperson and Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady the vice chairperson.

The curriculum of the school was designed, books were selected, and the committee came up with the school policies, such as attendance policy and the students' evaluation policies and procedures.

Apart from teaching, the teachers were actively involved in various functions of the ISCJ with their students, functions such as Eid celebrations, the Prophet's birthday celebrations, and the end-of-the-school-year celebrations.

The annual Islamic school graduation was always followed by a cultural program and a picnic. For these occasions, the teachers prepared their students to sing religious songs, deliver religious speeches, and perform religious plays.

Sr. Sharon Taha used to prepare her little ones to sing the song "I Am a Muslim." Sister Afaf used to teach Arabic religious songs from back home by using tapes. She also prepared her students to recite the Hadith of the prophet. Her students also delivered religious speeches.

Sister Farida was instrumental in teaching Arabic and Urdu religious songs to her students. She conducted plays that were written, directed, and produced by her. One of her plays that gained a lot of popularity was "The Barber of Baghdad." The play took us back to Khalifa Haroon ul Rasheed in the eighth century, the golden age of Islam. Dr. Mahmoud Taher once asked her, "Are you an Iraqi?" because most of her plays had to do with Baghdad, which she had learned in her school in India.

Although they were not teachers at the school, Sr. Tanveer Abad Ahmed, Sr. Anthia Dasti, Sr. Heera Ghouse Ismail, and Sr. Zaiba Huq were very helpful to the teachers in organizing social and cultural activities of the Islamic school. Sr. Zaiba Huq wrote and directed a play named "Unity Is Strength," which was performed in 1981 after the annual graduation.

Every year after the graduation, the students would sing religious songs and perform cultural programs to entertain and educate their parents about Islamic culture and history. Some of the stories of the Arabian nights were performed as plays. Sr. Farida Ali, with the help of other teachers and parents, used to conduct sports at the Colonial Park for the students after the school graduation.

Several photographs pertaining to the cultural programs and sports in the early years of the ISCJ have been provided for the publication in the forty years of ISCJ history project. It was a wonderful teamwork in which

the students, parents, and teachers of the ISCJ worked together for a greater cause, the cause of serving Allah (SWT) and his Deen. Alhamdulillah.

Sr. Farida Shoukat Ali is a founding member of the ISCJ and a founding member of the ISCJ Weekend School.

Xlibris

Women: An Integral Part Of The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Sogra Saleem, MD

At the annual general body meeting on April 15, 2012, members of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey (ISCJ) elected new trustees and overseers. Two weeks later, on April 30, 2012, the new board of trustees met and elected the executive committee to run the ISCJ. For the first time in the thirty-seven-year history of ISCJ, a female, Sr. Atiya Aftab, was elected ISCJ's chairperson. Sr. Atiya Aftab is not only the first woman to hold this leadership position, but she is also the first second-generation Muslim American to lead a burgeoning organization like the ISCJ as its chairperson.

Sister Atiya is one of the early graduates of ISCJ weekend school who chose to be involved with ISCJ activities from a very young age. An attorney by profession, Sister Atiya has served over fifteen years as a trustee and as an overseer and has volunteered her time and talent generously to several ISCJ committees. She has served as the secretary of ISCJ board for several years with distinction and has led the ISCJ as its acting president and chairperson in the absence of the president and chairperson. Sister Atiya is renowned for her work ethic and meticulous attention to details. Sister Atiya is an inspiration to young Muslim Americans.

Beginning in the late 1970s and 1980s, there have been other women who have served ISCJ board selflessly and with distinction. Sr. Azra Shahidi followed by Sr. Raafat Ahmad and Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady served

the ISCJ as trustees and Sr. Aziza Badr as an overseer. These women have retired from the ISCJ community.

In the 1990s, Sr. Sogra Saleem and Sr. Nadia Younes served as trustees. Other women, such as Sr. Fatima Aziz, Sr. Afaf Fayoumy, Sr. Reem Fakhry, Sr. Uzma Mehmood, Sr. Sadia Ansari, Sr. Azra Ahmed, and Sr. Durriya Asghar, worked as overseers and Sr. Naheed Rehmat as a trustee. Many of these sisters are still active in different ISCJ committees and some have served the board in the recent past.

Following Sister Atiya's lead, several other second-generation sisters are serving the ISCJ in several important capacities. Sr. Dalya Youssef has served the ISCJ as an overseer in the past and is currently a trustee. Sr. Rabia Saeed has just finished her term as an overseer and is replaced by Sr. Azra Baig. Sr. Omayma Mansour served as a trustee and Sr. Mona Abdala as an overseer in the past. Sister Mona is currently a full-time teacher and Sr. Omayma a part-time teacher at the Noor-Ul-Iman School.

Besides those names, there are several other women who have served the committees tirelessly and continue to do so. ISCJ acknowledges and appreciates their contributions to its success. Most of these women are wives and working mothers; there are a few who are young and pursuing higher education. The professions of women who serve the ISCJ include physicians, lawyers, educators, social workers, accountants, nutritionists, office workers, and nurses.

Twenty women have served the ISCJ either as trustee or overseer in ISCJ's thirty-seven-year history.

Currently, the overwhelming majority of the teachers at ISCJ Weekend School and full-time Noor-Ul-Iman School are women. It is very gratifying to see that women take a great pride in choosing teaching as their vocation. Other than teachers, there are only a few women who join the ISCJ committees. ISCJ has twenty-one committees, and I am confident that women can find the committee that is commensurate with their talent and become part of that committee. By volunteering, a sister not only helps ISCJ but also enriches her own life. Please volunteer and serve Islam and be rewarded by Allah (SWT). You may inspire and be a role model to your own children and those of your friends.

I encourage all the sisters of ISCJ, young and not so young, to get involved. It is my earnest hope that more sisters follow in the footsteps of their predecessors, seek elective office, join committees, and take the ISCJ to new heights.

May Allah (SWT) bless and guide the ISCJ community.

Summer 2012

Addendum: In April 2014, there was another milestone in the history of women at the ISCJ. Two women, Sr. Tabassum Khan and Sr. Heba Macksoud, were elected to the position of trustees. That made a total of three women serving as trustees in a given year. Not only that, Sr. Tabassum Khan, CPA will be the first woman to serve as the treasurer of the ISCJ.

Sr. Rabia Ahmed, after serving one year, resigned from her position as an overseer.

Dr. Sogra Saleem is a founding member of the ISCJ, a current member of the board of overseers, past member of Noor-Ul-Iman Board of Directors, and past member of the ISCJ Board of Trustees.

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My Services For The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey (ISCJ)

Sr. Hebatalla Elkhateeb, PhD

Dr. Hebatalla Elkhateeb's contribution to the Islamic Society of Central Jersey is that of public service. Dr. Elkhateeb is an Egyptian American who began her educational and professional career in Virginia and Washington, DC in 1987. She has a doctorate of education in the pedagogy of teaching and learning language arts. As an expert of Arabic language and a professor of Arabic and English who served at Princeton University, Rutgers University, and Vanderbilt University, she considers herself first and foremost a servant of God.

Since she joined Princeton University at 2005, Dr. Elkhateeb has been facilitating numerous interfaith meetings, conferences, and lectures at the ISCJ. She also engages in interfaith scripture study sessions that aim to move different communities of faith from blind tolerance to enlightened mutual understanding and acceptance.

Dr. Elkhateeb started "The Language of the Quran Lecture Series" at the Center for Muslim Life at Princeton University and continues to offer these lectures at the ISCJ Sunday seminars and her weekly class as well as at Princeton University.

To facilitate learning about Islam at the clergy leadership level, since February of 2014, Dr. Elkhateeb agreed to participate in continuous text study sessions with Rabbi Adam Feldman of The Jewish Center in Princeton and Rev. David A. Davis, pastor of Nassau Presbyterian Church. They agreed to alternatively study at the mosque, the synagogue, and the church. They initially used "scriptural reasoning," a curriculum developed by Peter W. Ochs, a professor of Judaic studies at the University

of Virginia, and then continued independently on their own. These study sessions of the three scriptures were facilitated by Adam M. Pechter, CEO of Pechter Polls, Princeton, New Jersey.

Their continuous scriptural study of the Torah, Gospel, and the Qur'an facilitated a robust engagement in public dialogue among Rabbi Adam Feldman, the Rev. David A. Davis, and Imam Hamad Ahmad Chebli of the Islamic Society of Central Jersey. The three clerics agreed to engage in public dialogue about their traditions at, respectively, the mosque, the synagogue, and the church on January 26–28, 2016.

Since 2014, at the ISCJ, Dr. Heba Elkhateeb has been continuously teaching a weekly course on the basic principles of Islam to reverts who newly embraced Islam and Muslims as well as non-Muslims who are interested to learn about Islam. She engages her students with the holistic meanings of the Arabic/Semitic spiritual concepts of the Qur'an and the Last Testament and how the Qur'an affirms and restores previous revelations—the New Testament and the Old Testament. One of her interfaith lectures at the ISCJ was captured by the *Home News Tribune* newspaper.

Dr. Elkhateeb facilitates a monthly Islamic forum as a community reach out, where members of different communities of faith are welcomed to learn about how Islam connects with everyone as a religion that works with human nature.

Dr. Elkhateeb has been a member of the zakat committee and the Qur'an Academy committee. She was also one of the founders of the ISCJ Qur'an Academy, directed by the renowned Qur'an reciters, Sheikh Ismael, Esq. Quran Academy successfully attracts young students and adults from different cities around the ISCJ community as they learn and memorize the Qur'an on daily basis.

Narrative About Br. Iqbal Shariff And Sr. Farida Shariff

Br. Dawud Assad

Br. Iqbal Shariff; his wife, Farida Shariff; and their two sons came to the United States from England in 1984. They heard about the ISCJ through a realtor who gave them the telephone number of the ISCJ and got in touch with Dr. Mahmoud Taher (Rahim ahu Allah), who told them that the ISCJ was open on Fridays for a couple of hours for Jumu'ah prayer and on Sundays for the weekend school.

A year or so later in 1986, Imam Chebli came to the ISCJ, and the Shariff family became friends with the imam's and Dr. Taher's families.

Brother Iqbal stated that he brought books that were donated by Dr. Taher and Br. Dawud Assad to the library with the help of Imam Chebli and started to open the library during the Sunday seminar break and after Zuhr prayer. He then joined forces with Br. Zaheer Nazif, who had accumulated numerous audio tapes of the sheikh who was reciting at the Taraweeh prayers then. Br. Jamal Badawy donated the video library of his lectures. Brother Shariff relinquished his responsibilities as the librarian in the mid-1990s.

Sr. Farida Shariff was a registered nurse and a midwife in England. She lived in an apartment near the ISCJ, and she was glad that the ISCJ became a new family for her.

Because of the dire need for Islamic funeral services in the community, Sister Farida volunteered to perform *ghusl* (bathing) services for the women who passed away, along with Aunt Zahiyya Radwan, the mother-in-law of Br. Dawud Assad.

Sr. Farida Shariff met a young Palestinian student, Mustafa Owaiss, who was filling their car with gas, and asked him to come to the ISCJ and teach the Qur'an He graciously accepted. Sister Farida volunteered to teach the Qur'an on Saturday mornings, and Brother Mustafa taught the Islamic class. Sister Farida feels grateful when she goes to the ISCJ for various events and meets many of her old students, who still remember her with passion and give her a big hug. She feels gratified that her students still come to the masjid and support the ISCJ community.

The author, Br. Dawud Assad, is one of pioneers/founding members of the ISCJ and served the ISCJ in various capacities, such as the chairman of the board of trustees, religious and zakat committees, and so on for over 40-plus years to date.

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The Islamic Society Of Central Jersey – Its Influence On Me

Sr. Rana Khan

I moved to the United States from Switzerland as a young bride in 1976 and was engrossed with adjustments in this new country, adapting to American life at a time when there was very little Eastern influence in America.

We lived in different cities in New Jersey, and with the birth of our children, we went looking for mosques or centers where they could receive a religious education. We visited many institutions and makeshift centers, including a two-room store in Lakewood, New Jersey, and then a rented office space that was used as a mosque for prayers and for religious education on weekends. I was involved in teaching there and attended prayers and lectures. The big purdah partition between men and women, which was a requisite, was always something that I could not accept but could see no way around.

The first time I was influenced by the ISCJ was when my mother died in December of 1997. The circumstances of her unforeseen death were devastating, and my first encounter with death and all that it entailed and the reality of the fact of mortality struck and shocked me. Br. Imam Chebli gave my aunt and two sisters and me an expeditious lesson about giving *ghusl* to a dead body in the funeral home in Princeton.

Then he conducted the last rites and prayers at the ISCJ. I can remember the coffin in the front of the mosque and the Namaze Janaza. It was such a peaceful feeling knowing that we all belong together and that we would all pass this route to Allah's house.

My memories of that day will always remain with me, the consciousness of being in a place that is truly what Islam is all about, equality for everyone

as it should be and has always been since Prophet Muhammad's (peace be upon him) time. There were no curtains or partitions separating men and women in the ISCJ; women could speak out their minds if they felt like it with no hindrance.

After that experience, when it was time to make a move, we were influenced by the proximity of the mosque to settle nearby in the Princeton area ten years later.

Since then, I feel very comfortable attending events and prayers at the ISCJ. The best time is during Ramadan, when the mosque is transformed. The atmosphere is so serene and at the same time festive, that one can only leave reluctantly at night with the promise of coming back the next day.

I have been volunteering at the senior sisters' Jamaat and have recently joined a group called Interfaith Stitchers for Peace, who, apart from meeting women in our mosque or at a church or a synagogue, knit for charity while praying for hope, healing, and peace throughout the world.

Alibris



A Tribute To Br. Sayed Hassan, The ISCJ's Administrator

Sr. Heba Hassan Macksoud

My father, Sayed Mahmoud Mostafa Hassan, has always been an exemplary role model. From as far back as I can remember, my family was always at a masjid. I have photos of myself as a baby being held by him as he sat and listened to some of the greatest imams and sheikhs who visited U.S. masjids, including Imam Khalid Al Husary and Sheikh Mohamed Jibreel.

In 1980, my father volunteered to be a weekend school teacher, and my mom assisted him. He taught all three subjects—Arabic, Seerah, and Islamic studies. Some of his students included Omayma Mansour (now a member of the ISCJ Board of Trustees). He taught for several years and then proceeded to volunteer for various activities. During this time, I was a teenager, and I witnessed his actions that heavily influenced me during those formative years. I saw him diligently attend every prayer (that he was available for) at the masjid and witnessed him always offering to help. He led the prayers at times, helped organize events, and donated funds as the masjid expanded. He was never interested in elective office and refused leadership positions; he just simply wanted to learn, worship, and be part of our *Ummah* at the masjid.

As a teenager, I really did not want to go the masjid every weekend, but he was adamant about all of us attending as a family. That diligence, that love and persistence of regularly going to the masjid made a significant impact on me. After I got married, I wound up buying a home within walking distance of the masjid, and my father also moved close to the ISCJ. A few years later, in 2002, as he was considering retiring from working in New York City, he was offered the opportunity to work as a

part-time administrator for ISCJ. He was so excited about being able to serve Allah by serving the community. I was surprised that he wanted to take on such a difficult job. Although he was only being offered minimal pay for twenty hours, it became obvious that time did not matter to him. He would attend Fajr prayer and then stay in his office working until past Zuhr every day and then go back after Isha prayer to finish up the paperwork. It was well known that if you had trouble at an event during the weekend, call "Brother Sayed" on his cell phone and he will be there in minutes to help. Eventually, he inspired me to also volunteer at the ISCJ, and after almost ten years of being on various committees, I was elected to the board of trustees in 2014, and am now in my second term. Observing my father give almost sixteen years of his dedication not only makes me so grateful to have such an amazing role model but also proud that I am able to experience spending time with him along with the rest of my "family," the ISCJ community.

My father is a giving tree; he blooms quietly and gives selflessly without any noise, without any trace of superficiality or expectation. He is a sincere person, a person of *iman* and *khair*, a person who will always be remembered in the future. Although my name means "gift," it was he who gave me the best gift, the gift of being an amazing parent, which, in turn, inspired me to try my hardest to become one as well.

May Allah bless our parents!

ISCJ Formation Timeline

Br. Dawud Assad

1) In 1973, ISCJ was established after an existence of two organizations in New Jersey (before ISCJ), one called ISLAMIC SERVICE ORGANIZATION (ISO) incorporated in New Jersey in 1968 headed by Br. Dawud Assad as president, Dr. Suhail Rifai as a secretary, and three other members, two from North Bergen and one from Brooklyn. This organization served the need of many Islamic centers and masjid in New York and New Jersey and contributed money to ISCJ as stated in Dr. Taher's fact sheet (see newspaper image below).

   The second was a student organization at Rutgers University called the ISLAMIC SOCIETY AND FRIENDS (ISF).

2) On May 27, 1975, ISCJ was incorporated as a nonprofit organization, tax-exempt, religious organization.
3) In 1977, a happy and blessed merger took place between the two Islamic communities of Greater New Brunswick and Princeton/ Trenton areas under the ISCJ.
4) On April 24, 1979, 6.4 acres of land in South Brunswick, on Stouts Lane and US Route 1 South, were purchased for $70,000 from Omar Boraie.
5) In 1982, the first phase of construction to house the school, multipurpose room, and offices started and completed on October 9, 1983.
6) On June 25, 1986, Imam Hamad Chebli was brought to serve as an imam at ISCJ and still there.
7) In 1988, the second phase of construction started and ended on December 1990.

8) In the fall of 1993, Nur-Ul-Iman full-time school opened.
9) In 1978–1979, the first official elections of ISCJ took place, elected Dr. Suhail Rifai as the first president and Br. Dawud Assad as the first chairman of the board.
10) More land was purchased later to make the total area of 16.5 acres at present (2017).

Xlibris





1. Top Photo: Br. Mohammad ElSaady and Br, Mamdouh Fahmy of the ISCJ Bottom Photo: Sitting Down from Right: Ghazi Kankan, Imam Ali Rashid, Dawud Assad, Imam Warithuddin Muhammad, and Imam of one of the masjids of Warithuddin Muhammad



2. From Left: Dr. Ma'Rouf Dawalibi (Past President of Syria). Pressman Br. Hafiz, Shaikh Hussainy from Jerusalem, Imam Baba Khanouf, Mufti of Kazakhstan, Dawud Assad (2005)



3. Dr. Ahmad Sakr (California)



4. From left: Dawud Assad, Dr. Moizul Matin, and Dr. Ahmad of Sudan in Turkey 2001



5. From left: Dr. Babar, Dawud Assad, and Delegates from Canada. Toronto, Canada 2008



6. Muslim Day Parade -New York City 2007



7. From left: Dawud Assad, Dr. Muhammad Abdel Rauf, Shaikh Al-Azhar, Assistant of Shaikh Azhar, Shaikh Hussary (Renowned Qari' of Quran)



8. Dawud Assad (left) with Senator Fulbright (right) in Washington, D.C.



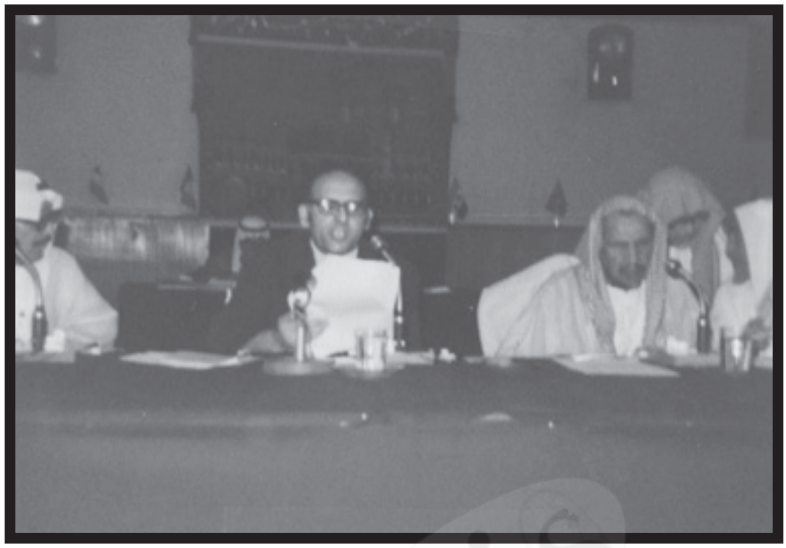
9. From left: Saffet Catovic (Pasha from England), Dr. Bashir Zikria (Afghanistan), Two Peace Ambassadors (Washington, D.C.)



10. Standing from left: Imam Hamad Chebli, Dawud Assad, D. Michael Jenkins, Br. Muhammad Ashraf. Sitting in center: Shaikh Safwat Amini, Rabitas General Secretary Assistant.



11. Jamboree Scouting 1994
From left: Chuck Alawan (Scout Master), Dawud Assad, and Son of Othman Ahmad



12. From right: Shaikh Abdel Aziz Bin Bazz (Mufti Saudi Arabia), Dawud Assad giving a speech about "Islam in America" 2006.



13. From right: Muzammil Siddiqi, Shaikh Muhammad Al- Harakan (Secretary General of Rabita in Makkah, Saudia Arabia) New York City 2008.



14. From right: Dr. Omar Nasseef (Secretary General of Muslim World League), Next: Dr. Fahd Nassar (Director of Rabita Office in N.Y.C), Standing: Dawud Assad



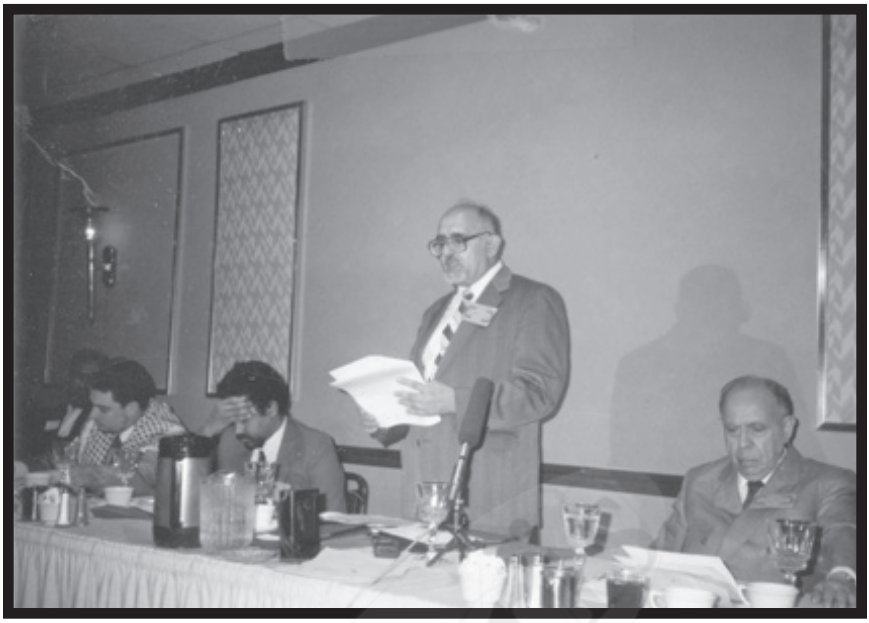
15. From left: Al-Marrek (Saudi Embassy in Washington), Center: Mr. Nuwaiser (Ambassador of Saudi Arabia), Right: Dawud Assad in the Saudi Embassy in Washington, D.C. 2009



16. Fourth from right: Rev. In Jin Moon of South Korea, 5th of left: Dr. Jenkins, Fourth from left: Dawud Assad on Capitol Hill, Washington, D.C. 2009



17. From left: Dawud Assad shaking hands with Congresswoman Sheila Jackson Lee of Houston, Texas



18. On right: Dr. Isa Nakhla, Standing: Dawud



19. 3RD from left: Congressman Andre Carson. On his right: Dr. Jenkins. On his Left: In Jin Moon from South Korea. First from right: Dawud Assad.



20. Center: Mufti of Jerusalem, Shaikh Muhammad Hussain. On right: Dawud Assad, Delegation of Peace Committee from different countries in visiting Jerusalem.



21. From right: Dr. Shawkat Futaki of Japan, Dawud Assad



22. From left: Dawud Assad, President Dentkash, Turkish Cyprus



23. From left: Shaikh Tusuf Qabbani of Bahrain, Shaikh Makhloof (Past muftiof Egpyt), Dawud Assad



24. Delegates from Indonesia, Azerbaijan, and Turkey, Standing: Dawud Assad Paterson, NJ 2012



25. First row: 3rd. from left: Syed Saeed ISNA Interfaith Director), 4th from left: Faisal Ra'ouf, 3rd. from left: Dawud Assad, The rest: Leaders of Jewish, Christian, and Muslims gathered in Washington, D.C. for peace (2012)



26. Abdel Rehim Riad



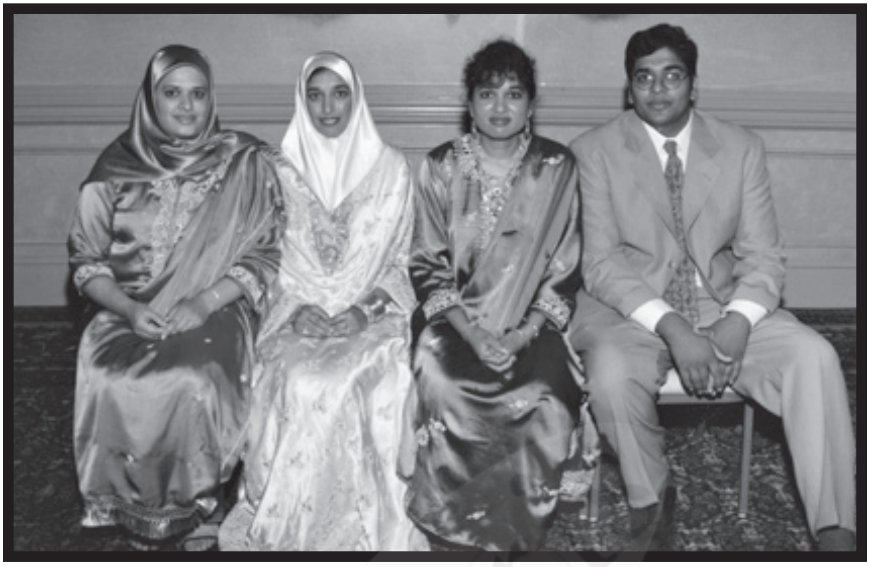
27. Dr. Riaz Iqbal



28. Dr. Riaz Iqbal



29. Invitation for Grand Opening Phase II



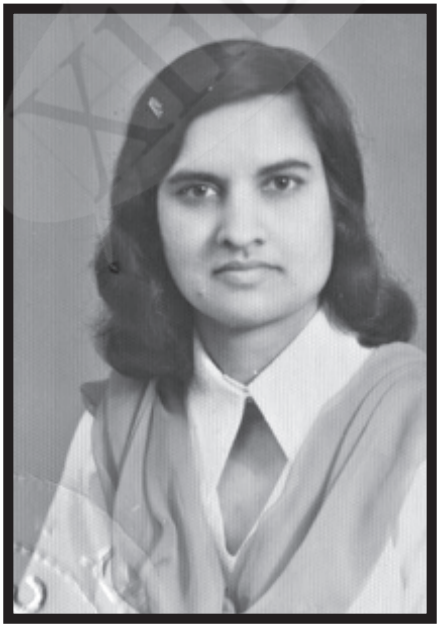
30.Hafiz and Sabiha Malik's four children. From left to right: Farah, Nahar, Naeema, and Asaad Malik



31.Family Photo of Sabiha Malik with son-in-law



32. Sabiha Malik



33. Dr. Riffat Sajjad



34. On left: Dr. Naheed Rahmet



Center: Dr. Naheed Rahmet



36. On right: Dr. Naheed Rahmet and family



37. Dr. Naheed Rahmet (center) and family



38. Dr. Rahmet family and ISCJ children



39. Dr. Naheed Rahmet family



40. Left: Imtiaz, Right: Dr. Naheed Rahmet



41. From left: Dr. Naheed Rahmet, Amna Rahmet, and Mehmood Rahmet



42. From left: Mehmood Rahmet and Amna Rahmet



43. From right: Mehmood Rahmet and friend



44. Dr. Naheed Rahmet family

THE CAST OF THE PLAY: THE BARBER OF BAGDAD

A PLAY EDITED AND DIRECTED BY SR. FARIDA ALI IN 1978

BARBER OF BAGDAD: SR. SABA ALI
HAROONUL RASHID: BR. ANWER AFTAB
THE WOOD CUTTER: SR. SOFIA DASTI
THE PONY: BR. BASIT ALI
OIL MERCHANT: SR. ATIYA AFTAB
OWNER OF THE HORSE: SR. SARA DASTI
THE STORY TELLER: SR. SAHAR FAKHRI
OTHERS WITH MINOR ROLES



Cast of the play Barber of Baghdad



a. Cast of the play Barber of Baghdad



b. Cast of play Barber of Baghdad



c. Cast of play Barber of Baghdad



49. Imam Chebli during Sunday School seminar at ISCJ (2004)



50. ISCJ Sunday School Principal's Recognition. Sr. Nazia Zamir (Principal) held by Parents' Association (2004)



51 ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Principal's Recognition held by Parents' Association. Members of Parents' Association



52. ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Principal's Recognition Day. Sitting on right: Imam Ahmad Chebli. Standing from left: Sr. Nazia Zamir (Principal) and Sr. Farida Ali speaking on behalf of Parent's Association



53 ISCJ Library (2000). Left to right: Sr. Farida Ali, Dr. Saleha Quraishi, and Sogra Saleem MD



54. ISCJ members with a visitor from India, Yusuf Quraishi (2000)



55. ISCJ Sunday School Teacher's Appreciation (2004) Parents and teachers listening to Imam Chebli.



56. ISCJ Library (2000). Right to left: Br. Shoukat Ali, Sr. Farida, Dr. Sogra Saleem and Br. Yusuf Quraishi



57. Dr. Suhail Rifai with chief guest (1977)



58. Prophet's (PBUH) Birthday Celebration (1977). Br. Dawud Assad speaking.



59. ISCJ Sunday School Graduation (1980)



60. ISCJ Sunday School Graduation (1980). Students singing, "I am a Muslim".



61. ISCJ Sunday School Graduation (1980). Br. Sobhi Khalil with his class, performing religious presentation.



62. ISCJ Fund Raising (1978). North Brunswick High School. Br. Mustafa reciting the Quran



63. ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Sr. Nazia Zamir on left with teachers



64. ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Sr. Nazia Zamir on left with teachers.



65. ISCJ Teacher's Appreciation (2002)



66. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Sr. Attiyaat ElSaady with her family. Eid festival held by Parent's Association.



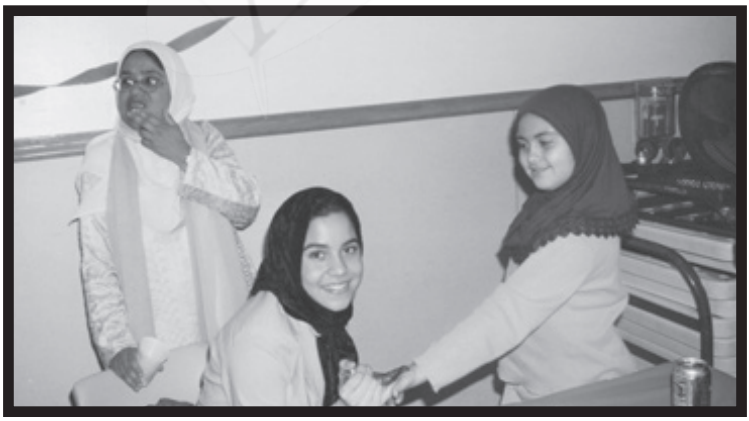
67. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Eid festival held by Parent's Association.



68. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Picture taking. Eid festival held by Parents' Association.



69. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Everybody enjoyed the cotton candy. Eid festival held by Parent's Association



70. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Applying Henna. Eid festival held by Parent's Association



71. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Prize Booth. Eid festival held by Parent's Association



72. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Eid festival held by Parent's Association



73. ISCJ Sunday School Eid festival (2002-2003). Held by Parents' Association



74. ISCJ Fund raising dinner. Members' recognition. Br. Mohammad Siddiqui speaking.



75. ISCJ Sunday School (2001). Members of Women's Committee



76. ISCJ Sunday School (2002-2003). Sr. Sanna Quasmieh with cotton candy on left, Br. Mehmood with cotton candy machine. Eid festival held by Parents' Association



77. ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Principal's Recognition held by Parents' Association. Sr. Nazia Zamir with teachers



78. ISCJ Sunday School (2004). Principal's Recognition. Sr. Nazia Zamir (left), Br. Naji (right)



79. ISCJ Fund Raising Dinner. Sr. Janet, the Principal of Noor-ul-Iman School



80. ISCJ (2002). Imam Chebli making dua at the end of the graduation



81. ISCJ (2002) Weekend School graduation audience



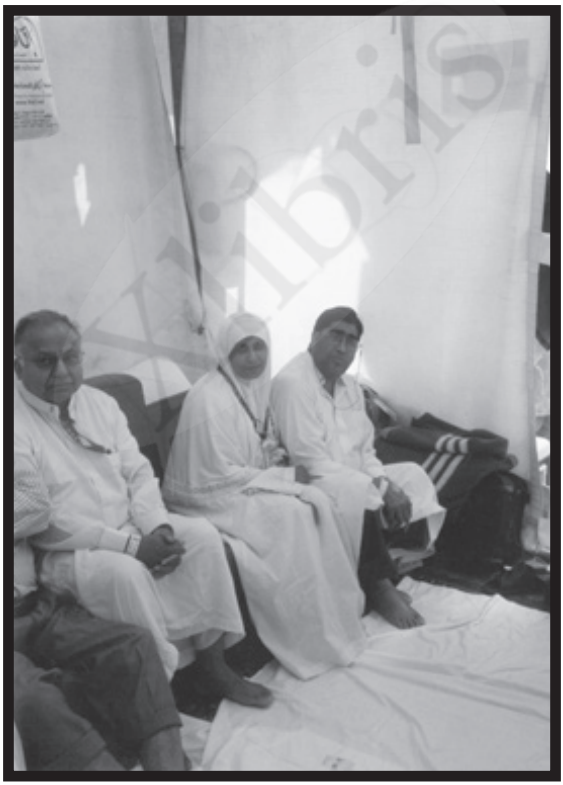
82. ISCJ Sunday School's Teachers' Appreciation Day (2001) held by Women's' Committee



83. ISCJ Sunday School (2001). Teachers' Appreciation Day. Elementary class teachers with their students, held by Women's Committee



84. ISCJ seminar (2001)



85. ISCJ Hajj Group accompanied by Imam Chebli (2005). Left to right: Br. Shoukat Ali, Sr. Shammi and Dr. Riaz Iqbal



86. ISCJ Sunday School Graduation (1980). Sr. Afaf Fayoumy with her students



87. (1979) ISCJ Sunday School Graduation. Sr. Mona's kindergarten students reciting religious na'ats



88. ISCJ Sunday School Parent's Association (2002-2003). Eid festival



89. ISCJ Sunday School. A teacher with her student. Left to right: Sr. Nadia Yunus and Sanna Quasmieh



90. ISCJ Sunday School (2001). Teachers' Appreciation Day. Parents and teachers gathering held by Women's Committee



91. ISCJ Sunday School (2001). Recognition award winners for helping the Sunday School and the Women's Committee



92. ISCJ Sunday School. Recognition award winners for helping the Women's Committee and Sunday School



93. ISCJ Sunday School (2001) Door prizes for Principal's Recognition Day held Women's Committee



94. ISCJ (2001) The Sunday School Assistant Teachers (Women's Committee)



95. ISCJ (2001). The Sunday School Teachers (Women's Committee)



96. ISCJ Sunday School (2001) School Service Awards (Women's Committee)



97. ISCJ Sunday School (2001) Teachers and Assistant Teachers Perfect Attendance (Women's Committee)



98. Women's Committee (2001) Essay Writing Competition 3rd. Place Award Winner



99. Women's Committee (2001) Essay Writing Competition 2ND Place Award Winners



100. Women's Committee Essay Writing Competition 1st Place Award Winner



101. ISCJ Sunday School Parents (2000). Principal's Recognition. Sr. Amber Iqbal (Principal) and parents of Sunday School students.



102. ISCJ Sunday School (2000). Principal's Recognition. From left: Imam Chebli, Sr. Farida Ali (Women's Committee), Sr. Amber Iqbal (Principal),



103. ISCJ Sunday School (2000). Sr. Amber Iqbal (Principal). Principal's Recognition held by Women's Committee



104. ISCJ Sunday School (2000). Principal's Recognition. Sr. Amber Iqbal (Principal), Sr. Farida Ali (Women's Committee)



105. Br. Abdel Rehim Raid (Riyadh, 2002)



106. ISCJ Fundraising Dinner (2002). Members' recognition for their Contribution and service over the years



107. ISCJ Fundraising Dinner (2002). Members' recognition for their services over the years. Br. Magdy Hagag speaking.



108. ISCJ Fundraising (2002). Member's recognition for their contributions and services over the years.



109. ISCJ Fundraising (2002). Members' Recognition for their contributions and services over the years



110. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day



111. ISCJ (1980) Sunday School Sports Day



112a. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day



112b. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



112c. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



113. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day



114. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



115. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



116. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



117. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



118. ISCJ (1980). Sunday School Sports Day.



119. ISCJ (1979). Sunday School Graduation and play written by Sr. Zaiba Huq and performed by students. Name of the play: "Unity is Strength".



120. ISCJ (1979). Sunday School Graduation. Dr. Taher (school principal)



121. ISCJ (1979) Sunday School Graduation celebration. Br. ElSaady with students



122. ISCJ (1979). Sunday School Graduation. Dr. Taher with students



123. Celebration of Prophet's (PBUH) Birthday (1976). Sr. Farida Ali and Sr. Sharon Taha on the right with their students



124. ISCJ (1978). Sunday School Graduation. At Rutgers University-students singing religious songs



125. ISCJ (1978) Sunday School Graduation Speech by Aiman Rifai



126. Br. Muhammad and Sr. Attiyaat Elsaady with Mahmoud Taher. Alexandria, Egypt (2007)



127. ISCJ (1978) Sunday School Graduation at Rutgers University. Students reciting religious na'at



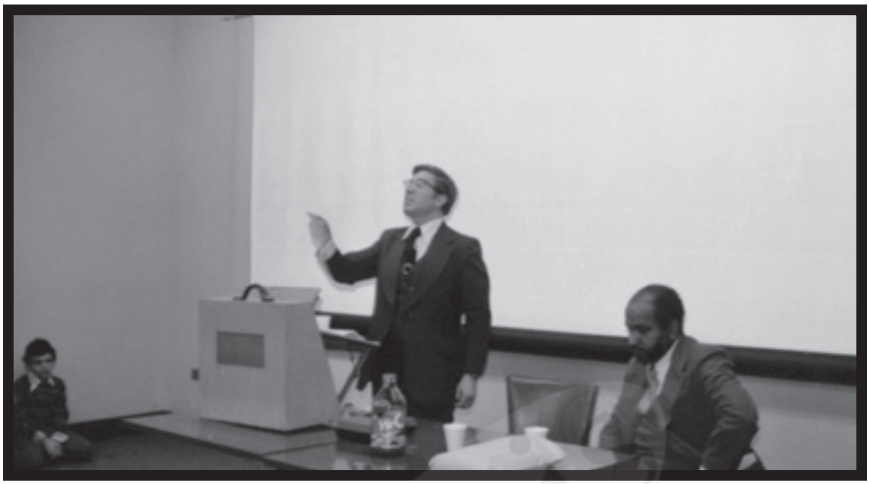
128. ISCJ Sunday School Graduation (1978). Standing on right: Sr. Farida and her students singing religious na'at



129. (1978) ISCJ. Standing from left to right: Architect, Dr. Taher, Br. Dawud Assad



130. (1980) ISCJ Sunday School Graduation. Dr. Mohd. Ali Chaudry, Chairman School Committee



131. (1978) ISCJ Prophet's (PBUH) Birthday Celebration. Dr. Suhail Rifai speaking.



132. (1978) ISCJ. Br. Mustafa reciting Quran. Standing: Dr. Suhail Rifai, and the chief guest.



133. (1977) ISCJ Eid-ul-Adha celebration with ISCJ students



134. (1977) Eid-ul-Fitr celebration at Rutgers, organized by Sr. Farida Ali. Sr. Sharon Taha singing religious songs along with other ladies



135. (1977) ISCJ Sunday School Graduation held at Rutgers. Sr. Ifaf (at podium), Dr. Taher (standing on the right).



136. (1977) ISCJ Sunday School Graduation held at Rutgers. Br. Fahkri Seymah speaking as President of Muslim Students' Association of Rutgers



137. (1977) Sunday School Graduation at Tilak Hall Rutgers University. Dr. Taher (Principal), Sr. Sharon Taha (teacher of kindergarten and first grade)



138. (1977) Occasion of Prophet's (PBUH) birthday. Singing the song, "I am a Muslim".



139. Muslim Students' Association (1977). Br. Fahkri Saymeh speaking



140. 1977, a gathering of parents and the children of weekend school at the celebration of the birthday of Prophet Muhammed (SAW)



141. Dr. Muhammad Lhan, President of the Islamic Congress Dr. Issa Nakhla Esq, President of the Higher Commission of Palestine Dawud Assad as a conference held in Newark, NJ



142. Dawud Assad, third from the right wearing white cap- photo taken in Jerusalem Palestine

ISLAMIC ART BY FARAZ KHAN











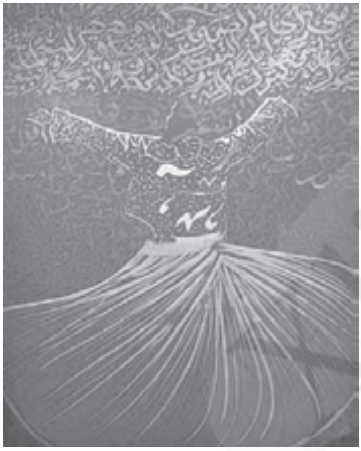








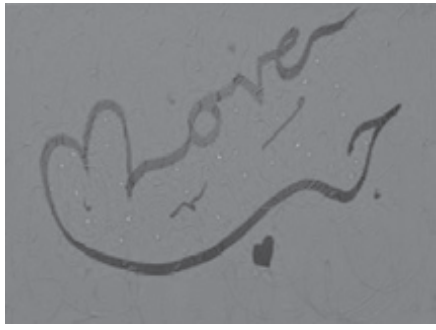

HOPE






Love
حب


Love
حب


Love
حب


PEACE
سلام
LOVE

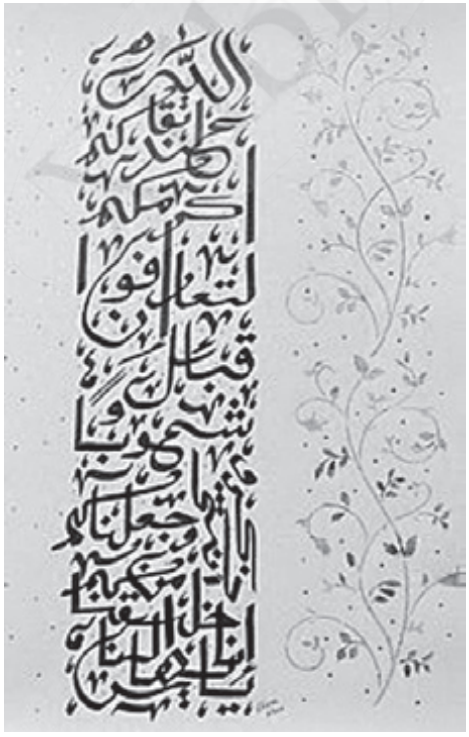






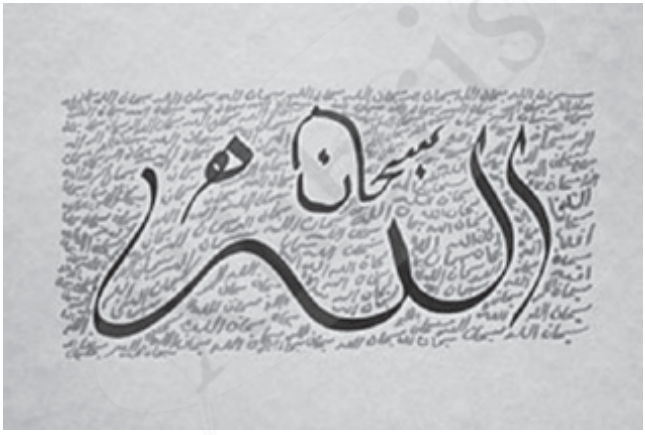







PRAISE
GOD

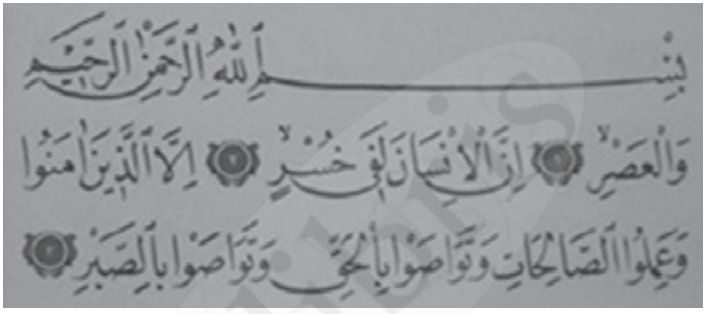

THANK YOU











In the Name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful By (the Token of) Time (through the ages)
Verily Man is in loss,
Except such as have Faith, and do righteous deeds, and (join together) in the mutual teaching of Truth, and of Patience and Constancy.

Xlibris